



BIG TEN

GAME GRADER

2025 SEASON			LAST 3 YEARS (2023-2025)			LAST 5 YEARS (2021-2025)			LAST 10 YEARS (2016-2025)		
P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE
1	INDIANA	91.8	1	OHIO STATE	84.6	2	OHIO STATE	84.4	2	OHIO STATE	84.1
2	OHIO STATE	86.8	2	OREGON	82.4	4	OREGON	73.8	7	MICHIGAN	67.6
5	OREGON	81.5	8	PENN STATE	69.9	6	MICHIGAN	71.3	8	PENN STATE	67.5
12	USC	67.5	10	MICHIGAN	65.5	9	PENN STATE	68.5	10	WASHINGTON	64.5
15	WASHINGTON	64.4	13	INDIANA	64.1	15	USC	60.4	11	OREGON	64.4
16	IOWA	64.0	18	USC	62.2	19	WASHINGTON	58.9	14	USC	60.9
26	MICHIGAN	58.7	19	WASHINGTON	62.2	26	IOWA	54.3	16	WISCONSIN	59.1
27	PENN STATE	58.3	29	IOWA	55.1	29	ILLINOIS	52.5	19	IOWA	57.9
28	ILLINOIS	57.7	33	ILLINOIS	50.5	31	MINNESOTA	51.5	31	MINNESOTA	51.2
42	NORTHWESTERN	47.6	39	NEBRASKA	48.1	33	UCLA	51.1	43	UCLA	47.8
45	NEBRASKA	45.9	44	MINNESOTA	45.4	37	WISCONSIN	49.2	44	INDIANA	47.7
54	RUTGERS	41.5	46	UCLA	45.0	43	INDIANA	47.7	49	NEBRASKA	44.8
55	MINNESOTA	40.3	52	RUTGERS	44.1	48	NEBRASKA	45.8	50	MICHIGAN STATE	44.0
56	MARYLAND	38.9	55	MARYLAND	43.5	52	MARYLAND	45.0	53	NORTHWESTERN	42.8
57	MICHIGAN STATE	38.3	58	WISCONSIN	42.5	61	MICHIGAN STATE	39.9	60	MARYLAND	40.3
60	WISCONSIN	34.2	60	NORTHWESTERN	40.9	62	PURDUE	38.1	61	PURDUE	40.2
62	UCLA	31.5	66	MICHIGAN STATE	33.7	63	RUTGERS	37.5	62	ILLINOIS	39.9
67	PURDUE	27.3	67	PURDUE	27.1	66	NORTHWESTERN	34.6	68	RUTGERS	30.0

OFFENSE

2025 SEASON			LAST 3 YEARS (2023-2025)			LAST 5 YEARS (2021-2025)			LAST 10 YEARS (2016-2025)		
P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE
3	USC	1.7	1	OREGON	1.6	1	OHIO STATE	1.7	1	OHIO STATE	1.5
5	OREGON	1.6	2	USC	1.5	2	OREGON	1.3	7	USC	0.9
6	INDIANA	1.4	5	OHIO STATE	1.2	3	USC	1.3	9	OREGON	0.9
13	OHIO STATE	1.0	9	WASHINGTON	0.9	11	MICHIGAN	0.8	12	PENN STATE	0.6
17	MICHIGAN	0.8	16	INDIANA	0.7	17	WASHINGTON	0.6	13	MICHIGAN	0.6
19	WASHINGTON	0.7	18	PENN STATE	0.6	21	PENN STATE	0.5	19	WASHINGTON	0.5
29	RUTGERS	0.5	23	MICHIGAN	0.5	29	UCLA	0.3	31	MARYLAND	0.2
31	PENN STATE	0.3	27	ILLINOIS	0.4	32	MARYLAND	0.3	32	WISCONSIN	0.2
38	ILLINOIS	0.1	37	MARYLAND	0.1	37	PURDUE	0.2	33	NEBRASKA	0.2
44	NEBRASKA	0.1	43	RUTGERS	0.1	40	NEBRASKA	0.1	35	UCLA	0.2
48	PURDUE	0.0	46	PURDUE	0.0	43	ILLINOIS	0.1	41	PURDUE	0.1
52	MICHIGAN STATE	-0.1	51	UCLA	-0.1	48	INDIANA	0.0	50	INDIANA	0.0
54	UCLA	-0.2	53	NEBRASKA	-0.1	53	MICHIGAN STATE	0.0	53	MINNESOTA	-0.1
55	MARYLAND	-0.2	61	WISCONSIN	-0.3	54	WISCONSIN	0.0	54	ILLINOIS	-0.1
57	NORTHWESTERN	-0.3	64	MICHIGAN STATE	-0.4	59	MINNESOTA	-0.2	58	MICHIGAN STATE	-0.1
58	IOWA	-0.3	65	MINNESOTA	-0.4	64	RUTGERS	-0.4	63	IOWA	-0.3
63	WISCONSIN	-0.6	66	IOWA	-0.5	65	NORTHWESTERN	-0.6	67	NORTHWESTERN	-0.6
67	MINNESOTA	-0.8	67	NORTHWESTERN	-0.5	67	IOWA	-0.6	68	RUTGERS	-0.8

DEFENSE

2025 SEASON			LAST 3 YEARS (2023-2025)			LAST 5 YEARS (2021-2025)			LAST 10 YEARS (2016-2025)		
P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE	P4 RANK / 68	TEAM	GRADE
2	OHIO STATE	1.7	1	OHIO STATE	1.6	2	OHIO STATE	1.1	4	OHIO STATE	0.9
5	OREGON	1.4	5	PENN STATE	1.0	4	IOWA	1.1	5	IOWA	0.9
7	IOWA	1.1	7	OREGON	1.0	5	PENN STATE	1.0	7	MICHIGAN	0.9
15	INDIANA	0.9	8	MICHIGAN	1.0	7	MICHIGAN	0.9	8	PENN STATE	0.9
16	WASHINGTON	0.9	9	IOWA	1.0	11	OREGON	0.7	10	WASHINGTON	0.7
18	MICHIGAN	0.8	20	WASHINGTON	0.6	14	WISCONSIN	0.7	13	WISCONSIN	0.7
25	ILLINOIS	0.5	26	UCLA	0.5	19	WASHINGTON	0.5	20	OREGON	0.5
26	WISCONSIN	0.5	28	INDIANA	0.5	27	UCLA	0.4	32	MICHIGAN STATE	0.3
31	PENN STATE	0.4	33	NEBRASKA	0.4	31	ILLINOIS	0.4	33	INDIANA	0.3
35	USC	0.3	34	WISCONSIN	0.4	34	INDIANA	0.3	34	UCLA	0.2
41	NEBRASKA	0.1	44	ILLINOIS	0.2	38	MINNESOTA	0.3	37	NORTHWESTERN	0.2
42	UCLA	0.1	46	MINNESOTA	0.1	39	NEBRASKA	0.3	40	MINNESOTA	0.1
43	NORTHWESTERN	0.0	49	MARYLAND	0.1	47	MARYLAND	0.1	41	USC	0.1
45	MINNESOTA	0.0	50	NORTHWESTERN	0.0	55	MICHIGAN STATE	-0.1	43	NEBRASKA	0.1
53	MARYLAND	-0.1	51	USC	0.0	56	NORTHWESTERN	-0.1	55	MARYLAND	-0.1
58	MICHIGAN STATE	-0.2	57	MICHIGAN STATE	-0.1	61	USC	-0.2	59	ILLINOIS	-0.2
65	PURDUE	-0.7	67	PURDUE	-0.7	66	RUTGERS	-0.5	66	PURDUE	-0.4
68	RUTGERS	-2.0	68	RUTGERS	-0.8	67	PURDUE	-0.5	67	RUTGERS	-0.4

ALL-TRANSFER TEAM

QB	ROCCO BECHT	Iowa State	→	PENN STATE	DL	JOHN HENRY DALEY	Utah	→	MICHIGAN
QB	JOSH HOOVER	TCU	→	INDIANA	DL	CHIDDI OBIAZOR	Kansas State	→	INDIANA
RB	CARSON HANSEN	Iowa State	→	PENN STATE	DL	SAHIR WEST	James Madison	→	UCLA
WR	NICK MARSH	Michigan State	→	INDIANA	DL	JAMES SMITH	Alabama	→	OHIO STATE
WR	TERRELL ANDERSON	NC State	→	USC	DL	QUA RUSSAW	Alabama	→	OHIO STATE
WR	CHASE SOWELL	Iowa State	→	PENN STATE	DL	TOBI OSUNSANMI	Kansas State	→	INDIANA
TE	BENJAMIN BRAHMER	Iowa State	→	PENN STATE	LB	CALEB BACON	Iowa State	→	PENN STATE
OL	TREVOR BUHR	Iowa State	→	PENN STATE	DB	MARCUS NEAL	Iowa State	→	PENN STATE
OL	BRENDAN BLACK	Iowa State	→	NEBRASKA	DB	JONTEZ WILLIAMS	Iowa State	→	USC
OL	TREE BABALADE	South Carolina	→	NEBRASKA	DB	KOI PERICH	Minnesota	→	OREGON
OL	RILEY ROBELL	James Madison	→	UCLA	DB	SMITH SNOWDEN	Utah	→	MICHIGAN
OL	JOE BRUNNER	Wisconsin	→	INDIANA	DB	EARL LITTLE	Florida State	→	OHIO STATE



BIG TEN

1 OREGON



2 OHIO ST.



3 INDIANA



4 USC



5 MICHIGAN



6(TIE) WASHINGTON



6(TIE) PENN ST.



8 IOWA



9 WISCONSIN



10(TIE) NEBRASKA



10(TIE) ILLINOIS



12 MINNESOTA



13 UCLA



14 N'WESTERN



15 MARYLAND



16 MICH. ST.



17 RUTGERS



18 PURDUE



ALL-BIG TEN: OFFENSE

1st TEAM		2nd TEAM		3rd TEAM	
QB	DANTE MOORE	OREGON	QB	JULIAN SAYIN	OHIO STATE
RB	JORDAN MARSHALL	MICHIGAN	RB	BO JACKSON	OHIO STATE
RB	ANTWAN RAYMOND	RUTGERS	RB	JORDON DAVISON	OREGON
WR	JEREMIAH SMITH	OHIO STATE	WR	KJ DUFF	RUTGERS
WR	EVAN STEWART	OREGON	WR	DAKORIE MOORE	OREGON
WR	CHARLIE BECKER	INDIANA	WR	NICK MARSH	INDIANA
TE	BENJAMIN BRAHMER	PENN STATE	TE	JAMARI JOHNSON	OREGON
OL	CARTER SMITH	INDIANA	OL	DAVE IULI	OREGON
OL	KADE PIEPER	IOWA	OL	JOHN MILLS	WASHINGTON
OL	TREVOR LAUCK	IOWA	OL	GREG JOHNSON	MINNESOTA
OL	IAPANI LALOULU	OREGON	OL	CARSON HINZMAN	OHIO STATE
OL	AUSTIN SIEREVELD	OHIO STATE	OL	LUKE MONTGOMERY	OHIO STATE
QB	DEMOND WILLIAMS	WASHINGTON	QB	DARIUS TAYLOR	MINNESOTA
RB	DARIUS TAYLOR	MINNESOTA	RB	CARSON HANSEN	PENN STATE
WR	CHRIS HENRY	OHIO STATE	WR	NYZIAH HUNTER	NEBRASKA
WR	DEZMEN ROEBUCK	WASHINGTON	WR	DJ VONNAHME	IOWA
TE	DJ VONNAHME	IOWA	TE	ANTHONY DONKOH	PENN STATE
OL	ANTHONY DONKOH	PENN STATE	OL	KWABENA ASAMOAH	RUTGERS
OL	KWABENA ASAMOAH	RUTGERS	OL	JAKE GUARNERA	MICHIGAN
OL	JAKE GUARNERA	MICHIGAN	OL	ALANI NOA	USC
OL	ALANI NOA	USC	OL	CONNER MOORE	MICHIGAN ST

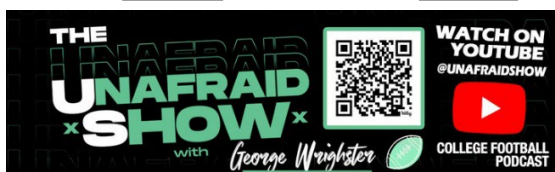
ALL-BIG TEN: DEFENSE

1st TEAM		2nd TEAM		3rd TEAM	
DL	TYRIQUE TUCKER	INDIANA	DL	MARIO LANDINO	INDIANA
DL	A'MAURI WASHINGTON	OREGON	DL	CHIDDI OBIAZOR	INDIANA
DL	JOHN HENRY DALEY	MICHIGAN	DL	BEAR ALEXANDER	OREGON
DL	ANTHONY SMITH	MINNESOTA	DL	MATAYO UIAGALELEI	OREGON
LB	ROLIJAH HARDY	INDIANA	LB	ISAIAH JONES	INDIANA
LB	MASON POSA	WISCONSIN	LB	MAVERICK BARANOWSKI	MINNESOTA
LB	JORDAN HALL	MICHIGAN ST	DB	ZACH LUTMER	IOWA
DB	BRANDON FINNEY	OREGON	DB	JONTEZ WILLIAMS	USC
DB	KOI PERICH	OREGON	DB	DEVIN SANCHEZ	OHIO STATE
DB	AMARE FERRELL	INDIANA	DB	JERMAINE MATHEWS	OHIO STATE
DB	JYAIR HILL	MICHIGAN	DB	EARL LITTLE	OHIO STATE
DL	TEITUM TUIOTI	OREGON	DL	SAHIR WEST	UCLA
DL	SAHIR WEST	UCLA	DL	KENYATTA JACKSON	OHIO STATE
DL	KENYATTA JACKSON	OHIO STATE	DL	JAHKEEM STEWART	USC
DL	JAHKEEM STEWART	USC	DL	JACOB MANU	WASHINGTON
DL	JACOB MANU	WASHINGTON	DL	MATTHEW BAILEY	ILLINOIS
DL	MATTHEW BAILEY	ILLINOIS	DL	MARCUS NEAL	PENN STATE
DL	MARCUS NEAL	PENN STATE	DL	ROBERT FITZGERALD	N'WESTERN
DL	ROBERT FITZGERALD	N'WESTERN	DL	ALEX McLAUGHLIN	WASHINGTON
DL	ALEX McLAUGHLIN	WASHINGTON	DL	JAMARI SHARPE	INDIANA
DL	JAMARI SHARPE	INDIANA	DL	ZEKE BERRY	MICHIGAN
DL	ZEKE BERRY	MICHIGAN			



BIG TEN - UNIT RANKS

TEAM	QB	RB	WR/TE	OL	DL	LB	DB
OREGON	1	3	2	4	1	3	1
OHIO STATE	2	4	1	1	3	2	3
INDIANA	6	14	4	2	2	1	4
USC	4	2	3	5	4	8	10
MICHIGAN	9	1	7	6	5	11	2
WASHINGTON	3	12	6	7	6	4	7
PENN STATE	5	7	5	8	10	6	8
IOWA	17	9	8	3	9	7	6
WISCONSIN	10	10	13	11	13	5	12
NEBRASKA	7	16	9	9	11	13	14
ILLINOIS	15	13	12	10	15	9	5
MINNESOTA	11	6	10	12	7	12	15
UCLA	8	11	11	13	12	16	11
N'WESTERN	13	8	16	14	16	15	9
MARYLAND	14	17	14	17	8	14	13
MICHIGAN ST	12	15	15	16	14	10	17
RUTGERS	18	5	17	18	17	18	18
PURDUE	16	18	18	15	18	17	16





OREGON

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#1

BIG TEN

#1

OVERALL



OREGON				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
15				(P) Indiana
14	(B) Oklahoma		(CG) Washington	INDIANA
13	(CG) UTAH	OREGON ST	WASHINGTON	(CG) Penn St
12	UTAH	WASHINGTON Georgia	(B) Liberty	(P) Texas Tech
11	STANFORD	OREGON ST	WASHINGTON	(P) JMU
10	OREGON ST	(B) UNC	ARIZONA ST	WASHINGTON
9	WASH ST	UTAH	USC	MINNESOTA
8	WASHINGTON	COLORADO	CAL	IOWA
7	COLORADO	CAL	UTAH	WISCONSIN
6	UCLA	UCLA	WASH ST	RUTGERS
5	CAL	ARIZONA	STANFORD	PENN ST
4	ARIZONA	STANFORD	COLORADO	Oregon St
3	Stony Brook (FCS)	WASH ST	Hawaii	N'WESTERN
2	Ohio St	BYU	Texas Tech	Oklahoma
1	Fresno St	E. Wash (FCS)	Port. St (FCS)	Mont. St (FCS)
2021		2022	2023	2024
CRISTOBAL		DAN LANNING		

OREGON				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
Montana St (FCS) W	59-13	262	0	74.8
OKLAHOMA ST W	69-3	420	2	87.5
N'WESTERN W	34-14	60	1	77.3
OREGON ST W	41-7	438	1	82.9
PENN ST W	30-24	148	1	93.1
INDIANA L	20-30	-59	-1	35.2
RUTGERS W	56-10	548	0	103.0
WISCONSIN W	21-7	139	1	81.1
IOWA W	18-16	134	1	80.9
MINNESOTA W	42-13	310	-1	99.1
USC W	42-27	54	1	92.9
WASHINGTON W	26-14	109	2	96.5
(P) JMU W	51-34	5	-2	81.3
(P) TEXAS TECH W	23-0	94	3	114.6
(P) INDIANA L	22-56	16	-3	23.0
OVERALL: 5th / 68 BIGTEN: 3rd / 18 81.5				

OREGON		UNIT RANKS	
BIG TEN RANK		NATIONAL	
(of 18)		TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	1	2	
RUNNING BACKS	3	9	
RECEIVERS & TE	2	5	
OFFENSIVE LINE	4	6	
DEFENSIVE LINE	1	1	
LINEBACKERS	3	14	
DEFENSIVE BACKS	1	1	

OREGON		RANK	
Scoring Offense	36.9 ppg	11	
Points per Play	0.56	7	
Total Offense	452 ypg	16	
Yards per Play	6.9	9	
Rushing Offense	199 ypg	20	
Yards per Carry	5.4	13	
O-Line Run Push	4.6	27	
Explosive Rush	7.1	19	
Passing Offense	254 ypg	39	
Yards / Attempt	8.7	13	
QB Rating	164	7	
TD / INT Ratio	3.1	28	
Sacks / Attempt	4%	25	
Explosive Pass	10.1	6	
Return. Production	65%	26	
Returning Snaps	12,298	36	
27.5 SECONDS/PLAY #46 of 68 P4			
MEHRINGER (2025 OREGON)			

In last year's 2025 preview, I wrote that "Oregon is my pick to win the national championship ... next year in 2026."

Dan Lanning elevated the program's recruiting profile to compete with the Dynasty Tier super-recruiters. And then he did it three years in a row. Oregon, Alabama, and Ohio State are the only programs to stack Top 5 recruiting classes in each of the past three years. Oregon took it a step further and signed two Top 5 transfer classes too.

On paper, it was an embarrassment of riches, but the 2025 two-deep was packed with first-time starters, true freshmen and sophomores. I still picked Oregon to finish third in the Big Ten and earn a Playoff at-large bid, but noted the real national title shot would come in 2026.

Five games in, Oregon looked ahead of schedule. They dealt Oklahoma State their worst loss in a century (69-3, +420 yardage), dominated the last scheduled Civil War with Oregon State (41-7, +440 yardage), and spoiled Penn State's dream season and White Out crowd in double-overtime.

Then their nation-best home win streak was snapped at 18 games by the eventual Heisman winner and eventual national champion Indiana.

Oregon got right back on track with a +550 yardage win over Rutgers, quarterback Dante Moore led a game-winning drive in the final minute to hold off Iowa's upset bid, and Oregon proceeded to win the rest of their games by double-digits.

That includes the first home playoff game in school history, a 51-34 win over James Madison, and then a Peach Bowl 23-0 shutout over #4 Texas Tech.

The semifinal rematch with Indiana was doomed from the start, as the Hoosiers took back the opening pass for a Pick Six and raced to a 35-7 halftime lead and eventual 56-22 win. Nothing was stopping Indiana in 2025. But Oregon's 13-2 campaign with a young roster will pay dividends in 2026 and beyond.

OFFENSE

It helps getting back a first-round NFL quarterback. Dante Moore surprised by returning to Oregon for a final year after passing for 3,565 yards, 30 touchdowns (10 picks), and the #5 QB Rating in Power 4. Moore is a polished passer, accurate with ball placement and a top five completion percentage (72%), and led the only offense to place in the top five of all three of my opponent-adjusted metrics: #5 overall, #4 passing, #4 rushing.

Moore returns as a Heisman favorite. Before he announced his return, former five-star and two-year Nebraska starter Dylan Raiola shocked Husker Nation and transferred to Eugene. Even after Moore's announcement, Raiola decided to stay at Oregon and will get a developmental year before gunning for the 2027 job.

Noah Whittington graduated after leading with 829 yards. The running back room was complicated by a run of injuries, and a pair of Top200 true freshmen aced their auditions. Jordon Davison cashed in 15 touchdowns, Dierre Hill gained a nation-best 8.8 yards/carry, and these two are the lead pair for 2026. The phenom freshmen sent three other backs to the portal, so the third back will be incoming Top100 Tradarian Ball.

Injuries hit the receiver room too, with original WR1 Evan Stewart getting knocked out in fall camp, and starters Gary Bryant and Dakorien Moore both missing games. Both Stewart and Moore were five-stars and the #1 rated receiver in their classes, and both returned fully healthy this offseason to form an elite one-two punch. Top100 freshman Jeremiah McClellan stepped up last year and despite neither of the three being slot receivers, the staff said they will go "position-less" to get their playmakers on the field together. Add in two more five-stars – Jalen Lott and Gatlin Bair – plus a 900-yard receiver last year in Iverson Hooks (UAB) and this is a top unit.

Kenyon Sadiq earned first-team All-Big Ten and was the first tight end off the board in April's NFL Draft. Oregon feels confident they'll make it two-in-a-row with Jamari Johnson who surged over

OREGON										OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)												
O																						
F	5	5	3	11	22	18	22	39	29	15	9th											
F	WILL STEIN			DILLINGHAM	JOE MOORHEAD		MARCUS ARROYO		CRISTOBAL		LUBICK											
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR											
D	TOSH LUPOI				DeRUUYTER	ANDY AVALOS		JIM LEAVITT		HOKE												
E	5	21	11	41	26	26	11	37	19	64	20th											
F																						

OREGON		RANK	
Scoring Defense	17.9 ppg	12	
Points per Play	0.29	15	
Total Defense	274 ypg	7	
Yards per Play	4.4	6	
3rd Down Conv%	38%	55	
Rushing Defense	116 ypg	24	
Yards per Carry	3.4	20	
Negative Play %	8%	80	
Explosive Rush	3.9	5	
Passing Defense	158 ypg	4	
Yards / Attempt	5.6	5	
QB Rating	108	8	
Completion %	53.3%	4	
Explosive Pass	4.5	16	
Return. Production	66%	11	
Returning Snaps	12,640	32	

OREGON		RANK / 68
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play		
Offense Overall		5
Rushing Offense	1.6	4
Passing Offense	33.2	4
Defense Overall		5
Rushing Defense	1.0	16
Passing Defense	36.1	2

defensive backfield in *Pick Six Previews*' history – at least in recruiting ranking terms. Four five-stars, four more Top50's, and four more Top100s.

That softens the blow of losing All-American safety Dillon Thieneman. Brandon Finney and Ify Obidegwu both surged to starting roles as freshmen last year, Finney earned Freshman All-America honors, and they are joined by two more five-stars Na'eem Offord and Aaron Scott (Ohio State). Aaron Flowers is a returning starter at safety, they signed the #1 transfer safety, All-Big Ten Koi Perich (Minnesota), and have a pair of five-stars packing the two-deep in Trey McNutt and Jett Washington.

Good luck throwing the ball against Oregon the next few seasons.

OUTLOOK

Oregon is #2 in Game Grader over the past three-year average. Last year they finished #5 in Game Grader and #1 in opponent-adjusted yardage margin – and did so with a younger lineup. They are the only program to stack three straight top five recruiting classes *and* two top five transfer hauls.

Well, it's 2026 and I am sticking to my call from back in July 2025. **Oregon is my 2026 National Champion pick.**

OREGON		RANK / 68
All-Time Wins	732	30
All-Time Win %	0.585	26
Wins (Last 100)	612	27
Wins (Last 50)	385	19
Wins (Last 25)	240	7
Wins (Last 10)	94	8
Wins (Last 5)	58	3
Game Grader (10 yr)	64.4	11
Game Grader (5 yr)	73.8	4
Game Grader (3 yr)	82.4	2
Draft Picks s' 2000	105	15
Draft Picks s' 2010	71	14
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		31
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		30

the back half of the season and was matching Sadiq's performance. A pair of Top50 prospects will battle for the second spot: Andrew Olesh (Penn State) and Kendre Harrison.

All five linemen earned All-Big Ten honors, and if it sounds repetitive, it is -- 12 offensive players were all-conference. The starting tackles Isaiah World and Alex Harkey and guard Emmanuel Pregnon are all gone but the other two return in center Iapani Laloulu and third-year starting guard Dave Iuli. The staff declined the transfer portal this cycle and doubled down on their recent blue-chip recruiting and development. At left tackle, four-star Fox Crader battles Top100 Ziyare Addison. At the other two spots, veterans Kawika Rogers and Michael Bennett will be challenged by four Top100 linemen.

DEFENSE

Oregon was the only team with a Top 5 offense *and* a Top 5 defense per my opponent-adjusted metrics. Nine defenders earned All-Big Ten honors and eight starters are back.

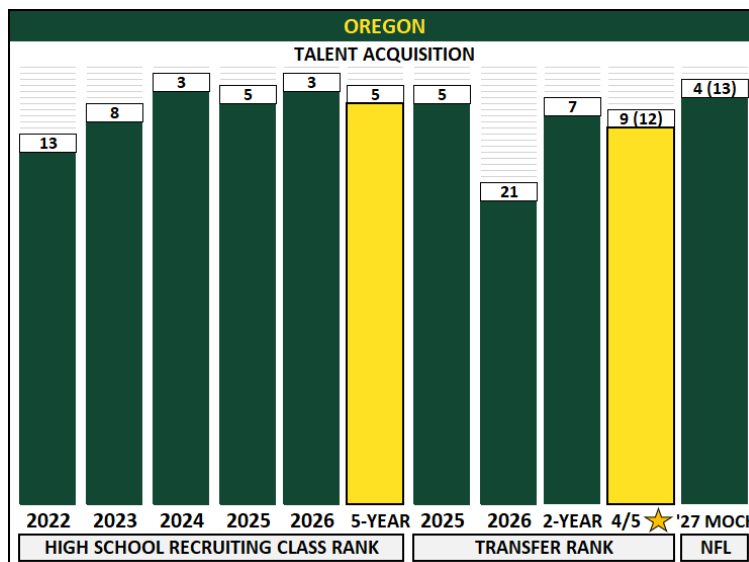
The entire starting defensive line returned intact with Bear Alexander and A'Mauri Washington on the interior, and Matayo Uiagalelei and Teitum Tuioti off the ends. Uiagalelei led the Big Ten in sacks in the 2024 regular season, Tuioti has a high motor, and both are third-year starters. The front four is so strong, all four of their backups transferred out to other Power 4 schools with four-star grades. UNC starter D'Antre Robinson helped bolster the new two-deep, along with two five-stars Elijah Rushing and Anthony Jones, and two more Top200 guys in Nasir Wyatt and Aydin Breland.

Their leader in the middle Bryce Boettcher is gone after posting 136 tackles, an Oregon high since 1979. Jerry Mixon is a returning starter, and former Top100 Devon Jackson has sprinter speed and is poised to finally break out. The staff ignored the portal here, instead going with three four-star freshmen reserves.

As if this roster wasn't stacked enough, the secondary is simply unbelievable. I don't think I've seen this amount of raw firepower in any

OREGON	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 5	BOISE STATE
S. 12	@ Oklahoma St
S. 18	PORTLAND ST (FCS)
S. 26	@ USC
O. 3	--- BYE ---
O. 10	UCLA
O. 17	NEBRASKA
O. 24	@ Illinois
O. 31	NORTHWESTERN
N. 7	@ Ohio State
N. 14	MICHIGAN
N. 20	@ Michigan State
N. 28	WASHINGTON

OREGON		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
81.5 (5)	77.4 (4)	88.2 (3)	67.4 (12)	54.4 (30)	58.5 (24)	74.3 (10)	53.4 (30)	51.7 (34)	37.6 (54)	64.4 (11)	





OVERALL

Ryan Day kept the offensive scheme safe and conservative for first-time starter Julian Sayin but then took off the training wheels after the first month. Sayin was flawless. He ended up setting an NCAA regular season record with a 78.4% completion rate and earned a seat at the Heisman ceremony.

OFFENSE

Most of the talent drain was on defense, and Ohio State returns their Heisman candidate quarterback, 1,000 yard running back, four offensive line starters, and superstar receiver Jeremiah Smith who many believe is the best overall player in college football.

Sayin finished his first season with 3,610 yards, 32 touchdowns and eight picks to win the Shaun Alexander Freshman of the Year award. His passing accuracy and ball placement are as good as anyone, but to unlock the final tier of his game, Sayin needs to create plays with his legs in crunch time – whether it be pocket elusiveness to extend the play, or tucking the ball on a critical third-and-medium. Basically the Craig Krenzel type plays that don't show up on the stat sheet, but eventually win national titles.

Bo Jackson is back after his surprise 1,000-yard freshman season, and the offense looks to add more explosiveness to the run game (#73). They may have found lightning in a bottle with incoming Top100 athlete Legend Bey who Day has already compared to Tyreek Hill and Buckeye great Curtis Samuel. Bey will be the do-it-all from the slot, H-back, etc.

Since 2019, Ohio State has featured at least two future first-round picks in their receiver room. Brian Hartline built a conveyor belt of five-stars and 2025 was no different with Smith earning unanimous All-America honors with 1,243 yards and 12 touchdowns. Carnell Tate was selected fourth overall. Smith is back for a final season and is on pace to break all school receiving records, and five-star Brandon Inniss also returns to the starting trio. A pair of five-stars Mylan Graham and Quincy Porter both transferred out to Notre Dame, likely due to the breakout of five-star Chris Henry who surged all the way to the #2 role in spring and will be the beneficiary of Smith's double-teams. Devin McCuin (UTSA) earned All-AAC last year with 65 catches and 726 yards, and another freshman Brock Boyd drew big spring reviews.

Both All-Big Ten tight ends Max Klare and Will Kacmarek are gone, but the staff signed another all-leaguer in Hunter Welcing (Northwestern). Mason Williams (Ohio) was All-MAC, but the spring hero was Top200 Nate Roberts.

OHIO STATE										OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)										
O																				
F	13	2	9	1	1	3	4	6	6	23	1st									
F	HARTLINE	KELLY	HARTLINE	KEVIN WILSON				WILSON / DAY			WARRINER									
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR									
D	PATRICIA	JIM KNOWLES			KERRY COOMBS		MATTISON	GREG SCHIANO		FICKELL										
F	2	1	2	32	27	49	3	56	5	3	4th									

OHIO STATE		RANK	
Scoring Defense	9.3 ppg	1	
Points per Play	0.17	1	
Total Defense	219 ypg	1	
Yards per Play	4.0	2	
3rd Down Conv%	31%	10	
Rushing Defense	89 ypg	7	
Yards per Carry	2.9	7	
Negative Play %	10%	13	
Explosive Rush	4.2	10	
Passing Defense	130 ypg	1	
Yards / Attempt	5.3	2	
QB Rating	108	7	
Completion %	60.8%	56	
Explosive Pass	3.0	1	
Return. Production	50%	78	
Returning Snaps	11,184	52	

OHIO STATE		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		13	
Rushing Offense	0.3	30	
Passing Offense	38.0	2	
Defense Overall		2	
Rushing Defense	1.4	6	
Passing Defense	32.9	5	

Ohio State has as strong a claim as anyone to the "Defensive Back U" title, and Caleb Downs leaves as one of their best safeties of all-time along with Mike Doss and Jack Tatum. Jaylen McClain returns at the other safety spot with star potential, and the staff signed a pair of All-ACC safeties in Earl Little (Florida State) and Terry Moore (Duke). They added more firepower with five-star Jay Timmons and Top100 Blaine Bradford. Davison Igbinosun heads to the pros but Jermaine Mathews returns at one corner, and five-star Devin Sanchez is poised to be yet another Buckeye great.

OUTLOOK

11 more draft picks gone? No problem. The Ohio State machine rolls on into 2026 with a top five offense, multiple Heisman contenders, a veteran offensive line, and another round of five-stars moving up into starting roles.

This time around they added six Power 4 starting defenders from the transfer portal for extra firepower for Patricia's second season calling the defense.

Ohio State will return to the Big Ten title game and then gear up for another Playoff run. If Sayin takes the next step and makes those X-Factor plays off-script, Ohio State can win the national title.

The offensive line was strong in the regular season, had its pinnacle performance against Michigan, but then struggled against the elite lines of Indiana and Miami. Four starters are back, all four earned All-Big Ten honors, and their 91 combined starts make this one of the most veteran lines in America: tackles Austin Siereveld and Phillip Daniels, guard Luke Montgomery, and center Carson Hinzman. Siereveld did not allow a single sack all year and is their best shot at an All-America season. Tegra Tshabola transferred out to Kentucky after losing his starting job. A trio of former Top200 prospects will battle to be the fifth starter – Joshua Padilla, Gabe VanSickle, and spring hero Ian Moore.

DEFENSE

The "mad scientist" Patricia built the best defense of the entire College Football Playoff era. Ohio State allowed just 9.3 points/game, 219 yards/game, which were both Playoff era bests (2014-2025). 12 defenders earned All-Big Ten, three were unanimous All-Americans, and three were drafted in the first 11 picks.

Kayden McDonald was a force in the middle, posting a productive stat line for a defensive tackle (65 tackles, 9 for loss, 3 sacks), Caden Curry led with 11 sacks and 16.5 tackles-for-loss, and Tywone Malone earned the other starting tackle spot. All three are gone, and end Kenyatta Jackson is the only returning starter on the line. Ohio State added two starters off the Alabama line – tackle James Smith and end Qua Russaw – and both were former five-star recruits who earned four-star transfer grades. They signed another former Top100 starter John Walker (UCF), and still have five-star Eddrick Houston ready for a breakout season at tackle.

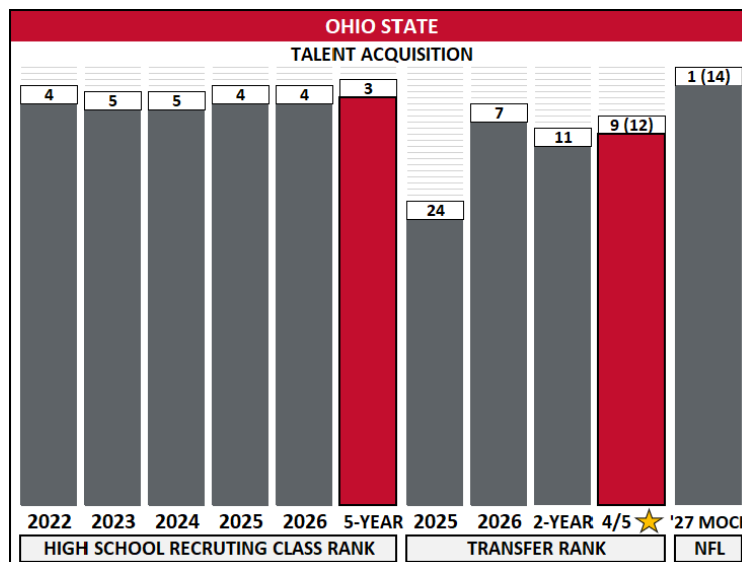
Even the greatest reloading programs would struggle here. Ohio State has to replace two All-American, first-round linebackers in Arvell Reese and Sonny Styles. Payton Pierce was their third backer and he steps into the top role, the staff signed Wisconsin starter Christian Alliegro who was ranked the #3 linebacker transfer this cycle, and then a trio of blue-chippers add to the position battle. Riley Pettijohn and TJ Alford were both Top100's from the 2025 class, five-star Cincere Johnson was the #1 linebacker of 2026, and spring reports mention that Alford was the early standout.

Ohio State has as strong a claim as anyone to the "Defensive Back U" title, and

OHIO STATE	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 5	BALL STATE
S. 12	@ Texas
S. 19	KENT STATE
S. 26	ILLINOIS
O. 3	@ Iowa
O. 10	MARYLAND
O. 17	@ Indiana
O. 24	--- BYE ---
O. 31	@ USC
N. 7	OREGON
N. 14	NORTHWESTERN
N. 21	@ Nebraska
N. 28	MICHIGAN

OHIO STATE		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	990	2	
All-Time Win %	0.737	1	
Wins (Last 100)	802	3	
Wins (Last 50)	482	1	
Wins (Last 25)	265	1	
Wins (Last 10)	115	3	
Wins (Last 5)	59	2	
Game Grader (10 yr)	84.1	2	
Game Grader (5 yr)	84.4	2	
Game Grader (3 yr)	84.6	1	
Draft Picks s' 2000	192	1	
Draft Picks s' 2010	123	2	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		33	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		34	

OHIO STATE		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
86.8 (2)	89.2 (1)	77.7 (5)	83.1 (3)	85.2 (3)	80.7 (4)	101.7 (1)	76.4 (5)	82.4 (7)	78 (5)	84.1 (2)	





INDIANA		RANK	
Scoring Defense	11.7 ppg	2	
Points per Play	0.21	3	
Total Defense	266 ypg	4	
Yards per Play	4.7	16	
3rd Down Conv%	30%	8	
Rushing Defense	77 ypg	2	
Yards per Carry	3.0	10	
Negative Play %	14%	2	
Explosive Rush	3.9	6	
Passing Defense	189 ypg	24	
Yards / Attempt	6.2	22	
QB Rating	113	15	
Completion %	62%	71	
Explosive Pass	4.8	35	
Return. Production	58%	39	
Returning Snaps	14,887	11	
INDIANA		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		6	
Rushing Offense	1.0	13	
Passing Offense	56.8	1	
Defense Overall		15	
Rushing Defense	1.3	11	
Passing Defense	27.0	9	

first two seasons. Tyler Morris is back from injury and was the spring hero in the slot. The staff also added Shazz Preston who was Tulane's #1 receiver last year and his 16.8 per-catch average was a Top 5 AAC mark.

The tight end room is the biggest question heading into fall camp after the departure of All-Big Ten Riley Nowakowski. Andrew Barker is a blocking tight end and incoming four-star Brock Schott (Miami) is the receiving threat. Given the uncertainty, coordinator Mike Shanahan may show some new wrinkles or more four-WR sets.

Four starters are back from their Joe Moore Award semifinalist line, including All-American, "Big Ten Lineman of the Year" Carter Smith at left tackle. All-Big Ten center Pat Coogan is the lone departure from their national title line. Bray Lynch shifted in to the center spot, Drew Evans is back at guard, and Adedamola Ajani who surged up the depth chart in the playoffs. The staff signed Wisconsin starter Joe Brunner, who was ranked the #3 interior lineman this cycle.

DEFENSE

Indiana allowed just 11.7 points/game (#2) and 266 yards/game (#4) and coordinator Bryant Haines was named the Broyles Award winner. Oregon's Dan Lanning faced Haines' defense twice last year and noted several challenges: "they're really good at post-snap movement, the defensive line plays with relentless effort, and it's the best zone break defense I've seen this year."

Nine defenders earned All-Big Ten honors, six return for 2026, plus the staff added five more starters off other Power 4 rosters.

The interior tackle duo of Tyrique Tucker and Mario Landino could be one of the nation's best pairs. Tucker could push for All-America honors, and Landino was a wrecking-ball throughout the season. Three ends are gone, but Daniel Ndukwe played well after the starters were injured, and the staff hit the portal here. Indiana signed both of Kansas State's starting ends with All-Big 12 Chiddi Obiazor and elite pass rusher Tobi Osunsanmi. Josh Burnham (Notre Dame) and Joe Hjelle (Tulsa) were three-star additions.

The quarterback-of-the-defense Aiden Fisher went pro, but the other two backers return after All-Big Ten seasons: Rolijah Hardy and Isaiah Jones. With a proven pair, they may show more 4-2-5 looks rather than their three-backer 4-3 last year.

Two first-team All-Big Ten defensive backs are gone with lockdown corner D'Angelo Ponds and strong safety Louis Moore both going pro. Jamari Sharpe had the national title-sealing interception and returns at corner, and the other corner spot is a battle between Ryland Gandy and former five-star, Penn State starter AJ Harris. Amare Ferrell returns at free safety and the staff added two more Power 4 starters in Quan Sanks (Cincinnati) and seventh-year Preston Zachman (Wisconsin).

OUTLOOK

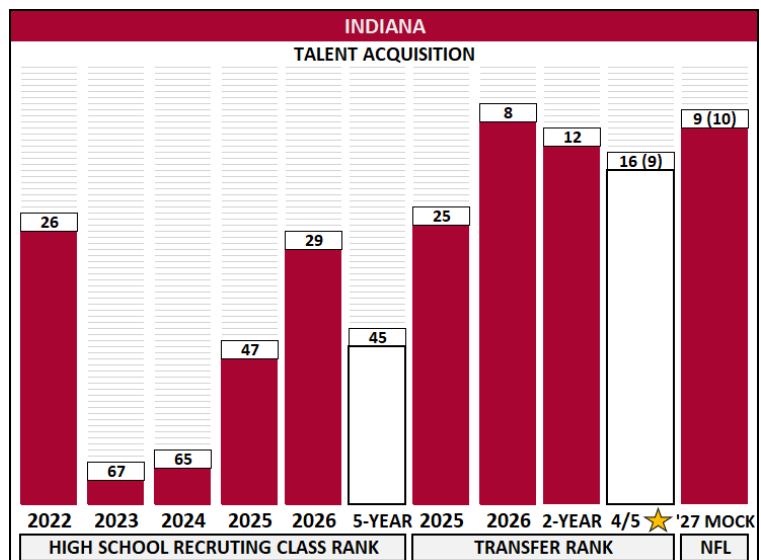
Cignetti's national champion Hoosiers head into 2026 with a clear top five defense with an impressive six All-Big Ten stars returning on that side of the ball. The offensive line should contend for the Joe Moore Award and their coordinators are both elite.

It's splitting hairs at the top of the Big Ten, but the loss of the Heisman winner and two game-changing receivers moves Indiana out of the top spot. They are still a Playoff pick and have a shot at a repeat title.

INDIANA	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 5	NORTH TEXAS
S. 12	HOWARD (FCS)
S. 19	W. KENTUCKY
S. 25	NORTHWESTERN
O. 3	@ Rutgers
O. 10	@ Nebraska
O. 17	OHIO STATE
O. 24	@ Michigan
O. 31	MINNESOTA
N. 7	--- BYE ---
N. 14	USC
N. 21	@ Washington
N. 28	PURDUE

INDIANA		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	535	65	
All-Time Win %	0.430	67	
Wins (Last 100)	410	67	
Wins (Last 50)	248	63	
Wins (Last 25)	127	63	
Wins (Last 10)	66	38	
Wins (Last 5)	36	35	
Game Grader (10 yr)	47.7	44	
Game Grader (5 yr)	47.7	43	
Game Grader (3 yr)	64.1	13	
Draft Picks s' 2000	35	61	
Draft Picks s' 2010	28	51	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		26	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		18	

INDIANA		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	2015	10-YEAR
91.8 (1)	72.8 (8)	27.6 (65)	23.4 (67)	22.8 (65)	56 (28)	50.3 (32)	43.1 (55)	43.9 (48)	45.8 (41)	47.7 (44)	



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#4

#11



BIG TEN

OVERALL

USC				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
14		(B) Tulane		
13		(CG) Utah		
12	CAL	UTAH	UCLA	OREGON
11	BYU	Notre Dame	WASHINGTON	WASHINGTON
10	UCLA	UCLA	UTAH	MARYLAND
9	ARIZONA ST	COLORADO	Notre Dame	PENN ST
8	Notre Dame	CAL	(B) Louisville	MICHIGAN
7	UTAH	ARIZONA	CAL	(B) Texas A&M
6	OREGON ST	WASH ST	ARIZONA	UCLA
5	STANFORD	ARIZONA ST	COLORADO	NEBRASKA
4	ARIZONA	OREGON ST	ARIZONA ST	RUTGERS
3	COLORADO	Fresno St	STANFORD	WISCONSIN
2	WASH ST	STANFORD	Nevada	Utah St
1	San Jose St	Rice	San Jose St	LSU
2021		2022	2023	2024
*WILLIAMS		LINCOLN RILEY		

In last year's preview magazine I wrote that the 2025 season was critical for Lincoln Riley and the USC program overall. They were projected to sign the #1 recruiting class in America, but a losing season could have been enough to fire Riley – and ultimately break apart that top class.

Riley needed to do enough to survive 2025 to get to the other side with a talent-packed roster.

USC dropped a 73-point bomb in the opener and stayed atop the offensive charts for most of the season, finishing 3rd of 68 Power 4 in my opponent-adjusted ranking. The 4-0 start was soured by a shootout loss at Illinois, and then a kickoff return touchdown cost them the Notre Dame game.

Other USC teams over the past decade would have crumbled, but this one found an extra gear. Down two linemen and three running backs, walk-on King Miller overpowered #15 Michigan with 158 rushing yards. Nebraska neutralized their pass game, but Miller again helped lead the win in a “Blackout” game at Memorial Stadium.

USC				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
MISSOURI ST W 73-13	373	2	86.6	
GA SOUTHERN W 59-20	378	0	87.3	
PURDUE W 33-17	103	3	67.1	
MICHIGAN ST W 45-31	186	-1	74.5	
ILLINOIS L 32-34	-12	0	52.3	
MICHIGAN W 31-13	173	0	102.7	
NOTRE DAME L 24-34	-46	-2	34.9	
NEBRASKA W 21-17	51	0	60.4	
N'WESTERN W 38-17	202	1	88.0	
IOWA W 26-21	40	1	79.1	
OREGON L 27-42	-54	-1	29.7	
UCLA W 29-10	80	0	67.6	
(B) TCU L 27-30	17	-1	47.9	
OVERALL: 12th / 68 BIGTEN: 4th / 18 67.5				

USC trailed Iowa 21-7 shortly before halftime but didn't flinch. Instead, the offense scored on five straight possessions for the comeback win to push to 8-2 overall and a Top 15 AP ranking.

They were unable to break through in a quasi Playoff play-in game against Oregon, losing 42-27 in Eugene, but they capped a perfect 7-0 home slate by beating UCLA 29-10 in the finale.

They don't hang banners in the LA Coliseum for nine-win seasons, but it was certainly enough to get Riley through to this program-changing recruiting haul. It was an important nine wins. Riley agrees and said, “we'll have better teams here in the future than this team, but I don't know if we'll have had a more *important* team.”

OFFENSE

Jayden Maiava took a major step forward in his first full season as the starter here. He earned third-team All-Big Ten, placed second in the league with a high 9.2 yards/attempt, and threw 24 touchdowns. Maiava will need to cut down on the 10 picks, but this should remain a Top 10 offense with him at the helm. Five-star Husan Longstreet was projected as the 2027 starter of the future but he transferred out to LSU.

Waymond Jordan and Eli Sanders were both injured in the Michigan game, forcing the walk-on Miller into the lead role. While healthy, Jordan was averaging 6.6 per carry and posted two 100-yard games in the five before the injury. Miller nearly broke the 1,000-yard milestone (6.2 per carry) and these two return to form a top duo in 2026. They added a pair of Top100 backs in Shahn Alston and Deshon Redeaux.

Makai Lemon was simply unstoppable. He led Power 4 in receiving yards/game (96), cashed in 11 touchdowns, and earned the Biletnikoff. His co-star Ja'Kobi Lane also graduated, but Tanook Hines impressed as a freshman and leads another crowded room into 2026. Zachary Williams was Utah's #1 receiver and is back from injury. The staff added NC State's lead receiver Terrell Anderson who was graded a four-star transfer and was fifth in the ACC in yards/catch. Then USC signed some extra firepower with two near-five-stars Ethan Feaster and Kayden Dixon-Wyatt, and another Top200 fresh off a CA state title run in Trent Mosley.

It's the same deal at tight end. Star veterans Lake McRee and Walker Lyons are gone, but five-star Mark Bowman (Mater Dei, CA) could start right away as a true freshman. The staff added blocking end Tucker Ashcraft (Wisconsin) who was called an “instant impact.” Riley's tight end usage more than doubled from 2024 to 2025 in targets and yards, but he may shift back to more 11 or 10 personnel if those elite receivers are as-advertised.

The offensive line returns all five original starters, but this group was crushed with injuries and they were forced to start seven different line combinations. Still, the line made it consecutive Top 25 finishes in both OL Run Push and Pass Protection. Elijah Paige is the anchor at left tackle, Justin Tauanu started all year at right tackle, Alani Noa has 22 career starts, and Tobias Raymond has

USC		UNIT RANKS	
BIG TEN RANK		NATIONAL	
(of 18)		TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	4	10	
RUNNING BACKS	2	7	
RECEIVERS & TE	3	12	
OFFENSIVE LINE	5	10	
DEFENSIVE LINE	4	12	
LINEBACKERS	8		
DEFENSIVE BACKS	10		

USC		RANK	
Scoring Offense	35.8 ppg	13	
Points per Play	0.55	9	
Total Offense	466 ypg	8	
Yards per Play	7.1	4	
Rushing Offense	169 ypg	55	
Yards per Carry	5.2	21	
O-Line Run Push	4.6	23	
Explosive Rush	6.8	28	
Passing Offense	296 ypg	5	
Yards / Attempt	9.2	8	
QB Rating	159	11	
TD / INT Ratio	2.6	43	
Sacks / Attempt	4%	8	
Explosive Pass	9.8	8	
Return. Production	67%	22	
Returning Snaps	10,341	58	
27.3 SECONDS/PLAY #44 of 68 P4			
RILEY (2025 USC)			

USC					OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)									
O	3	9	2	7	34	48	11	37	14	13				7th
F														
F	HUARD	JOSH HENSON	GRAHAM HARRELL	TEE MARTIN										
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016				10-YEAR
D	D'ANTON LYNN	ALEX GRINCH	TODD ORLANDO	CLANCY PENDERGAST										
E	35	52	50	66	60	10	38	32	33	24				41st
F														

USC		RANK	
Scoring Defense	23 ppg	51	
Points per Play	0.36	62	
Total Defense	351 ypg	49	
Yards per Play	5.6	65	
3rd Down Conv%	40%	82	
Rushing Defense	143 ypg	59	
Yards per Carry	4.4	82	
Negative Play %	9%	46	
Explosive Rush	7.1	91	
Passing Defense	208 ypg	47	
Yards / Attempt	6.8	54	
QB Rating	136	81	
Completion %	65.7%	115	
Explosive Pass	4.9	40	
Return. Production	64%	16	
Returning Snaps	10,346	58	
USC		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		3	
Rushing Offense	0.9	16	
Passing Offense	30.6	7	
Defense Overall		35	
Rushing Defense	0.2	44	
Passing Defense	2.5	39	

alongside Deven Bryant (Washington) who brings Big Ten starting experience. Incoming Top100 Talanoa Ili could push into the rotation.

Injuries plagued the secondary with two original starters -- Chasen Johnson and Prophet Brown -- lost by mid-September. Then in November both star safeties Kamari Ramsey and All-American Bishop Fitzgerald were injured. Johnson and Brown are back, the safeties are gone, and Patterson has plenty to sort out in the secondary. Marcelles Williams, Alex Graham, and Christian Pierce all started games last year. The staff signed the #1 transfer corner Jontez Williams (Iowa State) who earned All-Big 12 honors and is an instant starter here. And of course, they grabbed another Top100 super-recruit in corner Elbert Hill.

OUTLOOK

For the first time since the Pete Carroll dynasty, USC signed the nation's #1 recruiting class. Add in that extra firepower to last year's #12 Game Grader team (#7 in opponent-adjusted yardage margin), with 14 starters back plus six more Power 4 starters transferring in...

2026 is Playoff or Bust for USC. They are my pick for the final at-large Playoff spot in the 2026 bracket.

USC		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	891	10	
All-Time Win %	0.693	7	
Wins (Last 100)	757	8	
Wins (Last 50)	406	14	
Wins (Last 25)	213	12	
Wins (Last 10)	78	20	
Wins (Last 5)	39	27	
Game Grader (10 yr)	60.9	14	
Game Grader (5 yr)	60.4	15	
Game Grader (3 yr)	62.2	18	
Draft Picks s' 2000	137	8	
Draft Picks s' 2010	76	12	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)	9		
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)	45		



shown positional flexibility to play anywhere. Kilian O'Connor is back at center, plus the staff added the nation's #1 tackle in five-star Keeneyi Pepe.

In total, they have eight offensive starters back, plus NC State's #1 receiver, plus four incoming five-stars.

DEFENSE

After the defensive collapse under Alex Grinch, Riley hired D'Anton Lynn from across town. There was no breakthrough and after two years Lynn left.

A few weeks after playing TCU in the bowl game, Riley hired Mr. TCU himself -- former head coach Gary Patterson -- to take over the defense. Patterson's unique match-zone 4-2-5 defense helped build TCU into a mid-major powerhouse and eventually thrive through the transition up to the Big 12.

TCU went just 21-21 overall in his final four years there, but his 20-year sample size of elite defenses is no fluke. He inherits quite the stockpile of blue-chip talent, and at his opening presser he noted "I've never had this big of a defensive line."

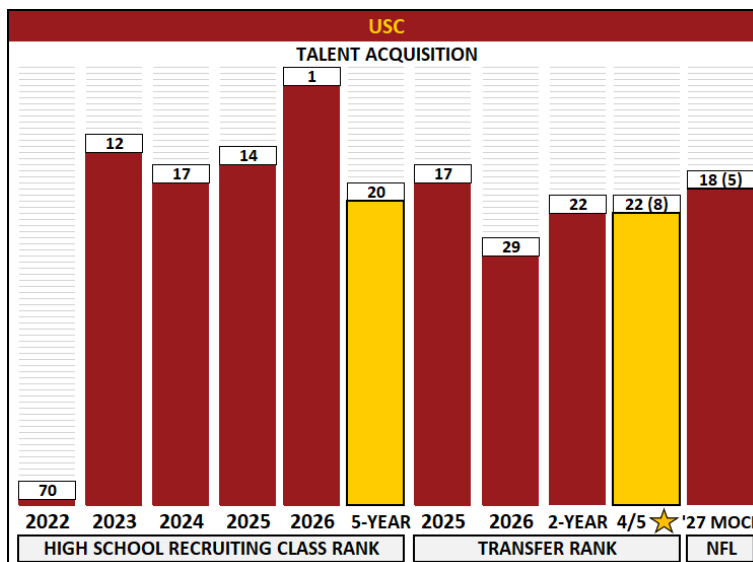
Three starting linemen return with Jide Abasiri at tackle and Kameryn Crawford and Braylan Shelby on the ends. Former five-star tackle Jahkeem Stewart earned Freshman All-America honors last year and the room was beefed up by three major signings: Michigan State starter Alex VanSumeren, five-star Jaimeon Winfield, and Top100 Tomuhini Topui.

The staff added two more to the end spots with Penn State starter Zuriah Fisher (rated as a four-star transfer) and five-star Luke Waffle (Princeton, NJ) who was ranked the #1 DE in the 2026 class. USC hasn't posted a Top 30 run defense since 2014 but this is their best shot.

USC loses do-it-all Eric Gentry whose skillset allowed for creative packages. Desman Stephens led with 89 tackles and is back and will likely start

USC	
2026 SCHEDULE	
A. 29	SAN JOSE STATE
S. 4	FRESNO STATE
S. 12	LOUISIANA
S. 19	@ Rutgers
S. 26	OREGON
O. 3	WASHINGTON
O. 10	@ Penn State
O. 17	--- BYE ---
O. 24	@ Wisconsin
O. 31	OHIO STATE
N. 7	--- BYE ---
N. 14	@ Indiana
N. 21	MARYLAND
N. 28	@ UCLA

USC		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
67.5 (12)	63.3 (18)	55.8 (26)	70.1 (9)	45.3 (45)	69.8 (11)	56.8 (22)	44.3 (51)	66.4 (13)	69.5 (10)	60.9 (14)	





MICHIGAN

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#5

BIG TEN

#14

OVERALL



MICHIGAN				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
15	(P) Georgia	(P) TCU	(NC) Washington	
14	MICH ST	(CG) Purdue	(P) Alabama	
13	(CG) Iowa	OHIO ST	(CG) Iowa	INDIANA
12	OHIO ST	ILLINOIS	OHIO ST	OREGON
11	MARYLAND	NEBRASKA	MARYLAND	ILLINOIS
10	PENN ST	RUTGERS	PENN ST	WASHINGTON
9	INDIANA	PURDUE	MICH ST	Texas
8	N'WESTERN	MICH ST	INDIANA	(B) Alabama
7	NEBRASKA	PENN ST	MINNESOTA	OHIO ST
6	WISCONSIN	IOWA	NEBRASKA	N'WESTERN
5	RUTGERS	MARYLAND	RUTGERS	MICH ST
4	N. Illinois	UConn	Bowling Green	WASHINGTON
3	Washington	Hawaii	UNLV	WISCONSIN
2	W. Michigan	Colorado St	E. Carolina	NEBRASKA
1				C. Michigan
				New Mexico
2021		2022	2023	2024
JIM HARBAUGH		SHERRONE MOORE		

MICHIGAN				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
NEW MEXICO W 34-17	185	2	75.5	
OKLAHOMA L 13-24	-120	2	30.1	
C. MICHIGAN W 63-3	477	1	88.6	
NEBRASKA W 30-27	40	0	52.9	
WISCONSIN W 24-10	193	1	85.8	
USC L 13-31	-173	0	17.7	
WASHINGTON W 24-7	168	3	106.8	
MICHIGAN ST W 31-20	57	0	65.2	
PURDUE W 21-16	122	-1	56.2	
N'WESTERN W 24-22	251	-5	66.3	
MARYLAND W 45-20	96	1	74.8	
OHIO ST L 9-27	-256	0	17.1	
(B) TEXAS L 27-41	-83	-2	26.3	
OVERALL: 26th / 68	BIGTEN: 7th / 18		58.7	

MICHIGAN	UNIT RANKS	
BIG TEN RANK	NATIONAL	
(of 18)	TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	9	
RUNNING BACKS	1	3
RECEIVERS & TE	7	
OFFENSIVE LINE	6	12
DEFENSIVE LINE	5	13
LINEBACKERS	11	
DEFENSIVE BACKS	2	8

MICHIGAN	RANK	
Scoring Offense 27.5 ppg	69	
Points per Play 0.43	53	
Total Offense 397 ypg	59	
Yards per Play 6.1	30	
Rushing Offense 210 ypg	14	
Yards per Carry 5.4	12	
O-Line Run Push 4.7	19	
Explosive Rush 6.7	30	
Passing Offense 187 ypg	107	
Yards / Attempt 7.1	73	
QB Rating 124	96	
TD / INT Ratio 1.1	117	
Sacks / Attempt 6%	75	
Explosive Pass 6.6	71	
Return. Production 72%	6	
Returning Snaps 8,035	83	
24.9 SECONDS/PLAY #15 of 68 P4		
BECK (2025 UTAH)	FAST	

After their 2023 national title, Michigan sent a Top 5 all-time draft class to the pros: 13 selections.

By definition, it was a transition year for new head coach Sherrone Moore in 2024 with a new starting lineup. Their broken offense held them back with a disappointing 6-5 record before shocking #1 Ohio State in the largest upset in "The Game" history.

Heading into 2025, Michigan addressed the need at quarterback by signing the nation's #1 overall recruit. Bryce Underwood started right away as a true freshman, flashed against the non-AQ teams in September, but ended up struggling through Big Ten play.

The offense doubled down on what was working, and their power rushing attack grinded out enough wins to remain in the Playoff hunt into November. Michigan held on to beat one-win Purdue 21-16, and then overcame three late turnovers to beat Northwestern 24-22 on a walk-off field goal.

Michigan had a "win and in" opportunity in the season finale against Ohio State, but after intercepting Julian Sayin on the second pass of the game, it was all Buckeyes. The loss snapped the four-game win streak in the series, and placed

Michigan outside the Game Grader Top 25 for the second straight year.

A week later, Moore was fired for an affair with a staffer, and then arrested and charged for other crimes. Michigan is also on NCAA probation for recruiting violations with fines that could reach \$30 million.

The program needed stability, and they got the perfect definition of it in their next hire. Kyle Whittingham was Utah's head coach for the past 21 years, took them undefeated back in 2008, helped move up to the Power 5 tier, and eventually built the program into back-to-back Pac-12 champions.

The 67-year-old says "I still have a lot left in the tank" and that he views this blueblood opportunity as a final challenge: "Michigan is a special place with a legitimate opportunity to win a national championship ... it can happen here, and has happened here."

OFFENSE

Whittingham described his program style as "physicality, toughness, and grit." Not only does that sound like Michigan's 2023 national title formula, Whittingham actually backs up those buzzwords. Just watch a Utah spring game, where they are smashing each other for 60 minutes – no 7-on-7 or non-contact jerseys for the quarterbacks.

He brought offensive coordinator Jason Beck with him. Last year, Beck's power-spread scheme led the most improved offense from 2024 to 2025. Utah led the nation in yards/carry (6.0), placed second in rushing yards/game (266), and complemented the run game with an efficient pass threat that ranked #31 in QB Rating.

Not to oversimplify the transition season, but Michigan's 2026 fate depends on Underwood's development in his second year. His freshman campaign was limited by a conservative gameplan, plenty of drops from the receivers, but also rookie mistakes. Underwood threw nine picks to just 11 touchdowns, was held under 100 yards three times, and placed #12 in the Big Ten in QB Rating.

Beck's scheme is geared towards dual-threat quarterbacks, and Underwood's best games last year were the ones when he used his legs.

Justice Haynes and Jordan Marshall both earned All-Big Ten honors and were the engine of the offense. Haynes transferred out to Georgia Tech but it was Marshall that surged with four straight 100-yard games late in the year. Michigan signed five-star super-recruit Savion Hiter who should get carries right away and form a top duo with Marshall.

Utah's offensive line coach Jim Harding just sent two linemen to the NFL's first round, and inherits a strong unit here. Injuries caused reshuffling last year but those ahead-of-schedule reps, and returning injured starters, should pay dividends here. Four guys earned All-Big Ten honors, two are gone – Giovanni El-Hadi and Greg Crippen – but tackle Andrew Sprague and center Jake Guarnera are back. As

MICHIGAN					OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)									
O	17	60	8	4	8	23	21	15	42	20				13th
F	LINDSEY	CAMPBELL	SHERRONE MOORE	JOSH GATTIS	HAMILTON	TIM DREVNO								
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016				10-YEAR
D	WINK MARTINDALE	JESSE MINTER	MACDONALD											
E	18	7	7	11	11	57	5	9	10	4				7th
F														

MICHIGAN		RANK	
Scoring Defense	20.4 ppg	29	
Points per Play	0.31	29	
Total Defense	323 ypg	23	
Yards per Play	4.9	24	
3rd Down Conv%	38%	53	
Rushing Defense	112 ypg	20	
Yards per Carry	3.4	19	
Negative Play %	9%	44	
Explosive Rush	5.3	33	
Passing Defense	211 ypg	54	
Yards / Attempt	6.5	37	
QB Rating	125	45	
Completion %	63.6%	92	
Explosive Pass	4.9	39	
Return. Production	55%	55	
Returning Snaps	11,782	41	
MICHIGAN		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		17	
Rushing Offense	1.6	5	
Passing Offense	(8.4)	57	
Defense Overall		18	
Rushing Defense	0.9	19	
Passing Defense	15.9	18	

a freshman, Blake Frazier stepped up and thrived at left tackle. Original starter Evan Link may shift inside to guard after Frazier's strong play. Andrew Babalola was a five-star 2025 signee who was also battling for a job but was injured last fall camp.

The receiver room was plagued with dropped passes, but halfway through the season true freshman Andrew Marsh emerged as an instant star. Marsh got Big Ten honors after posting 45 catches for 651 yards – all after September. The staff signed the #5 receiver transfer JJ Buchanan who started as a freshman for Utah last year. Marsh and Buchanan are the proven one-two punch, and two additional blue-chippers add to the rotation with Top200 freshman Travis Johnson and Top50 Jaime Ffrench (Texas). This is a young room but has sky-high potential.

Michigan loses their do-it-all Max Bredeson as well as tight end Marlin Klein. Zack Marshall moves up as the full-time starter after 16 catches last year.

DEFENSE

Whittingham hired BYU's Jay Hill to lead the defense. Hill took over a broken BYU defense and after a rebuilding season, his last two ranked #15 and #24 in my opponent-adjusted ranking.

This will look just like Utah's aggressive 4-2-5 base, as Whittingham notes that Hill "is from my coaching tree and played in our scheme."

Michigan's had consistent success on this side of the ball with five straight Top 20 units. They return an elite corner duo but lose their top four linebackers and both All-Big Ten defensive linemen.

The staff brought three impact starters with them from the Utah defense including first-team All-American John Henry Daley who was leading the nation in sacks at the time of his Week 11 injury. He should be back for fall camp and will pick up the pass rush role from the departing Derrick Moore. Utah's starting tackle Jonah Lea'ea joins Trey Pierce on the interior. Veteran Cameron Brandt was the third end last year, and this room was pumped with four Top100 freshmen: Titan Davis, Alister Vallejo, Nate Marshall (2025) and five-star Carter Meadows.

It's a complete restart at linebacker as the All-Big Ten trio of Jimmy Rolder, Ernest Hausmann, and Jaishawn Barham are all gone. Even worse, their backer of the future Cole Sullivan transferred out to Oklahoma. Redshirt freshman Nathaniel Owusu-Boateng was a Top200 prospect and could start alongside FCS standout Nathaniel Staehling (North Dakota State).

Whittingham says they will be in nickel 90% of snaps, and they are fully loaded with an all-league corner pair of Zeke Berry and Jyaire Hill joined by Utah's Smith Snowden at the nickel. Snowden was graded a four-star transfer, was second-team All-Big 12 and the staff even used him on offense with 21 touches for 100 yards. Three-time captain Rod Moore is back at safety but has not had a full healthy season since 2023. The other safety spot is open for either Chris Bracy (Memphis) or a wildcard in near-five-star athlete Salesi Moa who brings 10.7 sprinter speed and was getting receiver reps in the spring game.

OUTLOOK

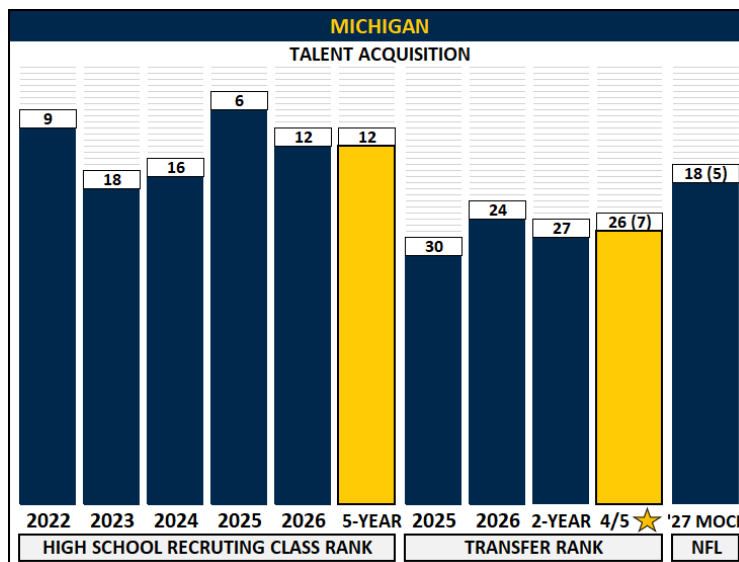
It's all about Underwood's development, scheme fit, and whether he gets a second-year starter bonus. There are few concerns across the rest of the roster, Whittingham and Beck are coaching upgrades, and they brought several all-conference stars with them from Utah.

Even through the coaching transition, Michigan remains in the Big Ten top five, and could push higher if Underwood lives up to his five-star billing.

MICHIGAN	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 5	W. MICHIGAN
S. 12	OKLAHOMA
S. 19	UTEP
S. 26	IOWA
O. 3	@ Minnesota
O. 10	--- BYE ---
O. 17	PENN STATE
O. 24	INDIANA
O. 31	@ Rutgers
N. 7	MICHIGAN STATE
N. 14	@ Oregon
N. 21	UCLA
N. 28	@ Ohio State

MICHIGAN		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	1021	1	
All-Time Win %	0.732	4	
Wins (Last 100)	759	7	
Wins (Last 50)	446	5	
Wins (Last 25)	216	10	
Wins (Last 10)	96	7	
Wins (Last 5)	57	4	
Game Grader (10 yr)	67.6	7	
Game Grader (5 yr)	71.3	6	
Game Grader (3 yr)	65.5	10	
Draft Picks s' 2000	141	7	
Draft Picks s' 2010	95	6	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		17	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		23	

MICHIGAN		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
58.7 (26)	49.5 (40)	88.4 (2)	83.2 (2)	76.9 (4)	36.9 (56)	67.1 (14)	76.5 (4)	59.3 (24)	79.2 (4)	67.6 (7)	





WASHINGTON

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#6(TIE)

BIG TEN

#18

OVERALL



WASHINGTON				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
15		(NC) Michigan		
14		(P) Texas		
13		(CG) Oregon	(B) Louisville	OREGON
12	WASH ST	ARIZONA ST	OREGON	WISCONSIN
11	COLORADO	(B) Texas	PENN ST	MICHIGAN
10	ARIZONA ST	WASH ST	INDIANA	OHIO ST
9	OREGON	COLORADO	IOWA	
8	UCLA	OREGON	RUTGERS	(B) Boise St
7	OREGON ST	OREGON ST	Wash State	PURDUE
6	Michigan	CAL	UCLA	ILLINOIS
5	Montana (FCS)	ARIZONA	USC	RUTGERS
4	STANFORD	STANFORD	MICHIGAN	MARYLAND
3	ARIZONA	Michigan St	N'WESTERN	Wash State
2	CAL	Portland St (FCS)	E. Michigan	UC Davis (FCS)
1	Arkansas St	Kent State	Weber St (FCS)	Colorado St
2021		2022	2023	2024 2025
JIMMY LAKE		KALEN DeBOER		JEDD FISCH

WASHINGTON				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
COLORADO ST W 38-21	244	0	64.6	
UC Davis (FCS) W 70-10	410	1	77.7	
WASH. ST W 59-24	167	3	97.7	
OHIO ST L 6-24	-123	1	26.6	
MARYLAND W 24-20	116	0	55.8	
RUTGERS W 38-19	86	0	74.0	
MICHIGAN L 7-24	-168	-3	16.9	
ILLINOIS W 42-25	112	2	95.7	
WISCONSIN L 10-13	45	-2	46.1	
PURDUE W 49-13	239	0	84.4	
UCLA W 48-14	218	1	87.3	
OREGON L 14-26	-109	-2	27.3	
(B) BOISE ST W 38-10	44	4	82.6	
OVERALL: 15th / 68 BIGTEN: 5th / 18 64.4				

WASHINGTON UNIT RANKS		
BIG TEN RANK	NATIONAL	
(of 18)	TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	3	9
RUNNING BACKS	12	
RECEIVERS & TE	6	
OFFENSIVE LINE	7	
DEFENSIVE LINE	6	
LINEBACKERS	4	15
DEFENSIVE BACKS	7	

WASHINGTON	RANK	
Scoring Offense 34.1 ppg	18	
Points per Play 0.53	13	
Total Offense 410 ypg	39	
Yards per Play 6.4	22	
Rushing Offense 165 ypg	58	
Yards per Carry 4.6	44	
O-Line Run Push 4.7	17	
Explosive Rush 6.8	27	
Passing Offense 245 ypg	52	
Yards / Attempt 8.6	16	
QB Rating 160	10	
TD / INT Ratio 3.3	25	
Sacks / Attempt 9%	115	
Explosive Pass 8.8	19	
Return. Production 69%	13	
Returning Snaps 12,156	37	
26.6 SECONDS/PLAY #35 of 68 P4		
FISCH (2025 WASHINGTON)		

Ohio State snapped Washington's 22-game home win streak in Husky Stadium, and then Maryland jumped out to a 20-0 lead the next week. In danger of an 0-2 league start in Jedd Fisch's second season, Washington flipped the switch.

Over their final four drives Washington gained 300 yards and scored 24 points, and held Maryland scoreless, to lead the massive fourth-quarter comeback win. The offense exploded by scoring 38+ points in their other four Big Ten wins, and former Purdue head coach Ryan Walters led an improved defense.

It was a strong, balanced season with Washington placing in the Top 20 of both my opponent-adjusted offense and defense rankings – plus a #15 finish in Game Grader. Only five other programs pulled that off in 2025.

The best part? They pulled off the nine-win season with an extremely young two-deep.

Fisch jump-started the transition in 2024 with a heavy transfer class that featured several of his top Arizona players. But in 2025 and 2026 the focus has shifted to the high school ranks and Washington has now landed back-to-back Top 25 recruiting classes. This 2026 class surged all the way up to #13 nationally – a UW record.

The next step in the program build is unlocking another gear against Playoff-tier opponents. Washington got within a score in the fourth quarter each time but failed to finish in crunch time.

OFFENSE

Demond Williams' stat line shows the contrast. In the nine wins, Williams threw 22 touchdowns and just two picks, but in the four losses he threw three touchdowns to six picks – including the 3-INT meltdown against Michigan. Of course, the stats in wins would be expected to look better. But when comparing the Big Ten quarterbacks, Williams ranked #2 in QB Rating in the "wins only" category, and all the way down at #12 in "losses only."

Still, it was undoubtedly a successful season for his first full year as a starter. In addition to placing fourth in QB Rating, Williams also led Big Ten quarterbacks in rushing with 611 yards. In the Rutgers win, he became just the 16th FBS quarterback to post a 400-yard passing, 100-yard rushing dual-threat game.

After the 2024 bowl game, Fisch called Williams the "face of the program," and after the 2025 bowl win he signed a contract to remain at UW. Two days later, Williams attempted to enter the transfer portal and it appeared headed to a precedent-setting court case, but then ultimately he returned to UW.

With so much talent and production back for 2026, the surprising loss of their star quarterback would have derailed a promising season.

Instead, Williams gets a second-year starter bonus and assuming he takes some steps forward against ranked teams, he could enter the Heisman discussion.

The offensive line improved by 50 spots in my OL Run Push from 2024 to 2025, and now four starters return up front. Left tackle Carver Willis is the lone loss. John Mills earned the starting left guard spot as a true freshman and fittingly earned Freshman All-America honors. The Hatchett brothers are back at center and guard, and right tackle Drew Azzopardi improved in his second season. The staff signed two top linemen to battle for the open left tackle spot in five-star Kodi Greene (Mater Dei, CA) and four-star transfer Kolt Dieterich (Sam Houston).

Denzel Boston was a pure #1 receiver and was selected in the second round. He will be missed, but this room is packed with young talent. As a freshman, Dezmen Roebuck finished #2 with 42 catches for 560 yards and 7 scores, and there are six four-stars competing for spots in the rotation. Chris Lawson and Justice Williams were 2025 signees, and three more Top200's are on their way with Mason James, Jordan Clay, and Trez Davis. The staff signed Bodpegn Miller (Ohio State) who was

WASHINGTON									
OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)									
O	19	26	5	13	63	46	40	25	18
F	26	5	13	63	46	40	25	18	12
F	DOUGHERTY	CARROLL	RYAN GRUBB	JOHN DONOVAN	BUSH HAMDAN	JONATHAN SMITH			19th
2025 2024 2023 2022 2021 2020 2019 2018 2017 2016									
D	WALTERS	BELICHICK	WILLIAM INGE	GREGORY	KWIAT.	LAKE / KWIATKOWSKI			
E	16	26	34	40	15	24	13	11	6
F	26	34	40	15	24	13	11	6	9
									10th

WASHINGTON		RANK	
Scoring Defense	18.7 ppg	15	
Points per Play	0.29	14	
Total Defense	311 ypg	21	
Yards per Play	4.8	18	
3rd Down Conv%	38%	56	
Rushing Defense	100 ypg	12	
Yards per Carry	3.3	15	
Negative Play %	7%	121	
Explosive Rush	4.1	8	
Passing Defense	211 ypg	52	
Yards / Attempt	6.1	17	
QB Rating	118	28	
Completion %	60%	43	
Explosive Pass	4.3	10	
Return. Production	61%	27	
Returning Snaps	13,063	26	

WASHINGTON		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		19	
Rushing Offense	(0.1)	44	
Passing Offense	32.8	5	
Defense Overall		16	
Rushing Defense	1.0	14	
Passing Defense	15.5	20	

a Top200 signee in the 2025 class, along with Kennesaw State's #2 target Christian Moss. And don't forget Rashid Williams who was originally a starter lost to injury in September.

Jonah Coleman went for 1,100 total yards and 17 touchdowns in his final season. When he was injured in November, Adam Mohammed shined with consecutive 100-yard games but he transferred out to California. Former four-star Jordan Washington has top-notch explosiveness but suffered a severe injury in spring and is doubtful. The staff signed another four-star Jayden Limar (Oregon) and Power 4 vet Trey Cooley.

Fisch called Quentin Moore the best blocking tight end he's ever coached. That's a big loss, but top receiving threat Decker DeGraaf returns after placing third on the team with 32 catches and 360 yards. Kade Eldridge missed half the season but returns and should help with the blocking role.

DEFENSE

When Steve Belichick left to coach with his dad at UNC, Fisch hired Ryan Walters and the move paid off. Washington improved from 88th to 15th in rushing yards/carry, remained a strong pass defense, and finished 16th of 68 Power 4 in my overall opponent-adjusted ranking.

There shouldn't be a drop off in 2026 as the back seven remains elite.

The uncertainty lies in the trenches where two starters graduated and another five rotational linemen transferred out to Power 4 programs. Elinneus Davis was the most consistent and he returns as the anchor at nose tackle. The tackle and end spots will be fall camp battles between transfers and incoming blue-chip recruits. Kai McClendon (Mississippi State) played in 12 games as a true freshman but then missed the 2025 season with a knee injury, and Darin Conley was a starter for Ball State. They will compete with a pair of incoming Top200 recruits in Derek Colman-Brusa (Kennedy Catholic, WA) and JD Hill (Mission Viejo, CA).

Zach Durfee graduated but co-sack leader Jacob Lane returns at edge. Two former starters are back from injuries in Isaiah Ward and Russell Davis.

The linebacker room is overflowing with star power and is the strength of the defense. Jacob Manu should push for All-Big Ten, Xe'Ree Alexander surged at the end of the year to finish second with 70 tackles, and Taariq Al-Uqdah was an original starter back from injury. Former Top100 super-recruit Zaydrius Rainey-Sale is a wildcard the staff can use at backer and off the edge on passing downs.

Washington had the tallest corner duo in the nation last year, and even though both Tacario Davis and Ephesians Prysock are out of eligibility, they will remain tall again here with another top duo. Dylan Robinson is a former Top200 who started five games last year as a true freshman, and Emmanuel Karnley (Virginia) was an ACC starter – both are 6'3. Defensive MVP Alex McLaughlin is back at safety after he led the team in tackles and scored on a Pick Six and a fumble return. Rahshawn Clark is back at nickel, and four-star Rylon Dillard-Allen takes over at free safety.

OUTLOOK

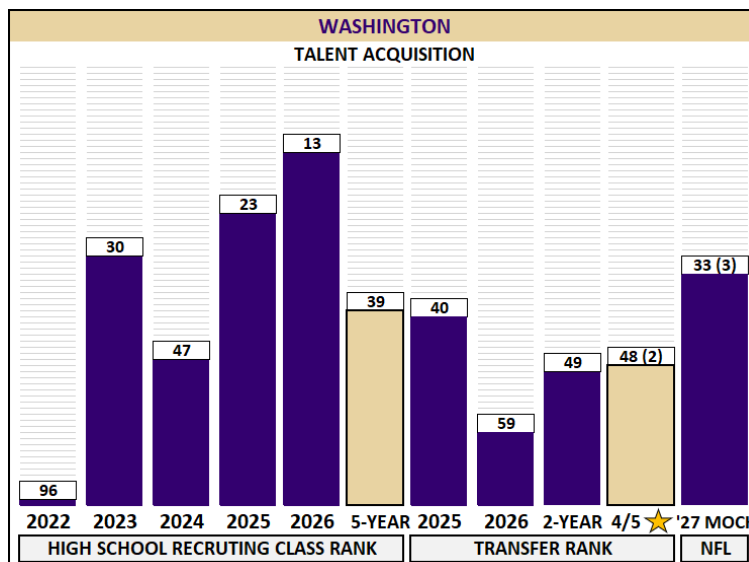
Washington ranked in the Top 20 on both sides of the ball last year -- #15 overall in Game Grader – and did so with a young lineup. Now they return as a veteran two-deep and join a crowded field of contenders for a Big Ten title spot.

Demond Williams is the X-Factor. He is my third-team All-Big Ten selection, and if he can start to shine against ranked teams, Washington can unlock a higher tier.

WASHINGTON		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	789	17	
All-Time Win %	0.619	18	
Wins (Last 100)	640	17	
Wins (Last 50)	379	21	
Wins (Last 25)	170	41	
Wins (Last 10)	87	11	
Wins (Last 5)	44	15	
Game Grader (10 yr)	64.5	10	
Game Grader (5 yr)	58.9	19	
Game Grader (3 yr)	62.2	19	
Draft Picks s' 2000	78	27	
Draft Picks s' 2010	59	19	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		11	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		9	

WASHINGTON		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
64.4 (15)	52.3 (36)	69.8 (12)	67.4 (13)	40.5 (53)	63.4 (17)	64.2 (18)	68.8 (9)	72.8 (12)	80.9 (3)	64.5 (10)	

WASHINGTON	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 6	WASHINGTON ST
S. 12	UTAH STATE
S. 19	E. WASH (FCS)
S. 26	MINNESOTA
O. 3	@ USC
O. 9	IOWA
O. 16	@ Purdue
O. 24	--- BYE ---
O. 31	@ Nebraska
N. 7	PENN STATE
N. 14	@ Michigan State
N. 21	INDIANA
N. 28	@ Oregon



WEEKLY, IN-SEASON FEATURE -- ADVANCED STATS & INFO

SAMPLE PDF, INFO, AND ORDERS AT PICKSIXPREVIEWS.COM/PLUS



PENN STATE

BRETT CIANCIA @PickSixPreviews

#6(TIE)

#20

BIG TEN

OVERALL



PENN STATE 5-YEAR WIN TREND				
16			(P) Notre Dame	
15			(CG) Oregon	
14			OHIO ST	
13	(B) Arkansas	OHIO ST	(B) Ole Miss	INDIANA
12	MICH ST	MICHIGAN	MICHIGAN	OHIO ST
11	MICHIGAN	(B) Utah	(P) Boise St	MARYLAND
10	OHIO ST	MICH ST	(P) SMU	MINNESOTA
9	ILLINOIS	RUTGERS	MARYLAND	N'WESTERN
8	IOWA	MARYLAND	PURDUE	UCLA
7	RUTGERS	INDIANA	WASHINGTON	OREGON
6	MARYLAND	MINNESOTA	WISCONSIN	(B) Clemson
5	INDIANA	N'WESTERN	USC	RUTGERS
4	Villanova (FCS)	C. Michigan	UCLA	NEBRASKA
3	Auburn	Auburn	ILLINOIS	MICH ST
2	Ball State	Ohio	Kent St	Villanova (FCS)
1	WISCONSIN	PURDUE	Delaware (FCS)	FIU
			Bowling Green	Nevada
			West Virginia	
2021 2022 2023 2024 2025				
JAMES FRANKLIN				

PENN STATE				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
NEVADA W 46-11	235	3	78.8	
FIU W 34-0	119	2	76.4	
Villanova (FCS) W 52-6	286	1	75.8	
OREGON L 24-30	-148	-1	32.3	
UCLA L 37-42	-78	-1	25.9	
N'WESTERN L 21-22	-8	-1	43.9	
IOWA L 24-25	-47	-1	53.2	
OHIO ST L 14-38	-280	0	8.2	
INDIANA L 24-27	10	-1	56.3	
MICHIGAN ST W 28-10	138	1	77.8	
NEBRASKA W 37-10	94	0	86.8	
RUTGERS W 40-36	-24	1	49.3	
(B) CLEMSON W 22-10	161	0	92.5	
OVERALL: 27th / 68 BIGTEN: 8th / 18 58.3				

PENN STATE		UNIT RANKS	
BIG TEN RANK		NATIONAL	
(of 18)		TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	5	13	
RUNNING BACKS	7		
RECEIVERS & TE	5		
OFFENSIVE LINE	8		
DEFENSIVE LINE	10		
LINEBACKERS	6		
DEFENSIVE BACKS	8		

PENN STATE	RANK	
Scoring Offense	31 ppg	34
Points per Play	0.5	22
Total Offense	362 ypg	85
Yards per Play	5.8	59
Rushing Offense	174 ypg	50
Yards per Carry	4.8	34
O-Line Run Push	4.4	47
Explosive Rush	5.5	59
Passing Offense	188 ypg	105
Yards / Attempt	7.2	67
QB Rating	139	57
TD / INT Ratio	2.3	55
Sacks / Attempt	6%	54
Explosive Pass	6.5	77
Return. Production	50%	78
Returning Snaps	13,263	28
26.6 SECONDS/PLAY #35 of 68 P4		
CAMPBELL (2025 IOWA ST)		

James Franklin was fired despite a 104-45 (.698) overall record at Penn State. By my count, only nine other coaches in college football history were fired with .700+ win percentages at their school.

From the Penn State mindset, 2025 was the year. This was "National Title or Bust."

The school-record 2022 signing class were experienced seniors, they were fresh off a Playoff semifinal appearance, the vast majority of the starting lineup returned, and they added in two of the top coordinators in the sport.

Franklin helped rebuild the program post-sanctions, won a Big Ten title, earned three New Year's Six bowl invites, and made it one throw away from a national title appearance. Still two hurdles blocked his program from reaching the "elite" tier: Top 10 opponents (4-21) and Ohio State (1-10).

So this was it, 2025 was the year to break through. It had to be.

After a 3-0 start, Penn State lost an overtime battle against #6 Oregon in front of a 111,000+ White Out. While it was a gut punch, all team goals were still intact heading into October. But then Penn State lost to a winless, coach-less UCLA team, and then got out-muscled by Northwestern. Per Chris Fallica, they became the first

team ever to lose consecutive games as 20+ point favorites.

The 0-3 start to Big Ten play – in this, the Title or Bust season – was enough for athletic director Pat Kraft to pull the plug and fire Franklin there in October.

His legacy remains positive, after helping return the program to the national stage, bring in an elevated level of recruits, and help secure the \$700 million facilities upgrade. But it was clear that his program plateaued, albeit at an "almost elite" level that most other schools would be ecstatic about.

After a 50+ day coaching search, Penn State surprised with one of the most sought-after coaches in college football: Iowa State's Matt Campbell. He inherited a broken program in Ames but built them into winners. The 2024 team was Iowa State's first-ever double-digit win season, he won Big 12 Coach of the Year three times, and walks away as the school's winningest coach.

Campbell became a popular target in the annual coaching carousel, but he declined the offers one by one over the years. Penn State must have been on his short list. He calls Penn State "one of the blue bloods of college football, and the program's history and tradition are unmatched."

OFFENSE

With a budget that Campbell said was "a fourth" of the top Big 12 spenders, he made up ground with top-notch player development and innovative schemes. Over his whole tenure at Iowa State, they signed just eight four-star commits, but he and his staff were able to develop 16, twice as many, into NFL draft picks.

Campbell brought his offensive coordinator Taylor Mouser with him, along with 13 starters off his 2025 Iowa State team that went 8-4. Mouser gets to run it back with his starting quarterback, workhorse running back, top two receivers, and top two tight ends from last year.

With Drew Allar off to the pros, and Ethan Grunkemeyer following Franklin to Virginia Tech, it's a new quarterback room. Rocco Becht transferred in from Iowa State where he started for three years, showed off elusiveness in the pocket, and had a penchant for late fourth-quarter winning drives. His playing style will remind Penn State fans of Trace McSorley.

Becht enters 2026 as one of the most experienced quarterbacks in Power 4 – second in career yardage and third in passing touchdowns – and brings those years of scheme knowledge. His deep ball is excellent, but he'll need to hit the shorter lay-ups with more consistency. The skillset is a perfect fit for Mouser's offense which establishes a power run game but then takes vertical passing shots more frequently than most.

The record-breaking duo at running back graduated but they left their mark. Kaytron Allen broke the all-time rushing yardage record (4,180) and earned All-American honors while Nicholas Singleton set the all-time touchdown mark (45). The staff brought their two-year starter Carson Hansen, who averaged 100+ yards per game last year and earned All-Big 12 second-team. Hansen is a between-the-tackles workhorse, while bowl game star Quinton Martin and Top100 James Peoples (Ohio State) have home-run explosiveness.

PENN STATE					OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)									
O	31	8	29	17	47	34	15	18	7	5				12th
F	ANDY KOTELNICKI		MIKE YURCICH		CIARROCCA		RICKY RAHNE		JOE MOORHEAD					
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR			
D	KNOWLES	ALLEN	MANNY DIAZ		BRENT PRY									
E	31	3	1	6	9	11	17	16	20	21				
F														

PENN STATE		RANK	
Scoring Defense	20.5 ppg	31	
Points per Play	0.32	38	
Total Defense	327 ypg	25	
Yards per Play	5.2	39	
3rd Down Conv%	41%	87	
Rushing Defense	143 ypg	56	
Yards per Carry	4.1	57	
Negative Play %	10%	24	
Explosive Rush	6.2	55	
Passing Defense	184 ypg	20	
Yards / Attempt	6.5	36	
QB Rating	129	54	
Completion %	62.8%	80	
Explosive Pass	5.5	60	
Return. Production	53%	67	
Returning Snaps	14,299	13	

PENN STATE		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		31	
Rushing Offense	0.5	22	
Passing Offense	18.7	18	
Defense Overall		31	
Rushing Defense	0.3	38	
Passing Defense	4.3	36	

moved Lavar Arrington to the edge.

Tony Rojas is back after his season-ending injury in the Oregon loss, and the captain is joined by the three Iowa State starting backers. Kooper Ebel was a two-year starter at middle backer for ISU, Caleb Bacon was rated a four-star transfer at outside backer, and Cael Brezina packs the two-deep.

Penn State retained their interim head coach Terry Smith, and the move allowed them to keep cornerback Audavion Collins, nickel Zion Tracy, and Daryus Dixon who surged up the depth chart as a true freshman causing two veterans to transfer out. Their top three safeties left, and again, the staff brought three safeties from Ames: Marcus Neal, Jeremiah Cooper and Jamison Patton. Neal is the headliner as a four-star transfer with Big 12 honorable mention, but they are all in new roles due to the scheme change.

OUTLOOK

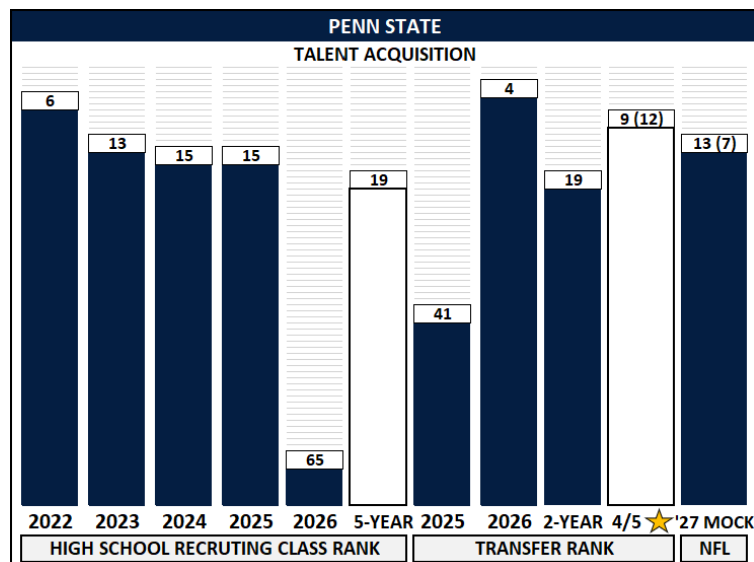
Campbell finally left Iowa State and brought 13 starters with him to Happy Valley. It's a roster transfusion, as most of the 2025 Penn State star power went pro or transferred out.

They get a schedule boost by avoiding the Playoff trio and instead draw five of the bottom seven. The talent level is behind the league's super-recruiters but this favorable schedule keeps Penn State in the race for Indianapolis.

PENN STATE	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 5	MARSHALL
S. 12	@ Temple
S. 19	BUFFALO
S. 26	WISCONSIN
O. 2	@ Northwestern
O. 10	USC
O. 17	@ Michigan
O. 24	--- BYE ---
O. 31	PURDUE
N. 7	@ Washington
N. 14	MINNESOTA
N. 21	RUTGERS
N. 28	@ Maryland

PENN STATE		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	950	7	
All-Time Win %	0.689	8	
Wins (Last 100)	753	9	
Wins (Last 50)	439	7	
Wins (Last 25)	211	14	
Wins (Last 10)	94	8	
Wins (Last 5)	48	8	
Game Grader (10 yr)	67.5	8	
Game Grader (5 yr)	68.5	9	
Game Grader (3 yr)	69.9	8	
Draft Picks s' 2000	123	12	
Draft Picks s' 2010	85	9	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		20	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		25	

PENN STATE		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
58.3 (27)	76.3 (6)	75.2 (7)	75.8 (6)	56.7 (28)	53.3 (29)	65.9 (15)	67.1 (14)	82.5 (6)	63.9 (15)	67.5 (8)	



WEEKLY, IN-SEASON FEATURE -- ADVANCED STATS & INFO

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IOWA

BRETT CIANCIA @PickSixPreviews

#8

BIG TEN

#24

OVERALL



IOWA				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
14 (B) Kentucky	NEBRASKA	(B) Tennessee	(B) Missouri	USC
13 (CG) MICHIGAN	OHIO ST	(CG) MICHIGAN	(CG) MICHIGAN	OREGON
12 WISCONSIN	ILLINOIS	MINNESOTA	UCLA	INDIANA
11 PURDUE	MICHIGAN	PENN ST	MICH ST	Iowa State
10 NEBRASKA	Iowa State	NEBRASKA	OHIO ST	(B) Vanderbilt
9 ILLINOIS	(B) Kentucky	ILLINOIS	Iowa State	NEBRASKA
8 MINNESOTA	MINNESOTA	RUTGERS	NEBRASKA	MICH ST
7 N'WESTERN	WISCONSIN	N'WESTERN	MARYLAND	MINNESOTA
6 PENN ST	PURDUE	WISCONSIN	WISCONSIN	PENN ST
5 MARYLAND	N'WESTERN	MICH ST	N'WESTERN	WISCONSIN
4 Colorado St	RUTGERS	W. Michigan	WASHINGTON	RUTGERS
3 Kent State	Nevada	Iowa State	MINNESOTA	UMass
2 Iowa State	SoDak St (FCS)	Utah State	Troy	Albany (FCS)
1 INDIANA			Illinois St (FCS)	
2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
KIRK FERENTZ				

IOWA				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
Albany (FCS) W 34-7	181	-1	64.8	
IOWA ST L 13-16	-24	0	41.6	
UMASS W 47-7	316	0	75.8	
RUTGERS W 38-28	-54	1	57.0	
INDIANA L 15-20	-53	-1	43.7	
WISCONSIN W 37-0	110	2	100.5	
PENN ST W 25-24	47	1	68.3	
MINNESOTA W 41-3	141	3	100.5	
OREGON L 16-18	-134	-1	45.1	
USC L 21-26	-40	-1	41.8	
MICHIGAN ST W 20-17	-34	-1	42.5	
NEBRASKA W 40-16	79	0	81.5	
(B) VANDERBILT W 34-27	-19	-1	69.1	
OVERALL: 16th / 68	BIGTEN: 6th / 18		64.0	

IOWA	UNIT RANKS	
BIG TEN RANK (of 18)	NATIONAL	TOP 15
QUARTERBACK	17	
RUNNING BACKS	9	
RECEIVERS & TE	8	
OFFENSIVE LINE	3	5
DEFENSIVE LINE	9	
LINEBACKERS	7	
DEFENSIVE BACKS	6	

IOWA	RANK	
Scoring Offense	29.3 ppg	54
Points per Play	0.48	28
Total Offense	320 ypg	119
Yards per Play	5.3	102
Rushing Offense	177 ypg	42
Yards per Carry	4.6	50
O-Line Run Push	4.4	42
Explosive Rush	4.8	90
Passing Offense	143 ypg	129
Yards / Attempt	6.5	103
QB Rating	126	90
TD / INT Ratio	1.5	96
Sacks / Attempt	6%	79
Explosive Pass	6.5	80
Return. Production	48%	84
Returning Snaps	6,784	101
30.4 SECONDS/PLAY #66 of 68 P4		
LESTER (2025 IOWA)		SLOW

Not counting the shortened 2020 pandemic season, Iowa notched its tenth straight eight-win season to join very elite company: Alabama, Georgia, Ohio State. That's it.

"Eight wins doesn't make headlines... it's hard to win, it's hard to win in college... I'm proud of the consistency," said head coach Kirk Ferentz who in September became the Big Ten's all-time winningest coach with 206 career wins.

Two things stood out about this 2025 eight-win regular season. Iowa thoroughly destroyed their old Big Ten West rivals, but came up just short against their ranked opponents.

Wisconsin dominated the division during the 2010s, but it is clear that Iowa has now taken the throne. They swept their border state rivals Minnesota, Nebraska, and Wisconsin by a combined score of 118-19 and extended their recent series dominance: 10 of the last 11 over Nebraska, 10 of the last 11 over Minnesota, and now four straight over Wisconsin.

They were also painfully close to knocking off their ranked opponents.

Iowa was tied or held leads in the final two minutes in three losses, blew a 14-point lead in the fourth one, gave eventual national champion Indiana its closest battle, and had semifinalist Oregon on the ropes.

Four ranked opponents, four losses by a combined 15 points. Though there are no moral victories, from a metrics perspective my Game Grader formula was impressed and ranked Iowa #16 – a five-year high for the program.

In the bowl game, Iowa was given one last ranked shot and beat #14 Vanderbilt, along with Heisman finalist Diego Pavia, to finally snap the 13-game losing streak against ranked teams.

OFFENSE

They did it the Iowa way: defense, special teams and a power run game.

Mark Gronowski was an upgrade at quarterback. The FCS national champion missed preseason due to injuries, which slowed his passing progression early on, but he ended up breaking the school records for quarterback rushing yards (545) and touchdowns (16).

Gronowski tied Michigan's Denard Robinson for the most rushing scores by a Big Ten quarterback in the past 30 years.

Gronowski's mobility helped on third downs and in the red zone, and his 67-yard run made the difference in the Penn State win. Two fourth-down conversions on the final drive gave Iowa a late lead over Oregon.

They lose his veteran presence as coordinator Tim Lester decided to stay in-house for the 2026 quarterback battle. Hank Brown was the original backup but struggled in September spots and Jeremy Hecklinski passed him on the depth chart midseason. Hecklinski showed off a variety of throws and arm angles, has pocket mobility, and Lester called him a "gunslinger."

After finishing 2024 as semifinalists, the 2025 offensive line won the Joe Moore Award. All five starters, plus the blocking tight end, earned Big Ten honors with center Logan Jones winning the Rimington Award as a unanimous All-American. The line was packed with veterans, and three multi-year starters depart for the pros: Jones, guard Beau Stephens, and tackle Gennings Dunker. That trio alone accounted for 110 career starts.

Trevor Lauck and Kade Pieper are returning starters and both should be All-America candidates for 2026. Leighton Jones is a lock at guard, while the other three candidates for starting jobs are former three-star prospects.

Kamari Moulton returns after a workhorse season. He got the bulk of carries with 170 for 878 yards (5.2 average) to earn All-Big Ten honorable mention. Xavier Williams (5.8 per carry) returns, and the staff signed an explosive FCS back in LJ Phillips (South Dakota) who rushed for 1,921 yards with 55 10+ yard carries.

IOWA									
OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)									
O	58	38	68	63	61	36	37	49	44
F									63rd
F	TIM LESTER	BRIAN FERENTZ							DAVIS
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017
D	PHIL PARKER								
E	7	30	3	2	8	4	15	7	27
F									33
									5th

IOWA		RANK
Scoring Defense	16.1 ppg	8
Points per Play	0.27	10
Total Defense	280 ypg	9
Yards per Play	4.7	13
3rd Down Conv%	34%	23
Rushing Defense	108 ypg	17
Yards per Carry	3.5	22
Negative Play %	8%	73
Explosive Rush	4.2	9
Passing Defense	173 ypg	10
Yards / Attempt	6	14
QB Rating	111	11
Completion %	57.8%	24
Explosive Pass	4.7	26
Return. Production	40%	105
Returning Snaps	4,995	116

IOWA		RANK / 68
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play		
Offense Overall		58
Rushing Offense	0.2	34
Passing Offense	(6.5)	52
Defense Overall		7
Rushing Defense	1.0	15
Passing Defense	36.7	1

The starting linebacker trio Karson Sharar, Jaden Harrell, and Jaxon Rexroth departs, though Jayden Montgomery actually took over Harrell's job late in the season. A pair of former four-stars – Cam Buffington and Derek Weisskopf -- are drawing huge praise and could jump up into starting jobs.

The top-rated secondary lost three All-Big Ten starters as corner TJ Hall and safety Xavier Nwankpa went pro and Koen Entringer transferred out to Louisville. Zach Lutmer is the star of the defense at the "CASH" position as a nickel/slot corner. Deshaun Lee returns at corner, but the staff went transfer-heavy to fill out the safety room. Tyler Brown (James Madison) was All-Sun Belt on JMU's playoff defense and the hard-hitter should start at strong safety. Anthony Hawkins (Villanova) was an FCS Freshman All-American and has the cover skills to start at free safety.

OUTLOOK

Few programs have built up a track record like Ferentz and Parker at Iowa. Even with another round of draft picks departing, you know what to expect: a powerful offensive line, elite tight end room, workhorse running back, a swarming defense, and nation-best special teams.

While this is a younger two-deep than usual, and low on transfer additions, Iowa will remain in the Big Ten upper half until proven otherwise.

IOWA		RANK / 68
All-Time Wins	711	34
All-Time Win %	0.548	43
Wins (Last 100)	545	46
Wins (Last 50)	368	23
Wins (Last 25)	209	15
Wins (Last 10)	86	12
Wins (Last 5)	45	13
Game Grader (10 yr)	57.9	19
Game Grader (5 yr)	54.3	26
Game Grader (3 yr)	55.1	29
Draft Picks s' 2000	101	17
Draft Picks s' 2010	68	16
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		10
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		6

Iowa loses their blocking tight end Hayden Large but they return a talented trio. DJ Vonnahme led the entire team in receiving yards and touchdowns as a freshman, had a breakout performance in the bowl game, and looks to continue Iowa's "Tight End U" lineage. Addison Ostrenga and Zach Ortwerth round out a top-notch room.

Three of the top four receivers are gone including consistent two-year starter Jacob Gill, do-it-all Kaden Wetjen, and Sam Phillips. Wetjen leaves as one of the best return specialists in college football history and was the first to win consecutive Jet Awards. He was a weapon on special teams but also got carries on reverses and end-arounds.

Reece Vander Zee returns and has the size and athleticism to be the #1 target. Iowa signed a pair of FCS Freshman All-Americans in Evan James (Furman) and Tony Diaz (UTRGV). They combined for 1,677 yards and 18 touchdowns last year and both add a vertical, explosive element to the pass game.

DEFENSE

Legendary coordinator Phil Parker delivered yet another Top 10 defense. Iowa finished #7 of 68 Power 4 in my opponent-adjusted ranking – Top 10 for the sixth time in eight years.

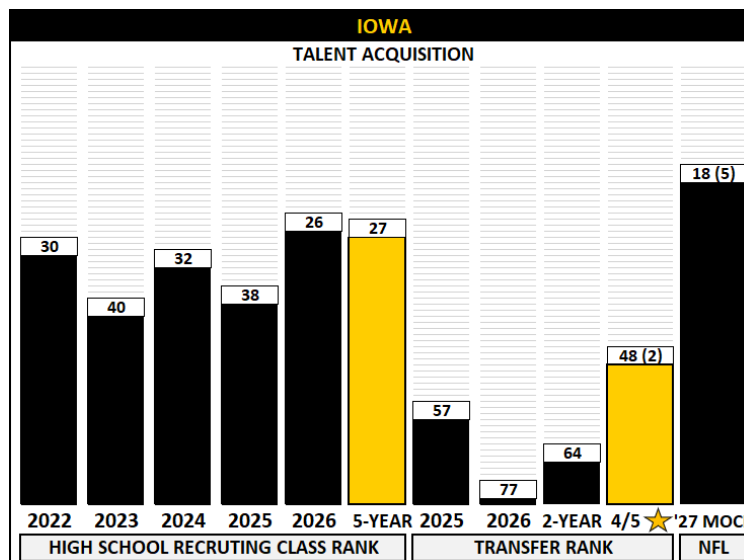
The pass defense was elite again and ranked #1 in my opponent-adjusted number, holding top passing attacks like Indiana, Oregon, and USC all well below their season averages.

There is a significant rebuilding project on this side of the ball heading into 2026. Iowa had eight defenders earn All-Big Ten honors, but seven are gone. 11 of the top 14 tacklers depart, two transferred out to Power 4 programs, but the staff went FCS-heavy with as many as three new starters coming from the lower level.

Six of the top eight defensive linemen are gone including all-league stars Aaron Graves, Jonah Pace, and Max Llewellyn. Bryce Hawthorne and end Kenneth Merrieweather return from the rotation, and two FCS transfers will compete for starting jobs. Brice Stevenson (Holy Cross) was a three-year starter as an interior space-eater, while Kahmari Brown (Elon) had 12 sacks last year off the edge. Five-star Iose Epenesa may be poised for a breakthrough in his second season.

IOWA	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 5	N. ILLINOIS
S. 12	IOWA STATE
S. 19	N. IOWA (FCS)
S. 26	@ Michigan
O. 3	OHIO STATE
O. 9	@ Washington
O. 17	--- BYE ---
O. 24	@ Minnesota
O. 31	WISCONSIN
N. 7	@ Northwestern
N. 14	PURDUE
N. 21	@ Illinois
N. 27	NEBRASKA

IOWA				GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)						
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR
64 (16)	56.7 (29)	44.7 (41)	52.5 (34)	53.7 (32)	69.9 (10)	62.9 (20)	66.7 (15)	57.3 (26)	50.7 (35)	57.9 (19)



WEEKLY, IN-SEASON FEATURE -- ADVANCED STATS & INFO

SAMPLE PDF, INFO, AND ORDERS AT PICKSIXPREVIEWS.COM/PLUS

WISCONSIN					
5-YEAR WIN TREND					
13	MINNESOTA	MINNESOTA	(B) LSU		
12	MICHIGAN	IOWA	N'WESTERN	MINNESOTA	MINNESOTA
11	Notre Dame	MICH ST	INDIANA	NEBRASKA	INDIANA
10	PENN ST	ILLINOIS	OHIO ST	OREGON	OREGON
9	(B) Arizona St	OHIO ST	IOWA	IOWA	OHIO ST
8	NEBRASKA	Wash St	Wash St	PENN ST	IOWA
7	N'WESTERN	(B) Okla St	MINNESOTA	USC	MICHIGAN
6	RUTGERS	NEBRASKA	NEBRASKA	Alabama	MARYLAND
5	IOWA	MARYLAND	ILLINOIS	N'WESTERN	Alabama
4	PURDUE	PURDUE	RUTGERS	RUTGERS	ILLINOIS
3	Army	N'WESTERN	PURDUE	PURDUE	WASHINGTON
2	ILLINOIS	NM State	GA Southern	S. Dakota (FCS)	Middle Tenn
1	E. Michigan	IL State (FCS)	Buffalo	W. Michigan	Miami (OH)
	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
	PAUL CHRYST		LUKE FICKELL		

WISCONSIN				
2025 RESULTS		Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE
MIAMI (OH)	W 17-0	236	1	73.2
MIDDLE TENN.	W 42-10	195	-1	71.5
ALABAMA	L 14-38	-245	-2	65.2
MARYLAND	L 10-27	-30	-1	19.5
MICHIGAN	L 10-24	-193	-1	17.4
IOWA	L 0-37	-110	-2	7.8
OHIO ST	L 0-34	-347	-1	2.1
OREGON	L 7-21	-139	-1	25.0
WASHINGTON	W 13-10	-45	2	63.0
INDIANA	L 7-31	-220	-2	8.3
ILLINOIS	W 27-10	3	0	83.0
MINNESOTA	L 7-17	50	-3	34.1
OVERALL: 60th / 68		BIGTEN: 16th / 18		34.2

WISCONSIN		UNIT RANKS
BIG TEN RANK		NATIONAL
(of 18)		TOP 15
QUARTERBACK	10	
RUNNING BACKS	10	
RECEIVERS & TE	13	
OFFENSIVE LINE	11	
DEFENSIVE LINE	13	
LINEBACKERS	5	
DEFENSIVE BACKS	12	

WISCONSIN		RANK
Scoring Offense	12.8 ppg	135
Points per Play	0.22	134
Total Offense	253 ypg	135
Yards per Play	4.4	135
Rushing Offense	117 ypg	116
Yards per Carry	3.3	128
O-Line Run Push	3.7	129
Explosive Rush	2.8	134
Passing Offense	136 ypg	132
Yards / Attempt	6	127
QB Rating	110	128
TD / INT Ratio	0.7	135
Sacks / Attempt	10%	126
Explosive Pass	4.4	130
Return. Production	61%	45
Returning Snaps	9,664	66


30.5 SECONDS/PLAY #67 of 68 P4
GRIMES (2025 WISCONSIN) SLOW

Not even the biggest doubters could have envisioned a 5-7 year in Luke Fickell's second season here. Even fewer would have seen a 4-8 third year.

The losing season in 2024 snapped their FBS-best 22-year bowl streak, and last year's collapse marked Wisconsin's first consecutive losing seasons since 1991-92. That was before Barry Alvarez built Wisconsin into Offensive Line U and the eventual Big Ten West bullies.

Considered by most as the top hire of the post-2022 coaching carousel, Fickell now ranks *dead last* of the 10 Power 4 hires, when comparing the three-year output to the four-year sample size before the hire for program context.

Sitting at 2-6 in mid-November, and despite fans in Camp Randall Stadium chanting “Fire Fickell,” athletic director Chris McIntosh issued a vote of confidence in his head coach and confirmed they would retain him for 2026.

Two days later, Wisconsin upset #23 Washington, snapped Fickell's 0-10 record against ranked opponents, and fans stormed onto the field to celebrate. Seven weeks later, with another field storming after Wisconsin knocked off #21

celebrate. Same thing two weeks later, with another field storming after Wisconsin knocked off #21 Illinois.

The ranked wins could help spark some momentum into Fickell's fourth year, but the returns from his first three are hard to ignore. It's the second straight year in which their rivalry trophy case is empty. He's 17-21 overall – 10-17 vs. the Big Ten – with a drop in the win column each year.

Any momentum from the ranked wins did not translate into the Talent Acquisition game. Wisconsin signed 33 transfers – zero four-stars – to rank 49th nationally and 13th in the Big Ten. Worse, they were unable to retain several veteran multi-year starters.

Wisconsin's best decades were built on continuity and player development. So far without their old formula, they have not been able to adapt to the NIL/Portal era.

OFFENSE

4.2 On the third play of the season, starting quarterback Billy Edwards was injured and essentially knocked out for the year. Backup Danny O'Neil threw as many picks as touchdowns and was injured in the fourth game. The collapse of the quarterback room was the catalyst for a broken offense that averaged just 12 points/game -- the worst in Power 4.

It was déjà vu for Wisconsin. 2025 made it three straight years of transfer starting quarterbacks getting injured early in the season. Without a passing threat, this time around they couldn't even muster up their reliable rushing attack that defined the program for 20+ years. Wisconsin averaged just 3.3 yards/carry (#128), got no run push from the line (#129), and it took until the 11th game to finally get a 100-yard rusher.

Fickell hopes the fourth time is the charm, and they signed Colton Joseph (Old Dominion) who earned second-team All-Sun Belt honors last year. Joseph is a true dual-threat, and adds a mobile element that the program has been missing. He rushed for over 1,000 yards last year, including a pair of 75-yard touchdown runs against Indiana, and is a threat in read option and quarterback-designed runs.

In two years, Joseph amassed 4,200 passing yards, 1,600 rushing yards, 56 total touchdowns and was ranked the #21 transfer quarterback this cycle. O'Neil should be back in time for fall camp, and Carter Smith also returns after stepping up as a true freshman last November.

The top two running backs missed seven games due to injury and combined for just 663 yards. Dilyn Jones transferred out to LSU, but lead rusher Darriion Dupree returns. The staff signed veteran Abu Sama (Iowa State) who has accumulated 1,933 rushing yards in his three seasons. He went for 270 yards in the infamous 2024 “Snowmageddon” game.

Receivers and tight ends actually got 48 carries for 260 yards last year but the staff mentioned they want a running back rotation for 2026. With Dupree and Sama, plus USC transfer Bryan Jackson, there are plenty of options.

Vinny Anthony and Trech Kekahuna got the vast majority of snaps and catches last year but both are gone. Backup Chris Brooks moves up the depth chart, the staff kept four-star Eugene Hilton away from

	WISCONSIN					OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)						
O												
F	63	53	38	31	37	58	9	10	13	33	32nd	
F	GRIMES		PHIL LONGO		ENGRAM	JOE RUDOLPH						
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
D	MIKE TRESSSEL			JIM LEONHARD							WILCOX	
F	26	40	30	18	3	14	12	40	7	16	13th	

WISCONSIN		RANK	
Scoring Defense	21.6 ppg	40	
Points per Play	0.36	60	
Total Defense	324 ypg	24	
Yards per Play	5.4	56	
3rd Down Conv%	38%	59	
Rushing Defense	105 ypg	15	
Yards per Carry	3.4	18	
Negative Play %	9%	49	
Explosive Rush	5.1	27	
Passing Defense	218 ypg	62	
Yards / Attempt	7.6	105	
QB Rating	149	120	
Completion %	69.8%	135	
Explosive Pass	5.5	57	
Return. Production	57%	46	
Returning Snaps	9,294	73	

WISCONSIN		RANK / 68
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play		
Offense Overall		63
Rushing Offense	(0.3)	47
Passing Offense	(18.2)	66
Defense Overall		26
Rushing Defense	1.2	12
Passing Defense	(2.0)	50

Their top four defensive linemen, top four outside backers, and five of the top six defensive backs are all gone. In the interior, All-MAC Junior Poyser (Buffalo) and Charles Perkins are the projected starters. There is more proven experience on the ends with Tyreese Fearbry and Sebastian Cheeks who was second on the team in QB pressures last year. The staff signed a roulette chip with Liam Danitz, a DIII transfer with All-America track speed.

The secondary should be transfer-heavy with as many as four starting spots going to newcomers. Javan Robinson (Arizona State) is a certainty, having started the past two years in the Big 12. Eric Fletcher (Oklahoma State) and a pair of former four-stars Cai Bates (Florida State) and Bryce West (Ohio State) will battle at corner and nickel. Marvin Burks (Missouri) brings SEC game experience at safety, and Matthew Jung returns after filling in well last season.

OUTLOOK

Quarterback injuries have handcuffed the offense the past three seasons. Fickell signed a proven, all-league dual-threat in Joseph whose skillset will elevate the other position groups. The quarterback fix – from meltdown to proven asset – plus a schedule boost will have Wisconsin returning to bowl season.

After facing one of the hardest schedules, Wisconsin wins the schedule lottery by drawing six of the bottom seven and avoiding the Playoff trio.

the portal, and Tyrell Henry drew high praise in spring. They signed Oklahoma State starter Shamar Rigby as a playmaker in the slot, and then took lottery tickets on a pair of former Top100 recruits Malachi Coleman (Minnesota) and Zion Kearney (Oklahoma).

Tight end Lance Mason led the team with 398 receiving yards, but he and two other tight ends are gone. Grant Stec flashed as a freshman before his injury, and Jacob Harris (Bowling Green) caught five touchdowns last year.

Wisconsin hired Eric Mateos to take over the offensive line. Mateos and coordinator Jeff Grimes were together at Baylor with his “RVO” Reliably Violent Offense. Last year at Arkansas, Mateos’ line helped them land the #1 rushing offense in my opponent-adjusted ranking.

Two starters return in Colin Cubberly and Emerson Mandell, but they lost two others to the portal with Joe Brunner going to Indiana with a high four-star grade and Jake Renfro going to Illinois. Kevin Heywood was originally a projected 2025 starter but tore his ACL last preseason. He is back at left tackle, and the staff added three Power 4 transfers: Blake Cherry (Arkansas), PJ Wilkins (Ole Miss) and Oklahoma State starting center Austin Kawecki.

DEFENSE

The defense held the explosive offenses of Washington and Illinois to just 10 points apiece, and finished ranked #26 in my opponent-adjusted ranking -- #10 against the run. They just didn’t have any help at all from the offense.

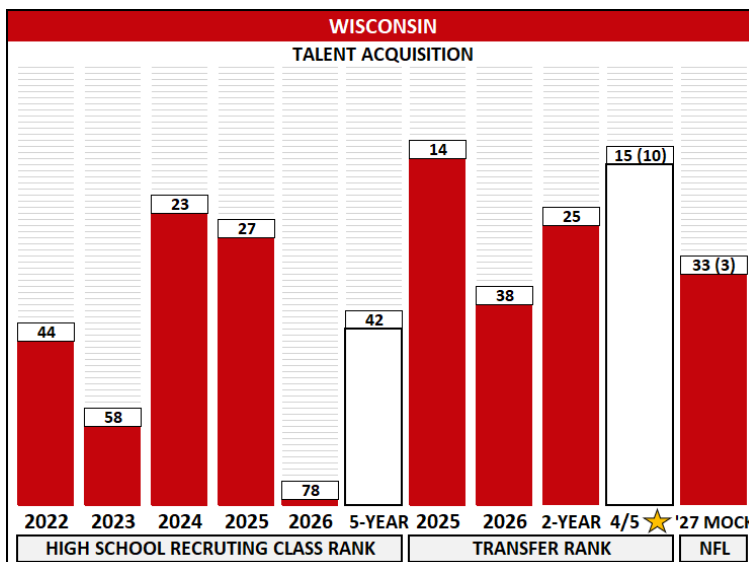
“You start to feel like a touchdown is the end-all, be-all” said outside backer Mason Reiger. One touchdown is an insane bar that they were forced to hit.

Just three starters return and it starts in the middle with last year’s freshmen phenoms Mason Posa and Cooper Catalano. The inside backers finished first and second in tackles (117 and 6 sacks combined) with Posa earning All-Big Ten honors. Both return, along with incoming Jon Jon Kamara (Kansas) but two veterans transferred out to Power 4 programs: Christian Alliegro (Ohio State) and Tackett Curtis (UCF).

WISCONSIN	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 6	*NOTRE DAME (GB)
S. 12	W. ILLINOIS (FCS)
S. 19	E. MICHIGAN
S. 26	@ Penn State
O. 3	MICHIGAN STATE
O. 10	--- BYE ---
O. 17	@ UCLA
O. 24	USC
O. 31	@ Iowa
N. 7	RUTGERS
N. 14	@ Maryland
N. 21	@ Purdue
N. 27	MINNESOTA

WISCONSIN		RANK / 68
All-Time Wins	751	23
All-Time Win %	0.582	28
Wins (Last 100)	571	37
Wins (Last 50)	359	25
Wins (Last 25)	215	11
Wins (Last 10)	78	20
Wins (Last 5)	32	46
Game Grader (10 yr)	59.1	16
Game Grader (5 yr)	49.2	37
Game Grader (3 yr)	42.5	58
Draft Picks s' 2000	100	18
Draft Picks s' 2010	56	23
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		62
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		54

WISCONSIN		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
34.2 (60)	42 (53)	51.3 (37)	52.3 (35)	66.4 (11)	56.9 (26)	75.3 (7)	60 (22)	83.3 (5)	69.1 (11)	59.1 (16)	



WEEKLY, IN-SEASON FEATURE -- ADVANCED STATS & INFO

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NEBRASKA

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#10(TIE) #37

BIG TEN OVERALL



NEBRASKA				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
13				
12	IOWA	WISCONSIN	IOWA	(B) Utah
11	WISCONSIN	MICHIGAN	USC	IOWA
10	OHIO ST	MINNESOTA	UCLA	PENN ST
9	PURDUE	ILLINOIS	OHIO ST	USC
8	MINNESOTA	PURDUE	INDIANA	MINNESOTA
7	MICHIGAN	Oklaoma	ILLINOIS	MICHIGAN
6	MICH ST	Ga Southern	(B) Boston Coll	UCLA
5	Oklaoma	N'WESTERN	WISCONSIN	N'WESTERN
4	ILLINOIS	IOWA	RUTGERS	MARYLAND
3	N'WESTERN	RUTGERS	PURDUE	MICH ST
2	Buffalo	INDIANA	N. Iowa (FCS)	Houston C. (FCS)
1	Fordham (FCS)	N. Dakota (FCS)	Colorado	Akron
		N. Illinois	UTEP	Cincinnati
	2021	2022	2023	2024
	2025			
	SCOTT FROST		MATT RHULE	

NEBRASKA				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
CINCINNATI W 20-17	82	2	56.8	
AKRON W 68-0	553	0	81.5	
Houston C. (FCS) W 59-7	394	2	77.7	
MICHIGAN L 27-30	-40	0	46.7	
MICHIGAN ST W 38-27	21	2	65.2	
MARYLAND W 34-31	88	-3	50.0	
MINNESOTA L 6-24	-126	0	17.1	
N'WESTERN W 28-21	-35	0	54.2	
USC L 17-21	-51	0	42.8	
UCLA W 28-21	13	0	53.5	
PENN ST L 10-37	-94	0	18.0	
IOWA L 16-40	-79	0	20.3	
(B) UTAH L 22-44	-192	-1	13.2	
OVERALL: 45th / 68	BIGTEN: 11th / 18		45.9	

NEBRASKA	UNIT RANKS
BIG TEN RANK (of 18)	NATIONAL TOP 15
QUARTERBACK	7
RUNNING BACKS	16
RECEIVERS & TE	9
OFFENSIVE LINE	9
DEFENSIVE LINE	11
LINEBACKERS	13
DEFENSIVE BACKS	14

NEBRASKA	RANK
Scoring Offense 28.7 ppg	59
Points per Play 0.45	43
Total Offense 371 ypg	82
Yards per Play 5.8	57
Rushing Offense 146 ypg	80
Yards per Carry 4.2	82
O-Line Run Push 4.4	39
Explosive Rush 4.7	95
Passing Offense 225 ypg	68
Yards / Attempt 7.7	41
QB Rating 150	25
TD / INT Ratio 3.3	22
Sacks / Attempt 9%	112
Explosive Pass 7.3	48
Return. Production 69%	14
Returning Snaps 16,499	9
27.7 SECONDS/PLAY #50 of 68 P4	
HOLGORSSEN (2025 NEBRASKA)	

Matt Rhule was hired to improve Nebraska's player development, their physicality on the lines of scrimmage, and then cash in with his usual third-year breakthrough.

2025 was Rhule's third season, but there was no breakthrough. Far from it.

Nebraska entered 2025 on a 10-35 run in one-score games, and they were able to notch a few close wins like the 20-17 opener over Cincinnati, a roller-coaster 34-31 win over Maryland, and touchdown decisions over UCLA and Northwestern. It was enough to punch a ticket to bowl season.

But Nebraska has been waiting for a signature, ranked win on the national stage. They had two opportunities last season, both in Lincoln, but lost to Michigan and USC by a combined seven points. They have now lost 30 straight against ranked teams – second-worst behind Rutgers' drought – and while the run started before Rhule, he has personally lost 20 straight including his Baylor tenure.

There was no breakthrough in the trenches. Michigan sacked quarterback Dylan Raiola seven times, Minnesota set a school-record with nine sacks, and the defensive line finished #114 against the run.

Player development? Nebraska is second-worst in the Big Ten with just three NFL draft picks (2024-2026) despite signing Top 25 recruiting classes most years.

Rhule's November record fell to 2-10 after consecutive blowout losses at Penn State 37-10 and then a 40-16 loss to Iowa for the 10th time in 11 years. In the bowl game, they were outgained by 200 yards and lost to Utah 44-22.

Part of the Rhule era breakthrough was supposed to be five-star Raiola, but he shocked Husker Nation and transferred out to Oregon. There were other factors at play – weather, their March Madness run – but it was still shocking to see Memorial Stadium empty for their annual Red-White spring game. Was it a Rhule Referendum? *HuskerOnline's* Steven Sipple noticed it: "Nebraska needs a boost to fan enthusiasm now more than I can ever remember, and I've been covering this since 1995."

OFFENSE

Raiola was injured in the ninth game and freshman TJ Lateef led the UCLA win before the season-ending three-game losing streak. With Raiola gone to Oregon, the staff got a commitment from four-star Notre Dame backup Kenny Minchey but 24 hours later he flipped to Kentucky. Finally, they signed Mountain West Player of the Year, Anthony Colandrea (UNLV).

At UNLV, Colandrea dazzled with 23 passing touchdowns, 10 more rushing scores, and cut down on his 26-20 touchdown-to-pick ratio from his time at Virginia. If there was ever a fit for the term "gunslinger" Colandrea is the definition – he will produce highlight-reel scrambles and off-balance throws but will also turn it over (29 picks and 17 fumbles over three seasons).

Offensive coordinator Dana Holgorsen is intrigued by Colandrea's pocket elusiveness and creativity when the play breaks down. They studied Diego Pavia film of off-script plays, and Colandrea's mobility adds an element missing from Raiola's skillset. Theoretically this will help cut down on the pass protection woes, and even create more downfield explosive plays with the extra few seconds outside the pocket.

Lateef also returns but Colandrea is the focal point of the offense heading into fall camp.

As the pass game began to struggle last season, the staff doubled down on what was working in the run game. Emmett Johnson was the engine of the offense with a 251-carry workload, and he surged for 1,451 yards and earned first-team All-Big Ten. Johnson went pro and leaves behind a wide-open running back room which Rhule decided not to supplement from the transfer portal. It looks like a trio for 2026 with Mekhi Nelson, four-star Isaiah Mozee, and true freshman Jamal Rule who had huge offseason reviews from the staff and scored on a 75-yarder in the spring game.

Dane Key departs but the other two starters Jacory Barney and yardage-leader Nyzhiah Hunter return to the receiver room. Hunter made game-changing plays in three of their wins and could push for All-Big

NEBRASKA					OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)									
O	44	57	42	44	7	35	31	16	22	46				
F														33rd
F	HOLGORSSEN	SATTERFIELD	WHIPPLE	LUBICK	WALTERS	LANGSDORF								
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016				10-YEAR
D	BUTLER	WHITE	BUSCH		CHINANDER		DIACO	BANKER						
E	41	36	18	52	30	39	47	51	65	42				43rd
F														

NEBRASKA		RANK	
Scoring Defense	24.6 ppg	67	
Points per Play	0.41	88	
Total Defense	330 ypg	30	
Yards per Play	5.4	59	
3rd Down Conv%	39%	65	
Rushing Defense	175 ypg	100	
Yards per Carry	4.8	114	
Negative Play %	8%	62	
Explosive Rush	7.5	108	
Passing Defense	154 ypg	3	
Yards / Attempt	6.4	26	
QB Rating	118	27	
Completion %	58.3%	27	
Explosive Pass	5.0	43	
Return. Production	69%	7	
Returning Snaps	11,483	47	

NEBRASKA		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		44	
Rushing Offense	(0.2)	45	
Passing Offense	13.4	26	
Defense Overall		41	
Rushing Defense	(0.4)	62	
Passing Defense	8.2	28	

Ten this season. The staff signed UCLA starter Kwazi Gilmer to replace Key, and the starting trio are experienced former four-stars. Starting tight end Luke Lindenmeyer also returns after a productive 29-catch, 312-yard season that earned him All-Big Ten honorable mention.

Nebraska has patiently waited for an offensive line breakthrough but last year it collapsed in pass protection -- #112 in Sack Rate -- and stunted the pass game. Rhule made a coaching change and hired offensive line guru Geep Wade who just helped build Georgia Tech into one of the sport's strongest lines.

They hit the transfer portal and brought in three experienced Power 4 starters that Wade was familiar with: Paul Mubenga (LSU), Brendan Black (Iowa State), and Tree Babalade (South Carolina). Black earned a four-star transfer grade and started 30 games at guard, Babalade was also a four-star with 15 starts, while Mubenga started 11 at LSU. Nebraska returns two impact starters with center Justin Evans and former five-star left tackle Elijah Pritchett who is developing into a pro prospect.

DEFENSE

Rhule made another coaching change on defense after the Blackshirts were pushed around in the final three games and ultimately finished #41 of 68 Power 4 in my opponent-adjusted rankings -- #62 against the run.

He replaced John Butler with San Diego State's Rob Aurich who helped lead a stat turnaround from #97 to #5 in scoring defense in his only season as their coordinator. Nebraska will shift away from their 3-3-5 scheme to Aurich's 4-2-5. But Rhule was more focused on non-scheme items: "I want player development, I want physicality, I want effort."

The defensive line loses two full-time starters in end Elijah Jeudy and tackle Keona Davis who transferred out to Miami with high four-star grades. Two ends return in Cameron Lenhardt and former five-star Williams Nwaneri. At tackle, the staff added Boston College starter Owen Stoudmire and breakout freshman Jahsear Whittington (Pittsburgh) to join veteran Riley Van Poppel.

Three of the top four linebackers are gone, but Vincent Shavers returns after battling through injuries to post a productive 61-tackle (7.5 for loss) season. Aurich wanted a bigger set of linebackers and they added a pair of 6'3 transfers in Dexter Foster (Oregon State) and Owen Chambliss (San Diego State) who earned first-team All-Mountain West in this scheme.

The secondary played well last year, ranking #3 nationally in pass/yards game, and #28 in my opponent-adjusted passing number. Two All-Big Ten defensive backs are gone but they return one in corner Andrew Marshall. At the other corner spot Nebraska signed five-star Danny Odem (Orlando, FL) and he'll battle spring game starter Jeremiah Charles. Aurich brought his starting safety Dwayne McDougale with him from San Diego State, Jamir Conn will start at the other safety spot, and Donovan Jones moves into the new nickel role. It's worth noting true freshman Odem is the only blue-chipper on the secondary's two-deep as they go through a scheme change.

OUTLOOK

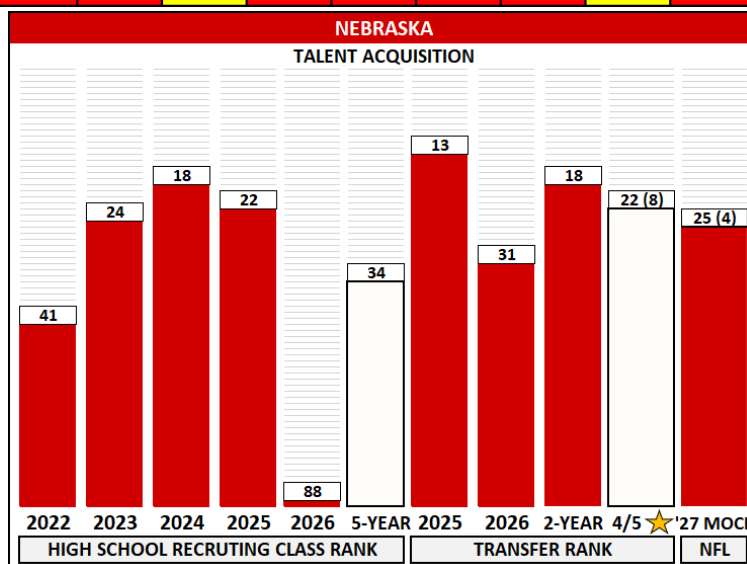
Nebraska hopes that Colandrea's scrambling skillset can help elevate the other positions groups around him. The offensive line's breakthrough still hasn't materialized, and now the defense has a coordinator/scheme change.

Nebraska was #10 in the Big Ten in Game Grader, #11 in my opponent-adjusted yardage margin, and now the schedule heats up as they draw the Playoff trio and six of the league's top ten.

NEBRASKA	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 5	OHIO
S. 12	BOWLING GREEN
S. 19	N. DAKOTA (FCS)
S. 26	@ Michigan State
O. 3	MARYLAND
O. 10	INDIANA
O. 17	@ Oregon
O. 24	--- BYE ---
O. 31	WASHINGTON
N. 6	@ Illinois
N. 14	@ Rutgers
N. 21	OHIO STATE
N. 27	@ Iowa

NEBRASKA		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	931	8	
All-Time Win %	0.676	9	
Wins (Last 100)	730	11	
Wins (Last 50)	436	10	
Wins (Last 25)	178	32	
Wins (Last 10)	51	59	
Wins (Last 5)	26	61	
Game Grader (10 yr)	44.8	49	
Game Grader (5 yr)	45.8	48	
Game Grader (3 yr)	48.1	39	
Draft Picks s' 2000	81	25	
Draft Picks s' 2010	40	37	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		68	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		67	

NEBRASKA		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
45.9 (45)	54.3 (31)	44 (45)	33.7 (57)	51.2 (37)	39.7 (54)	45.3 (42)	46.7 (45)	33.6 (58)	53.5 (29)	44.8 (49)	



WEEKLY, IN-SEASON FEATURE -- ADVANCED STATS & INFO

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ILLINOIS

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#10(TIE) #38

BIG TEN

OVERALL



ILLINOIS				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
13		(B) Miss St	MINNESOTA	WISCONSIN
12	IOWA	MICHIGAN	OREGON	WASHINGTON
11	RUTGERS	PURDUE	PENN ST	OHIO ST
10	WISCONSIN	MICH ST	(B) S. Carolina	INDIANA
9	PURDUE	INDIANA	N'WESTERN	(B) Tennessee
8	MARYLAND	N'WESTERN	RUTGERS	N'WESTERN
7	Virginia	NEBRASKA	MICH ST	MARYLAND
6	UTSA	MINNESOTA	MICHIGAN	RUTGERS
5	N'WESTERN	IOWA	PURDUE	PURDUE
4	MINNESOTA	WISCONSIN	NEBRASKA	USC
3	PENN ST	Chatt. (FCS)	C. Michigan	W. Michigan
2	Charlotte	Virginia	Kansas	Duke
1	NEBRASKA	Wyoming	E. Illinois (FCS)	W. Illinois (FCS)
2021 2022 2023 2024 2025				
BRET BIELEMA				

ILLINOIS				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
W. Illinois (FCS) W 52-3	279	1	76.8	
DUKE W 45-19	-19	5	87.5	
W. MICHIGAN W 38-0	154	0	88.0	
INDIANA L 10-63	-418	-1	0.0	
USC W 34-32	12	0	63.1	
PURDUE W 43-27	54	2	63.6	
OHIO ST L 16-34	23	-3	35.1	
WASHINGTON L 25-42	-112	-2	21.2	
RUTGERS W 35-13	133	-1	79.8	
MARYLAND W 24-6	104	0	68.4	
WISCONSIN L 10-27	-3	0	26.9	
N'WESTERN W 20-13	30	3	63.9	
(B) TENNESSEE W 30-28	139	1	76.1	
OVERALL: 28th / 68 BIGTEN: 9th / 18 57.7				

ILLINOIS		UNIT RANKS	
BIG TEN RANK		NATIONAL	
(of 18)		TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	15		
RUNNING BACKS	13		
RECEIVERS & TE	12		
OFFENSIVE LINE	10		
DEFENSIVE LINE	15		
LINEBACKERS	9		
DEFENSIVE BACKS	5		

ILLINOIS		RANK	
Scoring Offense	29.4 ppg	52	
Points per Play	0.46	40	
Total Offense	374 ypg	80	
Yards per Play	5.9	48	
Rushing Offense	138 ypg	89	
Yards per Carry	3.9	98	
O-Line Run Push	4.3	50	
Explosive Rush	4.8	88	
Passing Offense	236 ypg	59	
Yards / Attempt	8.2	27	
QB Rating	154	17	
TD / INT Ratio	3.8	14	
Sacks / Attempt	9%	110	
Explosive Pass	7.0	58	
Return. Production	52%	74	
Returning Snaps	14,409	19	
27.6 SECONDS/PLAY #47 of 68 P4			
LUNNEY (2025 ILLINOIS)			

In the Music City Bowl, quarterback Luke Altmyer led a game-winning drive that melted the final five minutes to knock off Tennessee. It was a fitting end to an all-time career.

For the past three seasons, Altmyer has been Illinois' get-out-of-jail-free card, bailing them out of one-score games. His seven game-winning drives are the nation's most over that span. Head coach Bret Bielema has grown accustomed to the late-game heroics: "I looked at Luke before our final drive, he gave me a head nod, that's all I needed to see."

Altmyer has been the leader and figurehead of the program's best five-year run (37 wins) since 1905. The 10-win season in 2024 tied a program-high and they clinched back-to-back bowl bids for the first time in 15 years. Illinois stacked consecutive 9+ win seasons for the first time ever.

The wins led a fan resurgence too. Memorial Stadium posted four consecutive sell-outs last season for the first time since 2008.

Illinois demonstrated some staying power in the top half of the deep Big Ten, and as they attempt to ascend further, Bielema credits this senior class for building the foundation: "our 2026 recruiting class is one of the best I've ever assembled – these seniors have been a big part of that."

Far from just coach-speak, the rankings back up that claim. At #21 nationally, the 2026 class became the highest-ranked class Illinois has ever signed in the modern recruiting era. In the ten years prior to Bielema, Illinois signed just three Top 50 classes. He's five for five, and this Top 25 class raises the bar.

OFFENSE

Altmyer ended his Illinois career with the second-most wins by a quarterback (23), the highest completion percentage (64%), highest QB Rating, and became the first 3,000-yard passer since Nathan Scheelhaase in 2013.

Illinois hit the transfer portal again and signed a former four-star Katin Houser who began at Michigan State but then posted two successful seasons at East Carolina. Last year he placed fourth in the AAC in QB Rating with an impressive two-year stat line: 5,306 yards, 37 touchdowns, and 17 picks.

Houser has a bigger frame, strong arm, but lacks the elusiveness of Altmyer. That could be an issue given the complete rebuild of the offensive line. Last year the veteran line was expected to become a strength with the ability to grind down opponents, Big Ten West style. Instead, they remained average in OL Run Push (#50), below-average in yards/carry (#98), and struggled in pass protection (#110) allowing a sack on 9% of attempts. And that was with a top-notch scrambler in Altmyer.

Four starters are gone, including first-team All-Big Ten JC Davis, with guard Brandon Henderson as the only returner. Nathan Knapik played well in the bowl game with Davis opted out, center Jake Renfro (Wisconsin) transferred in with Big Ten starting experience, and then the staff hit the junior-college ranks. They signed three of the top five JUCO linemen this cycle: Maika Matelau, TJ Taylor, and Alfred Washington.

Christian Abney moves up into a starting role after both tight ends – blocker Tanner Arkin and receiver Cole Rusk – departed. Rusk (Arizona) earned a four-star transfer grade and left after posting the most yards by a tight end here since Daniel Barker in 2020.

Illinois at least has stability at the other skill positions. Last year Kaden Feagin, Aidan Laughery, and Ca'Lil Valentine shared carries and the trio returns intact for 2026. The speedy, shifty Valentine led with 614 yards, Laughery may be the best of the bunch if he can avoid injuries, and big-back Feagin was getting reps at tight end this spring.

They do lose their top receiver in third-team All-Big Ten Hank Beatty who emerged as a reliable playmaker in the slot. He finished #2 in the Big Ten in yards-after-catch trailing only the Biletnikoff

ILLINOIS										OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)									
O																			
F	38	33	23	46	58	38	61	22	63	53									54th
F	LUNNEY				PETERSEN				ROD SMITH				McGEE						
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016									10-YEAR
D	HENRY				WALTERS				LOVIE SMITH*				NICKERSON						
E	25	53	41	13	28	67	51	68	53	50									59th
F																			

ILLINOIS		RANK	
Scoring Defense	23.6 ppg	56	
Points per Play	0.36	61	
Total Defense	345 ypg	46	
Yards per Play	5.3	46	
3rd Down Conv%	45%	124	
Rushing Defense	127 ypg	36	
Yards per Carry	3.9	53	
Negative Play %	8%	88	
Explosive Rush	4.9	20	
Passing Defense	218 ypg	63	
Yards / Attempt	6.6	48	
QB Rating	131	63	
Completion %	63.6%	95	
Explosive Pass	3.3	3	
Return. Production	47%	83	
Returning Snaps	10,008	62	

ILLINOIS		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		38	
Rushing Offense	(0.6)	61	
Passing Offense	21.1	11	
Defense Overall		25	
Rushing Defense	0.4	34	
Passing Defense	5.4	33	

impressed as a freshman and could become their next star. James Kreutz is back and Ismael Kante was ranked the #1 JUCO linebacker.

The clear strength of the defense, and the overall team, is in the secondary. Safeties Matthew Bailey and Xavier Scott both turned down the pros for a final season in Champaign. Juice Clarke is back at corner to make it three all-league stars in the defensive backfield. They added yet another JUCO star in #1 cornerback Jakwon Morris and this room is strong enough to lead them through the scheme change. They will miss three-year starter and two-time captain Miles Scott, but this will still be a top secondary in the Big Ten.

OUTLOOK

The graduation of a large, program-changing senior class leaves behind a younger and inexperienced two-deep for 2026. While the recruiting is surging in the right direction, it may need a few development seasons to translate onto the field.

Illinois also loses Altmeyer, their cheat code in close games. While they fall down a few spots in the Big Ten projection in this transition-type season, Bielema has clearly elevated the program's floor. If the JUCO wildcards hit, Illinois can get back to the upper-half of the league.

ILLINOIS		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	650	46	
All-Time Win %	0.506	56	
Wins (Last 100)	467	60	
Wins (Last 50)	254	59	
Wins (Last 25)	125	64	
Wins (Last 10)	54	56	
Wins (Last 5)	37	32	
Game Grader (10 yr)	39.9	62	
Game Grader (5 yr)	52.5	29	
Game Grader (3 yr)	50.5	33	
Draft Picks s' 2000	54	46	
Draft Picks s' 2010	37	41	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		1	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		11	

winner Makai Lemon. Beatty, and red zone threat Justin Bowick (Oklahoma State) are gone, but their #2 and #3 receivers return. Collin Dixon and Hudson Clement combined for 1,002 yards and eight touchdowns. A pair of freshmen Brayden Trimble and four-star Nas Rankin could push into the rotation. Then the staff signed first-team All-CUSA 6'5 Alex Perry (FIU) and speedy Jayshon Platt (FAU) who together combined for 1,560 yards and 14 touchdowns at the non-AQ level.

DEFENSE

Back in 2022, Bielema threw out the defensive playbook and together with Ryan Walters they designed a new scheme from scratch. It puzzled opposing coordinators and they posted the #1 scoring defense in America. Since then, Bielema claims two-thirds of the Big Ten has copied the scheme, and that it's essentially been figured out by now. Illinois fell to #31 in 2024, #56 in 2025, and Bielema wanted another change this offseason.

He surprised by hiring longtime Montana head coach Bobby Hauck. Bielema said he was the "only person in mind and I offered only one man the job." Hauck is from the Rocky Long tree, known for its aggressive, attacking 3-3-5 scheme.

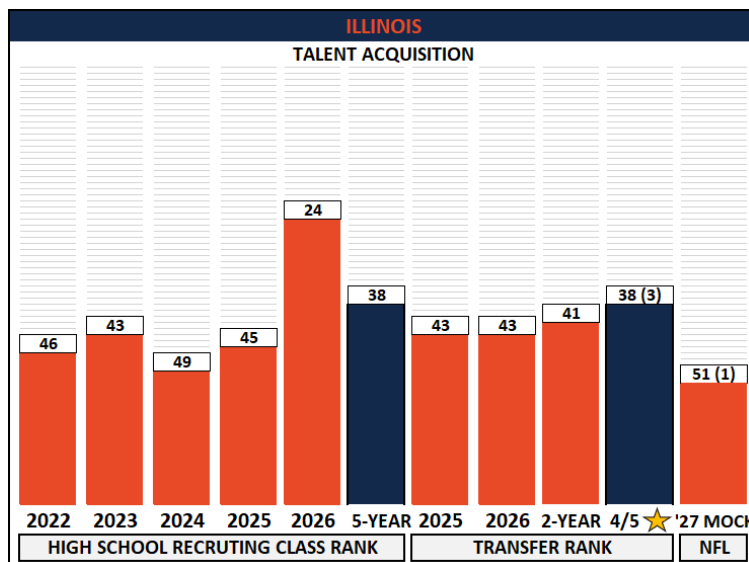
The scheme change caused an exodus from the defensive line and four top linemen transferred out to Power 4 rosters: four-star Tomiwa Durojaiye (South Carolina), Angelo McCullom (Texas A&M), Eli Coenen (Michigan State), and Curt Neal (Purdue). That is quite the talent drain. Pat Farrell was in the rotation last year and moves into a starting role. The staff backfilled with rotational linemen from the non-AQ level in Connor Sullivan (Washington State) and Darrell Prater (Jacksonville State) and All-Ivy Carter Janki (Penn).

Top defender Gabe Jacas is off to the pros after earning first-team All-Big Ten honors and posting one of the program's best pass rushing seasons. He led the league with 11 sacks, and two other outside backers Alec Bryant and Leon Lowery are also gone. Joe Barna played well in the bowl game, and Daniel Brown is a former JUCO All-American.

Starting middle backer Dylan Rosiek is gone, but four-star Grant Beerman

ILLINOIS	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 3	UAB
S. 12	DUKE
S. 19	S. ILLINOIS (FCS)
S. 26	@ Ohio State
O. 3	PURDUE
O. 10	@ Michigan State
O. 17	--- BYE ---
O. 24	OREGON
O. 31	@ Maryland
N. 6	NEBRASKA
N. 13	@ UCLA
N. 21	IOWA
N. 28	@ Northwestern

ILLINOIS		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
57.7 (28)	52.4 (35)	41.4 (49)	65.7 (16)	45.2 (47)	25.9 (63)	40.2 (49)	27.7 (65)	21.1 (67)	21.5 (66)	39.9 (62)	





MINNESOTA

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#12

BIG TEN

#44

OVERALL



MINNESOTA					
5-YEAR WIN TREND					
13	IOWA	IOWA	WISCONSIN	PENN ST	N'WESTERN
12	ILLINOIS	PENN ST	OHIO ST	RUTGERS	OREGON
11	Bowling Green	ILLINOIS	PURDUE	MICHIGAN	IOWA
10	OHIO ST	PURDUE	ILLINOIS	IOWA	OHIO ST
9	(B) W. Virginia	(B) Syracuse	MICHIGAN	UNC	California
8	WISCONSIN	WISCONSIN	N'WESTERN	(B) Va Tech	(B) New Mexico
7	INDIANA	N'WESTERN	UNC	WISCONSIN	WISCONSIN
6	N'WESTERN	NEBRASKA	(B) Bowling Gr.	ILLINOIS	MICH ST
5	MARYLAND	RUTGERS	MICH ST	MARYLAND	NEBRASKA
4	NEBRASKA	MICH ST	IOWA	UCLA	PURDUE
3	PURDUE	Colorado	UL-Lafayette	USC	RUTGERS
2	Colorado	W. Illinois (FCS)	E. Michigan	Nevada	NW State (FCS)
1	Miami (OH)	NM State	NEBRASKA	Rhode Isl. (FCS)	Buffalo
	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
	P.J. FLECK				

MINNESOTA				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
BUFFALO	W 23-10	292	0	63.8
NW St (FCS)	W 66-0	442	3	77.9
CALIFORNIA	L 14-27	-5	-2	24.7
RUTGERS	W 31-28	-28	1	47.6
OHIO ST	L 3-42	-312	0	2.1
PURDUE	W 27-20	-194	3	39.0
NEBRASKA	W 24-6	126	0	80.3
IOWA	L 3-41	-141	-3	6.0
MICHIGAN ST	W 23-20	-166	0	34.2
OREGON	L 13-42	-310	1	6.9
N'WESTERN	L 35-38	-202	1	29.2
WISCONSIN	W 17-7	-50	3	64.1
(B) NEW MEXICO	W 20-17	48	0	47.8
OVERALL: 55th / 68 BIGTEN: 13th / 18 40.3				

MINNESOTA	UNIT RANKS	
BIG TEN RANK	NATIONAL	
(of 18)	TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	11	
RUNNING BACKS	6	
RECEIVERS & TE	10	
OFFENSIVE LINE	12	
DEFENSIVE LINE	7	
LINEBACKERS	12	
DEFENSIVE BACKS	15	

MINNESOTA	RANK	
Scoring Offense	23 ppg	102
Points per Play	0.39	80
Total Offense	293 ypg	129
Yards per Play	4.9	122
Rushing Offense	103 ypg	128
Yards per Carry	3.6	117
O-Line Run Push	3.7	123
Explosive Rush	3.4	128
Passing Offense	190 ypg	102
Yards / Attempt	6.2	122
QB Rating	127	85
TD / INT Ratio	2.7	39
Sacks / Attempt	6%	65
Explosive Pass	4.4	131
Return. Production	71%	10
Returning Snaps	11,431	44
28.5 SECONDS/PLAY #59 of 68 P4		
FLECK (2025 MINNESOTA)	SLOW	

In his ninth season, head coach PJ Fleck notched another eight-win season and winning record in Big Ten play for the fourth time in five years. That makes this the best extended run since the 1960s when Minnesota last won a national title.

They gave the fans in Huntington Bank Stadium plenty to cheer for. Minnesota went a perfect 7-0 at home for the first time since 1967 and did so with a disruptive defense and last-second resiliency.

The Minnesota defense set two school records by holding Northwestern State to just 42 total yards and then swarming Nebraska for nine sacks. Two-way sensation Koi Perich took back a game-winning Pick Six to beat Purdue, and redshirt freshman quarterback Drake Lindsey led late game-winning drives to beat Rutgers and Michigan State.

Stacking winning seasons is an achievement in such a deep league, but from a statistical standpoint, not all "8-5 seasons" are equal.

All five of Minnesota's conference wins came against teams with losing Big Ten records (9-46 combined), they were outgained in four of them, and three were within a score. Their five losses were by an average margin of 24 points/game including blowouts against Iowa (41-3) and Playoff teams Ohio State (42-3) and Oregon (42-13).

This ended up as an interesting case-study for my opponent-adjusted Game Grader formula. Despite the 8-5 record, Minnesota finished just 55th of 68 Power 4 in Game Grader – their worst ranking in the entire Fleck era.

Then the program was stunned with the transfer departure of Perich -- the two-time All-Big Ten, hometown face of the program – who took Oregon's offer. There are thousands of FBS transfers each cycle, but this one was unbelievable.

The staff was able to rally a respectable transfer haul of their own, ranking 10th in the Big Ten, and are building around Lindsey for 2026 and beyond.

OFFENSE

Like the pessimistic outlook from Game Grader, my opponent-adjusted offense stats dropped Minnesota all the way to second-worst in Power 4. It was one of the least explosive offenses in both long-yardage rushing (#128) and passing (#131). The run game finished #117 in yards/carry and averaged just over 100 per game (#128) and it was even worse in the handful of games when star running back Darius Taylor was injured.

They did find a bright spot at quarterback in Lindsey. The first-time starter exceeded expectations and took care of the ball with just six interceptions against 18 touchdowns. He showed off a strong arm, led several fourth-quarter scoring drives, and "took really good command of the offense," per Fleck.

Lindsey returns and should get a second-year bonus. He noted pre-snap reads and audibles were points of emphasis for him this offseason, as well as pocket elusiveness. He finished 11th in the Big Ten in QB Rating – tied with fellow freshman Bryce Underwood (Michigan) – and that should improve in 2026.

Leading receiver Le'Meke Brockington graduated, and the entire second-tier of backups is gone. Last year's second and third options Jalen Smith and Javon Tracy are both back after combining for 65 catches, 873 yards, and 10 touchdowns. The staff signed a big one in former five-star Perry Thompson (Auburn) who should have an instant impact in the slot. Zion Steptoe (Tulsa) could help with the explosiveness issue as the vertical threat led the AAC in average depth of target last year.

Taylor returns as the workhorse back. In 2024 he was just short of 1,000 yards, and when healthy last year he averaged just under 100 per game. Taylor closed with back-to-back 100-yard games against Wisconsin and New Mexico and the offense was noticeably different with him in the backfield.

MINNESOTA									
OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)									
O	67	49	53	36	45	25	8	43	58
F									60
F	HARBAUGH	SIMON	CIARROCCA	SANFORD	CIARROCCA	JOHNSON			
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017
D	COLLINS	HETHERMAN		ROSSI				ROBB SMITH	SAWVEL
E	45	16	61	30	20	65	33	48	50
F									18
									40th

MINNESOTA		RANK	
Scoring Defense	22.9 ppg	50	
Points per Play	0.38	74	
Total Defense	332 ypg	34	
Yards per Play	5.4	51	
3rd Down Conv%	40%	81	
Rushing Defense	121 ypg	27	
Yards per Carry	3.7	38	
Negative Play %	12%	4	
Explosive Rush	6.8	83	
Passing Defense	211 ypg	51	
Yards / Attempt	7.4	89	
QB Rating	139	95	
Completion %	67%	126	
Explosive Pass	5.2	52	
Return. Production	65%	12	
Returning Snaps	11,835	40	

MINNESOTA		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		67	
Rushing Offense	(1.1)	66	
Passing Offense	(7.6)	55	
Defense Overall		45	
Rushing Defense	0.3	36	
Passing Defense	(6.3)	53	

Maverick Baranowski earned All-Big Ten honors after posting the school's first 100-tackle season since Blake Cashman in 2018. His fellow starter Devon Williams is gone, but Matt Kingsbury and Emmanuel Karmo moved up the depth chart.

Perich will be missed in the secondary, but John Nestor played well at corner and Fleck called him "the ultimate competitor." Aydan West (Michigan State) got nearly 400 snaps last year as a true freshman and could be the starter opposite of Nestor. The safety room returns an All-Big Ten headliner in Kerry Brown, plus Zack Harden who transitioned to the position midseason and impressed. The staff signed a wildcard in All-Patriot League Mekhai Smith (Lehigh) from the FCS level.

OUTLOOK

Minnesota was an interesting case study for Game Grader. Their five close-margin Big Ten wins were against teams with a combined 9-46 league record, so yes Minnesota went 8-5 but placed down at 55th in Game Grader (13th in the Big Ten).

They return program stars in Lindsey, Taylor, and Smith but now the schedule reverses and they draw six of the Big Ten's top nine. Statistically they were more like a six-win team last year, and that is where they are projected in 2026.

MINNESOTA		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	747	25	
All-Time Win %	0.573	31	
Wins (Last 100)	538	48	
Wins (Last 50)	279	53	
Wins (Last 25)	165	44	
Wins (Last 10)	75	28	
Wins (Last 5)	40	25	
Game Grader (10 yr)	51.2	31	
Game Grader (5 yr)	51.5	31	
Game Grader (3 yr)	45.4	44	
Draft Picks s' 2000	49	49	
Draft Picks s' 2010	31	48	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		48	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		8	

He could use some help from the trenches. The offensive line ranked just #123 in my OL Run Push stat and will be rebuilding the right side of the line. Minnesota does return its top two blockers in left tackle Nathan Roy and left guard Greg Johnson, plus starting center Ashton Beers. Tony Nelson started the final two games at right guard and moves up into the full-time role, and the staff signed Bennett Warren (Tennessee) who was a Top100 recruit in the 2024 class. The line is more athletic but smaller than the usual giant Minnesota offensive lines of the Fleck era.

The top three tight ends are gone, and they turn to a fifth-year Kaden Helms (Oklahoma) who has minimal game experience but was a four-star recruit stuck in a deep room.

DEFENSE

Fleck has an acronym or slogan for everything. First-time defensive coordinator Danny Collins certainly backed up their H.A.V.O.C. motto by disrupting opposing offenses at a top five clip. Minnesota ranked #4 in my Negative Play Rate which tracks how often the defense makes a sack or tackle behind the line of scrimmage.

The unit had big performances like the sack-fests against Nebraska and Michigan State, but collapsed in the 38-35 Northwestern loss, not to mention the Playoff-team blowouts.

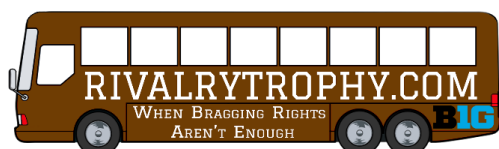
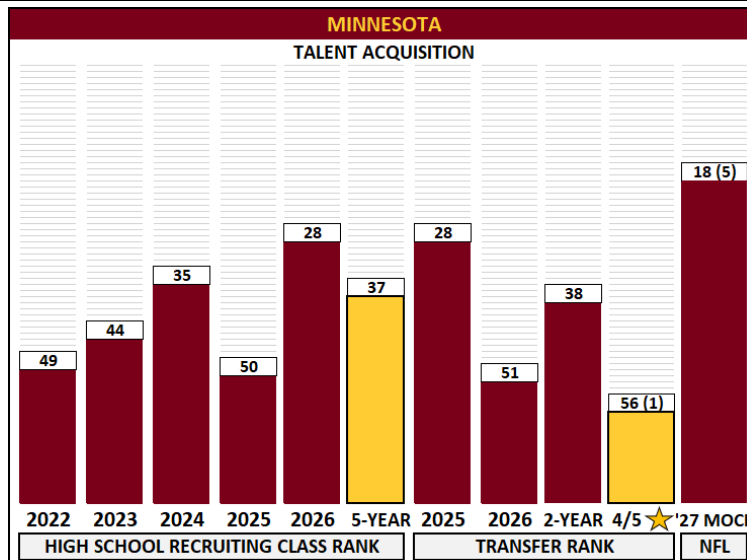
Three of their four All-Big Ten stars are back for 2026, but the headliner Perich's departure stings. The silver lining may have been more resources to boost the incoming transfer class, and they added some firepower to an already strong pass rush.

TJ Bush transferred in and was Cal's best pass rusher last year. First-team All-Big Ten Anthony Smith is back and his 12.5-sack season was the school's first double-digit sack year since Willie VanDeSteege in 2009. If Smith stacks another 10+ sack season he would break the Minnesota career record. Karter Menz (6.5 sacks) also returns, making this defensive end trio one of the best in the Big Ten.

It's a total rebuild in the middle, with the top four defensive tackles departing. The staff hit the portal with 320-pound space-eater Naquan Crowder (Marshall) and Xion Chapman (FIU).

MINNESOTA	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 3	E. ILLINOIS (FCS)
S. 12	MISS. STATE
S. 19	AKRON
S. 26	@ Washington
O. 3	MICHIGAN
O. 10	@ Purdue
O. 17	--- BYE ---
O. 24	IOWA
O. 31	@ Indiana
N. 7	UCLA
N. 14	@ Penn State
N. 21	NORTHWESTERN
N. 27	@ Wisconsin

MINNESOTA		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
40.3 (55)	60.1 (24)	35.8 (54)	59.4 (23)	62 (16)	40.9 (48)	69.4 (13)	51.2 (35)	41.6 (50)	50.9 (34)	51.2 (31)	





UCLA

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#13

BIG TEN

#49

OVERALL



UCLA				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
13		(B) Pittsburgh	CAL	
12	UTAH	USC	ARIZONA ST	USC
11	OREGON	ARIZONA	ARIZONA	WASHINGTON
10	ARIZONA ST	OREGON	OREGON ST	MINNESOTA
9	Fresno St	CAL	UTAH	PENN ST
8	CAL	ARIZONA ST	(B) Boise St	OREGON
7	USC	STANFORD	USC	LSU
6	COLORADO	UTAH	COLORADO	INDIANA
5	WASHINGTON	WASHINGTON	STANFORD	Fresno St
4	ARIZONA	COLORADO	WASH ST	IOWA
3	STANFORD	S. Alabama	NC Cent. (FCS)	NEBRASKA
2	LSU	AL State (FCS)	San Diego St	RUTGERS
1	Hawaii	Bowling Green	Coastal Carolina	Hawaii
2021			2025	
CHIP KELLY			DeSHAUN FOSTER	

Back in 2011, UCLA suffered a 50-0 loss to USC, an embarrassment so severe it caused the administration to change coaches and recommit to recruiting. It led to the Jim Mora era that started with a 29-11 run and pair of Top 15 seasons.

After a 5-7 debut season, DeShaun Foster's second team suffered a 43-10 loss to Utah, a loss to UNLV, and then a 35-10 meltdown against New Mexico. An 0-3 start, with a blowout loss to a coach-transition, Mountain West program – that was Foster's 50-0 moment.

UCLA fired Foster two days later and opened up a season-long coaching search that allowed for a much more thorough process than the February 2024 scramble after Chip Kelly left for Ohio State.

In the meantime, the interim staff sparked a three-game win streak capped by the 42-37 win over then #7 Penn State. Tight ends coach Jerry Neuheisel took over the playcalling and outdueled PSU's Jim Knowles to become the first 0-4 team to beat a Top 10 opponent in 40 years.

UCLA				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
UTAH L 10-43	-272	-1	2.9	
UNLV L 23-30	77	-2	34.1	
NEW MEXICO L 10-35	-124	1	12.1	
N'WESTERN L 14-17	-3	0	41.0	
PENN ST W 42-37	78	1	83.8	
MICHIGAN ST W 38-13	165	1	86.8	
MARYLAND W 20-17	77	-1	50.0	
INDIANA L 6-56	-274	-1	0.4	
NEBRASKA L 21-28	-13	0	32.3	
OHIO ST L 10-48	-218	0	5.4	
WASHINGTON L 14-48	-218	-1	5.0	
USC L 10-29	-80	0	24.4	
OVERALL: 62nd / 68 BIGTEN: 17th / 18 31.5				

"You'd think it was Mardi Gras," said interim head coach Tim Skipper regarding the postgame locker room celebration.

They notched wins over Michigan State and Maryland but lost the final five games. That makes it seven losing seasons in the past ten, and Rose Bowl attendance dwindled to a 37,000 per-game average.

The three-month coaching search ended with a major win as they hired James Madison's Bob Chesney, one of the top prizes in the biggest coaching carousel in college football history. Chesney took over JMU in 2024 after Curt Cignetti took his staff and 20 players with him to Indiana. In two years he went 21-6, won the Sun Belt, and earned a spot in the Playoff – quite the achievement for a school just five years removed from the FCS level.

Before that at Holy Cross he won the Patriot League five times in six seasons, and had similar success at DII Assumption and DIII Salve Regina. He brought both JMU coordinators and 10 of his players with him to Westwood to help spark the program rebuild.

UCLA	UNIT RANKS	
BIG TEN RANK (of 18)	NATIONAL	TOP 15
QUARTERBACK	8	
RUNNING BACKS	11	
RECEIVERS & TE	11	
OFFENSIVE LINE	13	
DEFENSIVE LINE	12	
LINEBACKERS	16	
DEFENSIVE BACKS	11	

OFFENSE

UCLA ranked in the national bottom ten in both scoring offense *and* scoring defense. James Madison was in the top ten in both with coordinators and schemes that clearly work.

Nico Iamaleava returns as the face of the franchise. The former five-star finished just 14th in the Big Ten in QB Rating, but he showed off his big arm and his athleticism in the Penn State win with five touchdowns. His toughness cannot be questioned, as he shouldered the team-high in carries and rushing yards, battled through hits and a November concussion, and rallied the locker room after the Foster firing.

His skillset fits better with this scheme, as James Madison used a lot of quarterback designed-runs.

The biggest concern is in the trenches, where last year's transfer portal gamble backfired and produced a below average unit. This cycle, they flipped the strategy and signed guys with proven starting experience. UCLA only returns one starter, but it's their best one in left guard Eugene Brooks. From there, it is Pick Your Transfer at the other four spots.

Three JMU linemen transferred in with tackle JD Rayner and the All-Sun Belt duo of Riley Robell and Carter Sweazie. Hall Schmidt was a starter on Boise State's 2024 Playoff team, Jordan Davis (South Alabama) is a three-year starter, and Derek Osman (Harvard) was All-Ivy.

Iamaleava was the lead rusher, and the trio of running backs shared carries with Jalen Berger, Anthony Woods, and Jaivian Thomas all getting 60+ attempts. Berger graduated, and the staff

UCLA	RANK	
Scoring Offense 18.2 ppg	126	
Points per Play 0.3	119	
Total Offense 320 ypg	120	
Yards per Play 5.2	106	
Rushing Offense 140 ypg	85	
Yards per Carry 4.5	61	
O-Line Run Push 4.4	43	
Explosive Rush 6.9	26	
Passing Offense 180 ypg	115	
Yards / Attempt 6	126	
QB Rating 123	101	
TD / INT Ratio 2.1	64	
Sacks / Attempt 7%	98	
Explosive Pass 3.5	134	
Return. Production 73%	5	
Returning Snaps 18,296	4	
28.4 SECONDS/PLAY #59 of 68 P4		
KENNEDY (2025 JMU)	SLOW	

UCLA										
OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)										
O	54	40	41	9	18	27	56	33	21	57
F	SUNSERI	BIENIEMY	CHIP KELLY*	JUSTIN FRYE	KELLY*	MORA*	POLAMALU			35th
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016
D	IKAIKA MALLOE	LYNN	McGOVERN	JERRY AZZINARO	TOM BRADLEY					
E	42	31	8	31	43	21	63	41	52	10
F										34th

UCLA		RANK
Scoring Defense	33.4 ppg	127
Points per Play	0.52	130
Total Defense	387 ypg	85
Yards per Play	6.1	115
3rd Down Conv%	55%	136
Rushing Defense	190 ypg	119
Yards per Carry	5.2	129
Negative Play %	5%	135
Explosive Rush	8.2	121
Passing Defense	197 ypg	35
Yards / Attempt	7.2	76
QB Rating	148	118
Completion %	66%	118
Explosive Pass	5.6	62
Return. Production	61%	29
Returning Snaps	14,063	15

UCLA		RANK / 68
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play		
Offense Overall		54
Rushing Offense	0.2	32
Passing Offense	(0.8)	44
Defense Overall		42
Rushing Defense	(0.4)	61
Passing Defense	(10.7)	57

signed their star running back Wayne Knight who rushed for 1,300 yards for them at JMU last year. Knight is a speedy 5'7 and put up 100+ yards in the Playoff loss to Oregon. Look for another three-man committee here.

Three of the top four receivers are gone, but with a boost from the portal it is an upgraded unit. The lack of explosiveness in the pass game (#134 nationally) was an issue but it's a fresh start for 2026. Aidan Mizell (Florida) is a former Top100 recruit and earned a four-star transfer grade and brings track speed to the room. Another speedster Brian Rowe (South Carolina) was a 2025 four-star and he'll battle veteran Mikey Matthews for reps in the slot.

They signed some proven production too. 6'4 Leland Smith (San Jose State) and Landon Ellis (James Madison) were both all-league performers at the non-AQ level, and combined for 77 catches and 1,312 yards last year. The staff also brought their blocking tight end Josh Phifer with them from JMU.

DEFENSE

Chesney brought defensive coordinator Colin Hitchens with him after building a dominant unit at JMU last year that placed in the national top ten in total defense, rushing defense, opponent QB Rating, and third downs among other categories.

10 of his 11 starters earned All-Sun Belt honors and three of them came to UCLA: corner DJ Barksdale and defensive ends Sahir West and Aiden Gobaira.

West is the headliner after a 7 sack, 14 tackle-for-loss season earned him Sun Belt Freshman of the Year. West and Gobaira, along with California's best edge rusher Ryan McCulloch, directly addresses their weakness in pass rush last year. UCLA was the least disruptive defense in America per my Negative Play Rate.

The interior tackles struggled too. Both starters Gary Smith and Keanu Williams are gone, and UCLA turns to Darold DeNgohe who was a projected starter for Rutgers before a preseason injury. DeNgohe was actually at JMU before that with the staff in 2024 and posted a productive season.

Former Top100 Tyson Ford (California) emerged as the other tackle starter.

Jalen Woods is the lone returning starter at linebacker after JonJon Vaughns graduated and Isaiah Chisom transferred out to Oklahoma State. The staff reloaded from the portal with four-star transfer Sammy Omosigho (Oklahoma) who posted 89 tackles, and 9.5 for loss, in two years in the rotation. Anthony Sacca (Notre Dame) was a 2025 four-star, and Drew Spinogatti came over from JMU.

Corner Rodrick Pleasant was arguably their top defender last year and he returns with all-league potential. Three more transfers are projected starters in Dante Lovett (Virginia Tech) at the other corner, Utah starter Tao Johnson at safety, and DJ Barksdale (JMU) at nickel. Key Lawrence graduated but Cole Martin is back at strong safety.

OUTLOOK

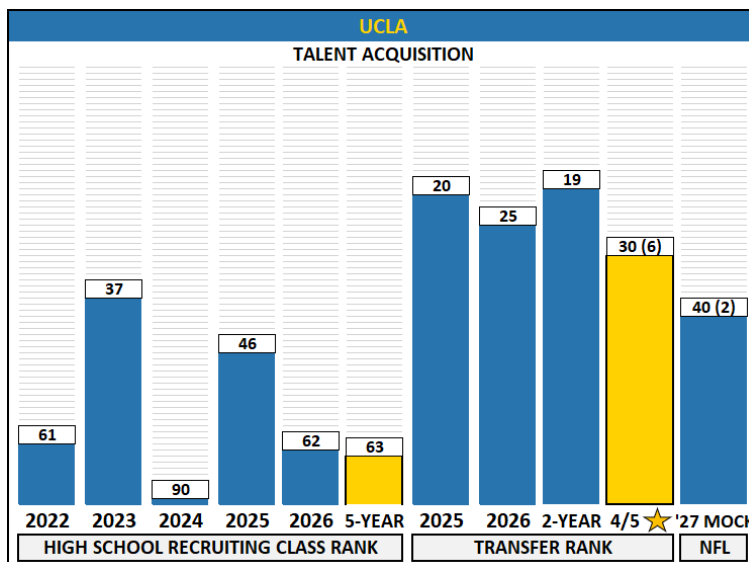
UCLA hired a proven winner in Chesney. He brought both of his James Madison coordinators, ten of their players, and multiple all-conference stars to jump start the transition.

The staff was also able to retain five-star Iamaleava and upgrade all the position rooms around him. UCLA will bounce back to the mid-tier of the Big Ten.

UCLA	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 5	@ California
S. 12	SAN DIEGO ST
S. 19	PURDUE
S. 26	@ Maryland
O. 3	--- BYE ---
O. 10	@ Oregon
O. 17	WISCONSIN
O. 24	MICHIGAN ST
O. 31	NEVADA
N. 7	@ Minnesota
N. 13	ILLINOIS
N. 21	@ Michigan
N. 28	USC

UCLA		RANK / 68
All-Time Wins	637	53
All-Time Win %	0.573	30
Wins (Last 100)	627	21
Wins (Last 50)	340	27
Wins (Last 25)	161	45
Wins (Last 10)	53	58
Wins (Last 5)	33	39
Game Grader (10 yr)	47.8	43
Game Grader (5 yr)	51.1	33
Game Grader (3 yr)	45.0	46
Draft Picks s' 2000	84	24
Draft Picks s' 2010	59	19
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		29
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		40

UCLA				GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)						
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR
31.5 (62)	43.1 (51)	60.4 (21)	60.9 (19)	59.7 (21)	62.9 (18)	37 (54)	35.3 (59)	44.2 (47)	43.3 (45)	47.8 (43)



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NORTHWESTERN #14 #55

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BIG TEN

OVERALL



NORTHWESTERN				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
13				
12	ILLINOIS	ILLINOIS	IOWA	ILLINOIS
11	PURDUE	PURDUE	NEBRASKA	MICHIGAN
10	WISCONSIN	MINNESOTA	PENN ST	USC
9	IOWA	OHIO ST	Duke	NEBRASKA
8	MINNESOTA	IOWA	RUTGERS	OREGON
7	MICHIGAN	(B) Utah	ILLINOIS	Tulane
6	NEBRASKA	MARYLAND	INDIANA	(B) C. Michigan
5	Duke	WISCONSIN	WASHINGTON	MINNESOTA
4	MICH ST	PENN ST	Duke	PURDUE
3	RUTGERS	Miami Ohio	PURDUE	PENN ST
2	Ohio	S. Illinois (FCS)	MARYLAND	UL-Monroe
1	Indiana St (FCS)	NEBRASKA	MINNESOTA	UCLA
		UTEP	Miami Ohio	W. Illinois (FCS)
	2021	2022	2023	2024
	2025			
	PAT FITZGERALD		DAVID BRAUN	

NORTHWESTERN				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
TULANE L 3-23	-184	-5	11.6	
W. Illinois (FCS) W 42-7	346	0	72.9	
OREGON L 14-34	-60	-1	26.3	
UCLA W 17-14	3	0	44.7	
UL-MONROE W 42-7	242	0	72.9	
PENN ST W 22-21	8	1	65.1	
PURDUE W 19-0	59	1	64.6	
NEBRASKA L 21-28	35	0	36.5	
USC L 17-38	-202	-1	12.6	
MICHIGAN L 22-24	-251	5	41.1	
MINNESOTA W 38-35	202	-1	67.7	
ILLINOIS L 13-20	-30	-3	34.8	
(B) C. MICHIGAN W 34-7	44	3	68.6	
OVERALL: 42nd / 68	BIGTEN: 10th / 18		47.6	

N'WESTERN	UNIT RANKS	
BIG TEN RANK NATIONAL		
(of 18) TOP 15		
QUARTERBACK	13	
RUNNING BACKS	8	
RECEIVERS & TE	16	
OFFENSIVE LINE	14	
DEFENSIVE LINE	16	
LINEBACKERS	15	
DEFENSIVE BACKS	9	

NORTHWESTERN	RANK	
Scoring Offense 23.4 ppg	98	
Points per Play 0.37	92	
Total Offense 346 ypg	98	
Yards per Play 5.4	89	
Rushing Offense 160 ypg	65	
Yards per Carry 4.6	45	
O-Line Run Push 4.2	71	
Explosive Rush 5.4	62	
Passing Offense 186 ypg	108	
Yards / Attempt 6.4	112	
QB Rating 121	110	
TD / INT Ratio 1.3	104	
Sacks / Attempt 4%	27	
Explosive Pass 5.5	111	
Return. Production 57%	59	
Returning Snaps 10,693	55	
29.0 SECONDS/PLAY #62 of 68 P4		
KELLY (2024 OHIO STATE)	SLOW	

David Braun's third season resembled parts of his first two. The streaky 2025 team had some surprising highs like his 2023 debut, but also some 2024-style offensive breakdowns and low-points.

It started with a four-interception game from new quarterback Preston Stone in the 20-point opening loss to Tulane. With a 1-2 record and star running back Cam Porter sidelined for the season, Braun worked his magic and Northwestern rattled off four straight wins with the old formula: run game and defense.

Their biggest moment was a 22-21 win at preseason favorite Penn State. Northwestern played perfect, mistake-free football, Caleb Komolafe punched in the game-winning score, and then the defense forced a final turnover on downs. This shocker was Northwestern's biggest upset win since 1995 and was the final knockout punch for Penn State's James Franklin.

A 19-0 shutout of Purdue got Northwestern to 5-2 overall – their best start since 2020 – and Braun praised his big offensive line and

running back stable: “we know who we are... it starts with the running game and it's built around that.”

The run game wasn't enough against three of the league's top recruiting programs and they lost to Nebraska, USC, and Michigan. Stone saved his best for November, and threw for 305 yards while rallying from a two-touchdown deficit to beat Minnesota and secure bowl eligibility.

A 7-6 season doesn't pop off the page, but in the context of where Northwestern was, it was just enough of a positive finish to spark the transition to their new era.

Insurance mogul Pat Ryan continued his philanthropy to his alma mater, and this round was the biggest yet. This October, Northwestern is set to open the new Ryan Field, a state-of-the-art \$865 million project that became the most expensive stadium in college football history. Paired with their iconic lakefront practice fieldhouse, Northwestern's facility combo is tough to top.

Then they made an offensive coordinator to match. Northwestern hired Chip Kelly, one of the best offensive minds in football, in a move that Braun called “reflective of Northwestern's long-term commitment to the pursuit of championships – a program-defining change.”

OFFENSE

Kelly built Oregon into a powerhouse with his hyper-tempo spread scheme, dual-threat quarterbacks, and pure speed at the skill positions. He then stacked three winning seasons at UCLA with consistent rushing attacks, and led the Ohio State offense to the 2024 national title.

This was a shocking win for a program that has been plagued by slow, unproductive offenses. The 2024 unit was one of the worst offenses in America, and while last year they made statistical gains in every category, the offense still remained below average – 57th of 68 Power 4 – in my opponent-adjusted metric.

Kelly added quarterbacks coach Jerry Neuheisel who led a three-game spark at UCLA as the interim playcaller last year. They will pick between a pair of experienced Power 4 starters in Aidan Chiles (Michigan State) and Nicco Marchiol (West Virginia). Chiles was a near-five star recruit back in 2023, started 20 games, but was eventually benched late last season.

Chiles has flashed a high ceiling, improved his decision-making with a 10-3 touchdown-to-pick ratio, and regardless of what happened with the benching, he still graded as a Top 15 transfer quarterback this cycle.

Both Chiles and Marchiol bring dual-threat skillsets that match Kelly's scheme.

Komolafe stepped up after Porter was sidelined with another injury, and ended up with 941 yards, 11 touchdowns, and All-Big Ten honors. Backup Joseph Himon also returns, and the staff signed veteran Gavin Sawchuk who has rushed for 1,600 yards while starting at Oklahoma and Florida

NORTHWESTERN										OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)									
O	57	67	57	57	62	56	68	64	51	43									67th
F	ZACH LUJAN	MIKE BAJAKIAN																	
F	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016									10-YEAR
D	TIM McGARIGLE	BRAUN*		JIM O'NEIL															
E	43	47	43	47	62	6	26	35	26	40									37th
F																			

NORTHWESTERN		RANK	
Scoring Defense	19.8 ppg	24	
Points per Play	0.34	44	
Total Defense	330 ypg	31	
Yards per Play	5.7	80	
3rd Down Conv%	42%	100	
Rushing Defense	136 ypg	48	
Yards per Carry	4.3	78	
Negative Play %	7%	113	
Explosive Rush	6.1	52	
Passing Defense	194 ypg	30	
Yards / Attempt	7.3	82	
QB Rating	132	66	
Completion %	64.3%	104	
Explosive Pass	5.8	72	
Return. Production	58%	43	
Returning Snaps	11,690	45	

NORTHWESTERN		RANK / 68
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play		
Offense Overall		57
Rushing Offense	0.1	38
Passing Offense	(16.3)	63
Defense Overall		43
Rushing Defense	0.2	45
Passing Defense	3.0	38

But like the offensive line, it's a full rebuild here in the trenches. Aidan Hubbard graduated after placing fifth on the school's all-time career sacks leaderboard (20.5). The other star edge rusher Anto Saka transferred out to Texas A&M, and both starting defensive tackles Carmine Bastone and Najee Story are gone. Tackle Brendan Flakes and end Michael Kilbane slot in as veteran starters, and the staff added a trio of three-star transfers: Jamaal Johnson (UCF), Dominic Kirks (Ohio State) and tackle Glory Stephen-Wangboje (Sacred Heart).

Multi-year starter Mac Uihlein graduated after a 100-tackle, four-interception season. Braydon Brus had 81 tackles in his first starting season and returns at weakside backer. Kobie McKinzie (Oklahoma) earned a four-star transfer grade and should start in Uihlein's spot.

OUTLOOK

2026 marks a new chapter for Northwestern with the opening of the almost-billion-dollar Ryan Field. This latest financial boost upgraded the facilities and the coaching staff but hasn't been reflected in roster talent acquisition yet.

Northwestern has to replace eight linemen – four offensive linemen and the full defensive line – and their future first-rounder was poached by Texas A&M. They signed zero four-star linemen and the trenches will hold them back in 2026.

State. Kelly's most recent college offense featured a duo – TreVeyon Henderson and Quinshon Judkins – and he may share carries here too.

Griffin Wilde returns as the #1 receiver after posting the school's best season in a decade (Austin Carr, 2016). His 71 catches, 880 yards, and 8 touchdowns earned third-team All-Big Ten honors. Hayden Eligon surged at the end of the season, with more than half of his season production coming in the final three games, and is a vertical threat to complement Wilde. Veterans Frank Covey and Ricky Ahumaraeze are joined by Top150 four-star Jaden McDuffie on the two-deep.

Hunter Welcing also earned all-league honors but went to Ohio State as a four-star transfer tight end. Northwestern signed in-line blocker 6'7 270-pounder Alex Honig (UConn) and a wildcard in Division II All-American Luke Dehnicke (Minnesota-Duluth).

Northwestern made stat gains in both my Offensive Line Push (from #133 to #71) and Pass Protection (from #60 to #27) and this was one of their best lines in recent memory. Four starters, including two of the three all-league performers, are gone and it is a full rebuild for Kelly disciple Tim Drevno. Ezomo Oratokhai is the lone returner and he can play both guard or center. They signed a proven starter in Grant Seagren (Oklahoma State) and a pair of unknowns in Arkel Anugwom (Alabama) and David Anchondo (DII Saginaw Valley). This is an uncertainty, though Kelly has never failed to produce an effective, productive run game.

DEFENSE

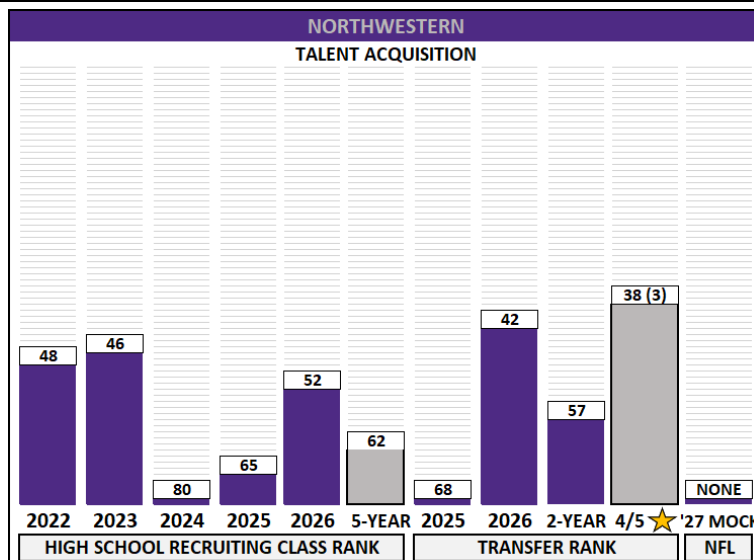
Northwestern finished in the Top 25 in scoring defense, but due to their slow-tempo offense, that is a bit misleading from a per-play perspective. They allowed 5.7 yards/play (#80), 4.3 per carry (#73), and ranked #66 in Opponent QB Rating.

This side of the ball featured eight defenders with some form of All-Big Ten honors. Four return with three stars back in the secondary headlined by do-it-all safety Robert Fitzgerald. Top corner Josh Fussell is back along with Braden Turner. On returning production alone, this should be an above average Big Ten secondary.

NORTHWESTERN	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 5	* SO DAK ST (FCS)
S. 12	--- BYE ---
S. 19	* COLORADO
S. 25	@ Indiana
O. 2	** PENN STATE
O. 10	** BALL STATE
O. 17	@ Michigan State
O. 24	** RUTGERS
O. 31	@ Oregon
N. 7	** IOWA
N. 14	@ Ohio State
N. 21	@ Minnesota
N. 28	** ILLINOIS
* Martin Stadium (Lake)	
** Ryan Field	

NORTHWESTERN		RANK / 68
All-Time Wins	563	62
All-Time Win %	0.441	66
Wins (Last 100)	431	64
Wins (Last 50)	228	64
Wins (Last 25)	155	47
Wins (Last 10)	59	50
Wins (Last 5)	23	66
Game Grader (10 yr)	42.8	53
Game Grader (5 yr)	34.6	66
Game Grader (3 yr)	40.9	60
Draft Picks s' 2000	35	61
Draft Picks s' 2010	22	61
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		32
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		47

NORTHWESTERN				GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)						
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR
47.6 (42)	28.5 (63)	46.5 (40)	26 (64)	24.5 (64)	59.5 (22)	35.1 (57)	51.2 (34)	60.4 (22)	49 (39)	42.8 (53)



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MARYLAND

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#15

BIG TEN

#56

OVERALL



MARYLAND				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
13	MICHIGAN	OHIO ST	MICHIGAN	
12	MICH ST	PENN ST	PENN ST	
11	PENN ST	WISCONSIN	N'WESTERN	
10	MINNESOTA	PURDUE	ILLINOIS	
9	OHIO ST	MICHIGAN	OHIO ST	
8	IOWA	(B) NC State	(B) Auburn	
7	(B) V. Tech	RUTGERS	RUTGERS	
6	RUTGERS	N'WESTERN	NEBRASKA	
5	INDIANA	INDIANA	INDIANA	
4	Kent State	MICH ST	MICH ST	
3	ILLINOIS	SMU	Virginia	
2	Howard (FCS)	Charlotte	Charlotte	
1	West Virginia	Buffalo	Towson (FCS)	
	2021	2022	2023	2024
	2025			
MIKE LOCKSLEY				

After a 4-8 season in 2024, and an exodus of players to the transfer portal, Maryland put their future in the hands of a core of highly-touted freshmen. New quarterback Malik Washington started fast and Maryland beat Florida Atlantic, Northern Illinois, and Towson to extend their nation-best nonconference win streak of 18 games. Washington's 773 yards were the most by any Power 4 true freshman in his first three college games since 2018.

Then in the Big Ten opener Maryland beat Wisconsin 27-10 behind a pair of Washington touchdown passes and a 46-yard Pick Six from star safety Jalen Huskey.

From 4-8 to a 4-0 start – the expectations quickly shifted and Maryland was considered a surprise breakout team. They took a 20-0 lead on Washington, but the Huskies rattled off 24 unanswered over the final quarter-plus.

Two more blown leads ensued in losses to Nebraska (34-31) and UCLA (20-17) and the losses piled up from there. When the dust settled, it was another 4-8 season for head coach Mike Locksley.

"This year was not good enough, we did not meet expectations that any of us set," said Locksley. There were many shortcomings – an ineffective run game, dropped passes, a weak run defense – but extreme roster youth was the overarching theme.

The focus on roster retention became clear right away. Maryland shifted most of its roster budget away from the transfer portal market and instead kept their best young prospects at home in College Park. Back in December, *Inside Maryland Sports* listed their top ten most important players, and Locksley was able to retain all ten – an incredible feat given the extreme player movement nowadays.

All the growing pains of 2025 are set to pay dividends in 2026. Thanks to their strong retention, Maryland now has the second highest amount of returning production in Power 4.

OFFENSE

The next move was to fix the run game. Maryland averaged just 104 yards per game (#124), 4.1 per carry (#89), and they ranked #128 in my Offensive Line Run Push. Locksley re-assigned Pep Hamilton to an analyst role and hired Clint Trickett to take over at offensive coordinator. Last year Trickett led Jacksonville State to a nine-win season thanks to a ground game that produced the nation's rushing champ.

Washington is back under center after starting all 12 games as a true freshman. The high four-star threw for 2,963 yards, 17 touchdowns, 9 picks, and his 459 yards against Michigan State placed second on the school's all-time leaderboard. Efficiency-wise, he has room to grow from a 57% completion rate and a #16 finish in the Big Ten in QB Rating. Maryland is all-in on Washington as their franchise quarterback and he should get the usual second-year starter bonus in 2026.

Nolan Ray entered as the feature back but was passed by DeJuan Williams who finished as the lead rusher with 501 yards. Williams was heavily featured in the pass game and posted the most receiving yards by a Maryland running back (426) since 2001. Williams is back, Ray transferred out to Boston College, and the staff signed Harry Dalton (USC) who was a four-star recruit in the 2025 class.

Heading into 2025, Maryland had to replace a pair of NFL-bound stars in Tai Felton and Kaden Prather. They certainly missed them, as this was one of Maryland's weakest receiver rooms in recent memory, plagued by dropped balls and a lack of separation. The three starters – Octavian Smith, Jalil Farooq, and Shaleak Knotts – all depart, leaving a wide-open room for 2026.

Two former four-star recruits, Kaleb Webb and Zymear Smith, will compete for starting jobs with the pair of incoming transfers. Chris Durr was Wyoming's top receiver, Na'eem Abdul-Rahim Gladding (Old Dominion) earned All-Sun Belt, and the two combined for 96 catches, 1,136 yards,

MARYLAND				
2025 RESULTS		Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE
FAU	W 39-7	26	6	69.1
N. ILLINOIS	W 20-9	69	-1	51.6
Towson (FCS)	W 44-17	147	1	64.8
WISCONSIN	W 27-10	30	1	76.7
WASHINGTON	L 20-24	-116	0	38.8
NEBRASKA	L 31-34	-88	3	36.5
UCLA	L 17-20	-77	1	31.3
INDIANA	L 10-55	-295	-4	0.4
RUTGERS	L 20-35	-82	1	21.0
ILLINOIS	L 6-24	-104	0	22.0
MICHIGAN	L 20-45	-96	-1	16.9
MICHIGAN ST	L 28-38	81	0	37.3
OVERALL: 56th / 68 BIGTEN: 14th / 18 38.9				

MARYLAND		UNIT RANKS	
BIG TEN RANK		NATIONAL	
(of 18)		TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	14		
RUNNING BACKS	17		
RECEIVERS & TE	14		
OFFENSIVE LINE	17		
DEFENSIVE LINE	8		
LINEBACKERS	14		
DEFENSIVE BACKS	13		

MARYLAND		RANK	
Scoring Offense	23.5 ppg	95	
Points per Play	0.35	101	
Total Offense	360 ypg	87	
Yards per Play	5.4	88	
Rushing Offense	104 ypg	124	
Yards per Carry	4.1	89	
O-Line Run Push	3.7	128	
Explosive Rush	4.8	87	
Passing Offense	256 ypg	35	
Yards / Attempt	6.2	123	
QB Rating	119	115	
TD / INT Ratio	2.0	74	
Sacks / Attempt	2%	1	
Explosive Pass	4.9	125	
Return. Production	68%	17	
Returning Snaps	13,667	24	
25.8 SECONDS/PLAY #28 of 68 P4			
TRICKETT (2025 JAX ST)			

MARYLAND					OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)									
O	55	50	19	38	16	16	52	26	52	34				31st
F	HAMILTON	GATTIS	ENOS	MONTGOMERY	CANADA	BELL								
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016				10-YEAR
D	MONACHINO	B. WILLIAMS	STEWART	HOKE	BUH									
E	53	48	29	23	56	54	58	39	47	59				55th
F														

MARYLAND		RANK	
Scoring Defense	26.5 ppg	77	
Points per Play	0.37	68	
Total Defense	402 ypg	98	
Yards per Play	5.6	73	
3rd Down Conv%	43%	109	
Rushing Defense	176 ypg	101	
Yards per Carry	4.4	86	
Negative Play %	8%	93	
Explosive Rush	6.4	64	
Passing Defense	227 ypg	82	
Yards / Attempt	7.1	67	
QB Rating	134	74	
Completion %	63.2%	85	
Explosive Pass	5.1	48	
Return. Production	74%	4	
Returning Snaps	12,284	35	

MARYLAND		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		55	
Rushing Offense	(0.3)	48	
Passing Offense	(17.7)	64	
Defense Overall		53	
Rushing Defense	(0.3)	58	
Passing Defense	(4.1)	52	

and 10 scores last year. Dorian Fleming finished second among Big Ten tight ends with 40 catches and is joined by former Terp Preston Howard who transferred back from Auburn.

The offensive line has been a weakness here for most of the Locksley era, and the 2025 line remained an issue – at least in the run game. Aided by Washington's quick release, Maryland actually finished #1 in pass protection and allowed a sack on just 2% of pass attempts.

Three starting linemen are gone: Isaiah Wright, Aliou Bah (LSU) and their best one All-Big Ten Alan Herron. Maryland has returning starters in tackle Rahtrel Perry and center Michael Hershey, plus Top100 Jaylen Gilchrist who is back from a season-ending injury and should become an all-league star. Maryland threw their hat into the Jordan Seaton sweepstakes, but the #1 transfer lineman picked LSU. The only incoming transfer they signed was three-star Tellek Lockette (Texas State).

DEFENSE

The roster retention on defense was a major win for the program. Maryland kept a pair of Freshman All-Americans plus a pair of All-Big Ten honorable mention defenders.

Defensive end Sidney Stewart set the school record for tackles-for-loss by a freshman (10.5), and former Top100 Zahir Mathis was named a semifinalist for the Shaun Alexander Freshman of the Year Award. This was already one of the best young pass rush duos in America, but then Maryland landed their biggest recruiting prize in school history in local five-star Zion Elee (St Frances Academy). Elee was rated as the #1 defensive end, and #5 overall prospect, in the entire 2026 class. That's some serious firepower off the edges.

The interior needs a boost after the run defense collapsed. Maryland allowed six straight 190+ yard rushing games, and veteran Dillan Fontus transferred out to Syracuse. The 350-pounder Bryce Jenkins was a four-star recruit and is a potential star, plus the staff added three more Power 4 linemen in Lavon Johnson (Texas), Derrick LeBlanc (UCF), and Armon Parker (Washington).

They retained Daniel Wingate who posted the school's first 100-tackle season since Tre Watson in 2018. Wingate is joined by Trey Reddick and four-star sophomore CJ Smith who posted 64 tackles last year.

Maryland ranked just 53rd of 68 Power 4 defenses in my opponent-adjusted stat – 52nd in pass defense – but they led the nation with 19 interceptions. Both transfer additions last cycle ended up as Big Ten honorable mention cornerbacks, and both Jamare Glasker and Dontay Joyner return for 2026. The do-it-all safety Jalen Huskey heads to the pros, but Lavain Scruggs returns at strong safety, and former blue-chipper Messiah Delhomme is ready for a starting role.

OUTLOOK

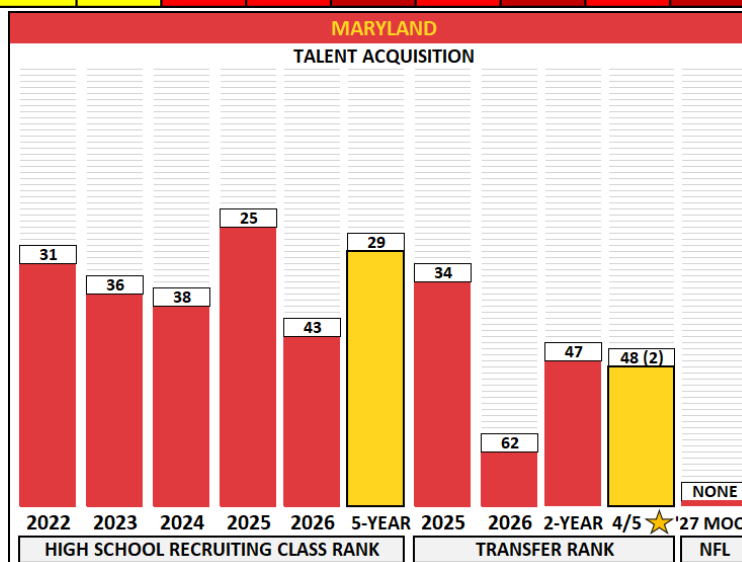
Other programs signed flashier transfer portal hauls, but Maryland's wins were on the high school recruiting trail, and more importantly, roster retention of emerging stars. Locksley retained all ten key players, and their pass rush should be elite.

Maryland draws both of the bottom Big Ten teams Rutgers and Purdue, and gets three mid-tier league teams at home in College Park (UCLA, Illinois, and Wisconsin). They are a step up from the bottom three, but have not proved staying power in the mid-tier yet.

MARYLAND	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 5	HAMPTON (FCS)
S. 12	@ UConn
S. 19	VIRGINIA TECH
S. 26	UCLA
O. 3	@ Nebraska
O. 10	@ Ohio State
O. 17	RUTGERS
O. 24	--- BYE ---
O. 31	ILLINOIS
N. 7	@ Purdue
N. 14	WISCONSIN
N. 21	@ USC
N. 28	PENN STATE

MARYLAND		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	684	39	
All-Time Win %	0.516	51	
Wins (Last 100)	554	42	
Wins (Last 50)	290	51	
Wins (Last 25)	149	52	
Wins (Last 10)	51	59	
Wins (Last 5)	31	47	
Game Grader (10 yr)	40.3	60	
Game Grader (5 yr)	45.0	52	
Game Grader (3 yr)	43.5	55	
Draft Picks s' 2000	62	40	
Draft Picks s' 2010	36	43	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		39	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		60	

MARYLAND		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
38.9 (56)	36.5 (58)	55.1 (28)	52.6 (33)	41.8 (52)	41.4 (46)	26.8 (64)	46.8 (44)	28.2 (62)	34.7 (59)	40.3 (60)	



WEEKLY, IN-SEASON FEATURE -- ADVANCED STATS & INFO

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MICHIGAN STATE

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#16

BIG TEN

#59

OVERALL



MICHIGAN STATE 5-YEAR WIN TREND

13	OHIO ST				
12	PURDUE				
11	(B) Pittsburgh	PENN ST	PENN ST	RUTGERS	IOWA
10	PENN ST	INDIANA	OHIO ST	ILLINOIS	PENN ST
9	MARYLAND	MICHIGAN	MINNESOTA	INDIANA	MINNESOTA
8	MICHIGAN	OHIO ST	MICHIGAN	MICHIGAN	MICHIGAN
7	MARYLAND	MARYLAND	RUTGERS	OREGON	INDIANA
6	INDIANA	MINNESOTA	IOWA	OHIO ST	UCLA
5	RUTGERS	Washington	MARYLAND	Boston Coll.	NEBRASKA
4	W. Kentucky	RUTGERS	Washington	PURDUE	USC
3	NEBRASKA	ILLINOIS	INDIANA	IOWA	MARYLAND
2	Miami FL	WISCONSIN	NEBRASKA	PV A&M (FCS)	Y'Town St (FCS)
1	Y'town St (FCS)	Akron	Richmond (FCS)	MARYLAND	BC
1	N'WESTERN	W. Michigan	C. Michigan	FAU	W. Michigan
	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
	MEL TUCKER	*BARNETT	JONATHAN SMITH		

After hitting rock bottom in 2023, Michigan State hired Jonathan Smith to rebuild the program in the same way he turned his alma mater Oregon State from punching bag to the Top 25. The 5-7 transition year – with a signature win over Iowa -- was understandable, but the lack of progress in his second season quickly warmed up the hot seat.

Michigan State opened up with a 3-0 start, including a wild double-overtime shootout win over Boston College, but their Big Ten troubles returned. They lost eight straight league games, the first five by double-digits, and two others with blown leads in the final minutes. Looking back, the 38-13 loss to a 1-4 UCLA team was the point of no return for the Smith era.

In a classic “hire the opposite” move, Michigan State fired the calm, reserved former West Coast quarterback, and hired the fiery, passionate, Midwestern linebacker.

Pat Fitzgerald won two Big Ten division titles, posted nine winning seasons, and brought his alma mater Northwestern to four New Year’s Day bowls. He led their golden age of football, was fired in the aftermath of a hazing scandal, and was eventually vindicated with a wrongful termination lawsuit and settlement.

With his name cleared, Fitzgerald spent the past two seasons studying the modern era – NIL, transfer portal, roster retention, player analytics – and is fired up for the opportunity.

He certainly won the opening press conference, with countless one-liners including “toughness was born here in Michigan State football.”

Then the school received a massive \$400 million commitment with most of it going towards the athletic department’s new “For Sparta” fundraising campaign. That financial boost may help with talent acquisition in future cycles, but it didn’t lead to a program-changing explosion in this transfer round.

Fitzgerald made it clear he wants college production over potential, and it became the first MSU transfer class with more players from the non-Power 4 levels than the Power 4. The strategy has merits, but their class ranked outside the national Top 50, 14th in the 18-team Big Ten: 27 transfers, zero four-stars.

OFFENSE

Fitzgerald hired Nick Sheridan to lead the offense. Holding their scheme close to the vest, it’s been described as multiple formations, variable tempos, 11, 12, and 13 personnel. Sheridan was on the Alabama staff last year that resorted to a pass-heavy approach due to a lack of a run push. Before that he was with Curt Cignetti at Indiana. We won’t know what his 2026 scheme looks like until kickoff.

Aidan Chiles was Smith’s handpicked quarterback but midway through the year he was benched (and then injured) in favor of Alessio Milivojevic. Chiles transferred out to Northwestern, and Milivojevic is the face of the program now after a strong November as the starter. He completed 64% of passes for 1,267 yards, 10 touchdowns, and just three picks, and his QB Rating would have placed ninth in the Big Ten.

The staff added Cam Fancher, a veteran with 28 starts across three FBS schools, to backup Milivojevic.

Tackle Conner Moore is the only other returning starter, and the starting lineup and two-deep will be transfer-heavy. Three linemen graduated and a fourth, Stanton Ramil, transferred out to Auburn. It could be four incoming transfers rounding out the starting line with FCS All-American Trent Fraley (North Dakota State) at center, highly-touted Ben Murawski (UConn) at guard, and Nick Sharpe (South Carolina) and Robert Wright (Georgia Southern) joining Moore.

MICHIGAN STATE				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
W. MICHIGAN W 23-6	119	-1	70.1	
BOSTON COLL. W 42-40	-77	0	36.9	
Y'Town St (FCS) W 41-24	105	0	55.2	
USC L 31-45	-186	1	23.2	
NEBRASKA L 27-38	-21	-2	28.0	
UCLA L 13-38	-165	-1	7.5	
INDIANA L 13-38	-97	0	18.8	
MICHIGAN L 20-31	-57	0	31.6	
MINNESOTA L 20-23	166	0	59.4	
PENN ST L 10-28	-138	-1	20.5	
IOWA L 17-20	34	1	61.5	
MARYLAND W 38-28	-81	0	47.3	
OVERALL: 57th / 68 BIGTEN: 15th / 18 38.3				

MICHIGAN STATE UNIT RANKS		
BIG TEN RANK	NATIONAL	
(of 18)	TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	12	
RUNNING BACKS	15	
RECEIVERS & TE	15	
OFFENSIVE LINE	16	
DEFENSIVE LINE	14	
LINEBACKERS	10	
DEFENSIVE BACKS	17	

MICHIGAN STATE	RANK	
Scoring Offense 24.6 ppg	89	
Points per Play 0.38	81	
Total Offense 346 ypg	99	
Yards per Play 5.4	91	
Rushing Offense 123 ypg	110	
Yards per Carry 3.8	104	
O-Line Run Push 4.2	63	
Explosive Rush 5.3	67	
Passing Offense 223 ypg	70	
Yards / Attempt 7.1	71	
QB Rating 137	61	
TD / INT Ratio 3.3	20	
Sacks / Attempt 10%	124	
Explosive Pass 5.4	114	
Return. Production 48%	88	
Returning Snaps 12,084	39	
27.7 SECONDS/PLAY #50 of 68 P4		
SHERIDAN (2025 ALABAMA)		

MICHIGAN STATE					OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)									
O	52	54	64	33	23	52	51	67	46	26				
F	BRIAN LINDGREN	JAY JOHNSON	SALEM	DAVE WARNER / JIM BOLLMAN										58th
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016				10-YEAR
D	JOE ROSSI	SCOTTIE HAZELTON	MIKE TRESSSEL	BARNETT / TRESSSEL										
E	58	37	60	50	40	34	22	6	18	47				32nd
F														

MICHIGAN STATE		RANK	
Scoring Defense	29.9 ppg	104	
Points per Play	0.47	118	
Total Defense	379 ypg	73	
Yards per Play	6.0	109	
3rd Down Conv%	42%	98	
Rushing Defense	147 ypg	65	
Yards per Carry	4.5	90	
Negative Play %	7%	100	
Explosive Rush	6.9	85	
Passing Defense	231 ypg	93	
Yards / Attempt	7.6	104	
QB Rating	147	117	
Completion %	65.9%	116	
Explosive Pass	5.7	70	
Return. Production	45%	91	
Returning Snaps	11,468	48	
MICHIGAN STATE		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		52	
Rushing Offense	(0.5)	54	
Passing Offense	7.9	35	
Defense Overall		58	
Rushing Defense	0.2	46	
Passing Defense	(12.9)	61	

Jordan Hall led the team in tackles, earned All-Big Ten honors, and returns to lead the defense in 2026. The next three backers are gone, but the staff brought in two with heavy college experience in All-MAC Dion Crawford (Buffalo) and former Maryland starter Caleb Wheatland.

The line got hit hard with portal exits, with Jalen Thompson, Alex VanSumeren, and David Santiago all landing on Power 4 rosters. Isaac Smith is a returning starter at edge, Ben Roberts was playing well at defensive tackle before a midseason injury, and Derrick Simmons is a former Top250 four-star ready for a breakout. Eli Coenen (Illinois) will also contend for a starting spot in the interior.

Unlike most hires, Fitzgerald doesn't have a legion of players following him from his former school. But even after several years, he was able to reconnect with Kenny Soares, who ended up as a starter at NC State and could move into an edge role here.

OUTLOOK

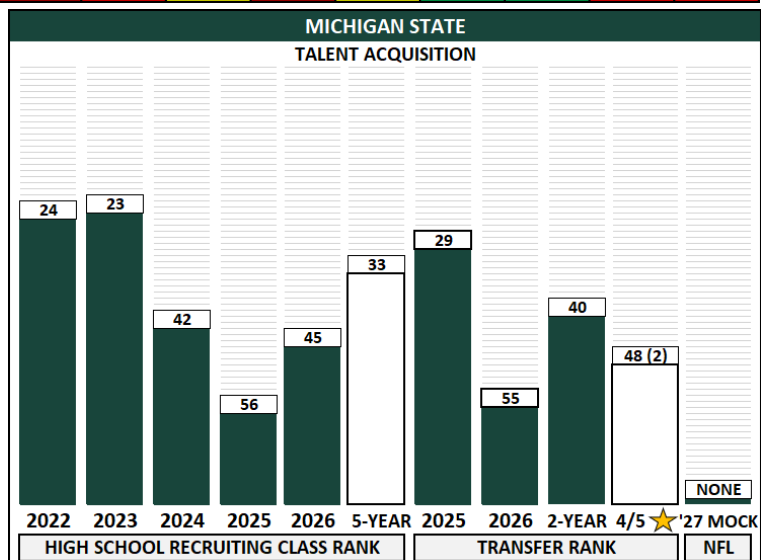
Michigan State went with the "Hire the Opposite" approach and brought Pat Fitzgerald back to the Big Ten. They also flipped their transfer strategy to bring in experienced players from the non-AQ tier: college production over Signing Day hype.

The Megaphone Trophy returns with Notre Dame back on the schedule, but that means they need to find *four* league wins to earn a bowl bid. This is a program rebuilding year that should pay dividends in 2027.

MICHIGAN STATE	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 4	TOLEDO
S. 12	E. MICHIGAN
S. 19	@ Notre Dame
S. 26	NEBRASKA
O. 3	@ Wisconsin
O. 10	ILLINOIS
O. 17	NORTHWESTERN
O. 24	@ UCLA
O. 31	--- BYE ---
N. 7	@ Michigan
N. 14	WASHINGTON
N. 20	OREGON
N. 28	@ Rutgers

MICHIGAN STATE		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	740	26	
All-Time Win %	0.593	23	
Wins (Last 100)	604	30	
Wins (Last 50)	320	35	
Wins (Last 25)	178	32	
Wins (Last 10)	58	51	
Wins (Last 5)	29	51	
Game Grader (10 yr)	44.0	50	
Game Grader (5 yr)	39.9	61	
Game Grader (3 yr)	33.7	66	
Draft Picks s' 2000	72	31	
Draft Picks s' 2010	40	37	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		56	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		56	

MICHIGAN STATE		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
38.3 (57)	35.9 (59)	26.9 (66)	40.7 (51)	57.7 (27)	29.2 (61)	51 (31)	55.9 (25)	63.9 (16)	40.9 (49)	44 (50)	





RUTGERS

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#17

BIG TEN

#63

OVERALL



RUTGERS					
5-YEAR WIN TREND					
13	(B) Wake Forest				
12	MARYLAND	MARYLAND	MARYLAND	(B) Kansas St	
11	PENN ST	PENN ST	PENN ST	ILLINOIS	
10	WISCONSIN	MICH ST	IOWA	USC	
9	N'WESTERN	MICHIGAN	OHIO ST	UCLA	
8	MICH ST	MINNESOTA	WISCONSIN	WISCONSIN	
7	OHIO ST	NEBRASKA	MICHIGAN	NEBRASKA	
6	MICHIGAN	OHIO ST	(B) Miami FL	MICH ST	
5	INDIANA	IOWA	INDIANA	MARYLAND	
4	ILLINOIS	INDIANA	MICH ST	MINNESOTA	
3	Delaware (FCS)	Temple	Wagner (FCS)	WASHINGTON	
2	Syracuse	Wagner (FCS)	Virginia Tech	Norfolk (FCS)	
1	Temple	Boston Coll.	Temple	Miami (OH)	
			N'WESTERN	Ohio	
	2021	2022	2023	2024	
				2025	
	GREG SCHIANO				

Timing is everything in college football, and unfortunately for Rutgers their two sides of the ball have not matched up.

Over the past 10-year window, Rutgers is dead last 68th of 68 Power 4 in my opponent-adjusted offense. During most of that time, Greg Schiano's defense has had to carry the weight and single-handedly get them to bowl eligibility.

But the past two seasons, and especially 2025, the strengths flipped but did not overlap. Offensive coordinator Kirk Ciarrocca finally got Rutgers above average on offense in 2024, and then last year they posted a 3,000-yard passer, 1,000-yard rusher, and 1,000-yard receiver all together for the first time since 2007. They ranked #29 in my opponent-adjusted number – 10th in passing – and set a school record for games scoring 30+ points.

Normally, that offensive output paired with a typical Schiano defense would be enough to get Rutgers to eight or nine wins. Instead, the defense collapsed at the same time the offense clicked.

RUTGERS				
2025 RESULTS				
		Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE
OHIO	W	34-31	-41	0 38.9
MIAMI (OH)	W	45-17	53	1 71.2
Norfolk (FCS)	W	60-10	343	2 77.4
IOWA	L	28-38	54	-1 45.7
MINNESOTA	L	28-31	28	-1 44.8
WASHINGTON	L	19-38	-86	0 24.7
OREGON	L	10-56	-548	0 0.4
PURDUE	W	27-24	198	0 56.2
ILLINOIS	L	13-35	-133	1 16.8
MARYLAND	W	35-20	82	-1 64.7
OHIO ST	L	9-42	-283	0 3.0
PENN ST	L	36-40	24	-1 53.7
OVERALL: 54th / 68 BIGTEN: 12th / 18 41.5				

Rutgers finished *dead last* in FBS by allowing 7.8 yards/play, and the 7.6 in league-play is the Big Ten's worst since 2000. My opponent-adjusted numbers agree, and not only did Rutgers finish dead last in 2025, it was the lowest-rated statistical defense I've graded since I began tracking in 2010.

Even with the extreme contrasts, Rutgers was in position to return to bowl season and finally snap the losing streak to Penn State. But they blew second-half leads in four losses, fourth-quarter leads in three, and had untimely mistakes that flipped the results. After lighting up the stout Iowa secondary in the first half, Rutgers threw a costly late interception, a botched shotgun snap tacked on 15 more yards to a missed field goal in the three-point Minnesota loss, and Penn State scooped up a play-action fumble for the decisive touchdown.

To flip the script in 2026 there were three requirements this offseason: retain top starters, add high-quality talent from the transfer portal, and fix the defense.

Rutgers lost five proven starters who transferred out to Power 4 programs, signed the lowest-rated transfer class in the Big Ten, and led a 64-day search for the defensive coordinator. That looks like two strikes, and the third, while an unconventional hire, remains up for grabs.

OFFENSE

Ciarrocca did a phenomenal job here and it finished as Rutgers best offense of their entire Big Ten era (2014-2025). Athan Kaliakmanis saved his best season for last as he threw for 3,100 yards, 20 touchdowns, and surged up to #7 in QB Rating in the Big Ten.

Rutgers now turns to a pair of former four-star recruits with incumbent backup AJ Surace battling incoming Dylan Lonergan (Boston College). Lonergan was originally at Alabama, then Bill O'Brien handpicked him to lead his BC offense in 2025. He posted a few 300-yard games in September but slowed down once opposing coordinators got some film, and he was eventually benched.

Lonergan has a strong arm but needs more game experience with pocket awareness and decision-making. Surace has a high ceiling but had minimal snaps last year. This battle should go into August.

While they did lose five starters to the portal, the staff was able to retain three important All-Big Ten stars on offense: running back Antwan Raymond, receiver KJ Duff, and guard Kwabena Asamoah.

Raymond took on the workhorse role with four 100-yard games including his huge 41-carry, 240-yard explosion in the Purdue win. That performance ranked third all-time here behind a pair of Ray Rice games. He earned second-team All-Big Ten and was one of ten semifinalists for the Doak Walker.

RUTGERS		UNIT RANKS	
BIG TEN RANK		NATIONAL	
(of 18)		TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	18		
RUNNING BACKS	5	15	
RECEIVERS & TE	17		
OFFENSIVE LINE	18		
DEFENSIVE LINE	17		
LINEBACKERS	18		
DEFENSIVE BACKS	18		

RUTGERS		RANK	
Scoring Offense	28.7 ppg	60	
Points per Play	0.41	64	
Total Offense	407 ypg	44	
Yards per Play	5.8	60	
Rushing Offense	141 ypg	84	
Yards per Carry	3.6	112	
O-Line Run Push	4.1	81	
Explosive Rush	3.9	120	
Passing Offense	266 ypg	25	
Yards / Attempt	8.4	20	
QB Rating	148	30	
TD / INT Ratio	3.1	26	
Sacks / Attempt	10%	127	
Explosive Pass	8.2	27	
Return. Production	49%	82	
Returning Snaps	10,918	52	
⌚ 26.6 SECONDS/PLAY #35 of 68 P4			
CIARROCCA (2025 RUTGERS)			

RUTGERS					OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)									
O														
F	29	45	43	67	65	63	67	68	67	68				68th
F	CIARROCCA		SEAN GLEESON		McNULTY		KILL		MEHRINGER					
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016				10-YEAR
D	SMITH		HARASYMIK		ROBB SMITH		BUH		NIEMANN					
E	68	66	36	35	58	44	59	45	58	60				67th
F														

RUTGERS		RANK
Scoring Defense	31.8 ppg	118
Points per Play	0.56	134
Total Defense	433 ypg	127
Yards per Play	7.6	136
3rd Down Conv%	40%	80
Rushing Defense	210 ypg	131
Yards per Carry	6.8	136
Negative Play %	7%	115
Explosive Rush	12.6	136
Passing Defense	223 ypg	77
Yards / Attempt	8.6	130
QB Rating	159	131
Completion %	65.4%	112
Explosive Pass	7.7	123
Return. Production	46%	88
Returning Snaps	9,198	76
RUTGERS		RANK / 68
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play		
Offense Overall		29
Rushing Offense	(0.4)	50
Passing Offense	23.2	10
Defense Overall		68
Rushing Defense	(2.3)	68
Passing Defense	(26.9)	68

The 6'6 Duff was a reliable playmaker all season and was the top downfield threat with an average target depth of 17 yards. He excels in jump balls and one-on-ones – the one-handed catch against Penn State is a “catch of the year” candidate. His co-star Ian Strong transferred out with a four-star ranking, and slot receiver DT Sheffield graduated. Veteran backup Ben Black moves up into a starting role on the outside, while Michael Thomas and four-star true freshman Dyzier Carter are in the slot.

Asamoah is the anchor to build the offensive line around again after consecutive All-Big Ten seasons. Tyler Needham returns at tackle, and the two of them have a combined 55 starts. Three starters depart, but Rutgers does get back two original projected starters Ryder Langsdale and Dantae Chin who both missed the season with injuries. Center Gus Zilinskas graduated but his brother Hank transferred in after starting for Colorado. The line remained below-average in OL Run Push (#81) but collapsed in pass protection (#127) allowing a sack on 10% of pass attempts.

DEFENSE

After the historically bad season, Schiano made a change on this side of the ball. The search process lasted over two months and he eventually made a surprise hire of South Dakota head coach Travis Johansen. As the defensive coordinator there in 2024 he led a Top 10 FCS defense, and last year as head coach they went 10-5 with an FCS quarterfinals appearance.

His transition unit will feature just two returning starters and as many as four FCS transfer starters.

The entire starting defensive line is gone. Bradley Weaver, Jordan Thompson, and top pass-rusher Eric O'Neill all graduated, and defensive end Jordan Walker transferred out to Georgia Tech. The staff signed three non-AQ linemen to fill out the starting line. There are all rated as three-star transfers though all three earned all-league honors last year: Malachi Davis (Toledo), J'Dan Burnett (Tulsa), Rondo Porter (App State). Zaire Angoy and Keshon Griffin both have game experience at tackle.

In their 4-2-5 scheme, only two linebackers got the vast majority of snaps. Dariel Djabome is gone but Abram Wright returns at one backer spot. Two transfers from lower levels will battle for the other spot: All-AAC Ty Morris (Rice) and Pioneer Conference Player of the Year Sean Allison (Drake).

Like the backers, there was minimal rotation in the secondary, and four of the five starters are gone. Their top two corners left for Power 4 programs with Jacobie Henderson going to Virginia and four-star transfer Bo Mascoe heading to Texas.

Three FCS transfers are projected starters as Mikey Munn (South Dakota), Bradlee Jones (Citadel), Zahmir Dawud (Villanova) all come in with three-star transfer grades. Munn was an FCS All-American, led the nation in interceptions, and followed his coach to Rutgers. Kaj Sanders is the lone returning starter but the secondary needs vast improvements after finishing #131 in opponent QB Rating, #130 in yards/attempt, #123 in explosive passing, and dead last in my opponent-adjusted stat.

OUTLOOK

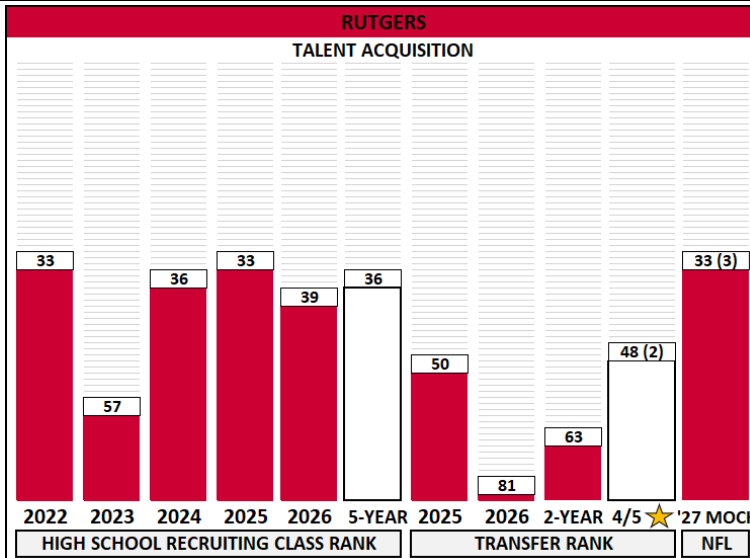
Rutgers retained All-Big Ten stars in Raymond and Duff, but now the quarterback spot is an uncertainty.

It was a historically bad defense last year but there was no overnight fix as just two starters return and they went FCS-heavy. Rutgers came up short in the transfer portal by losing five starters and then signing the league's lowest-ranked class. That talent drain will keep them out of bowl season again in 2026.

RUTGERS	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 3	UMASS
S. 11	@ Boston Coll.
S. 19	USC
S. 25	HOWARD (FCS)
O. 3	INDIANA
O. 10	--- BYE ---
O. 17	@ Maryland
O. 24	@ Northwestern
O. 31	MICHIGAN
N. 7	@ Wisconsin
N. 14	NEBRASKA
N. 21	@ Penn State
N. 28	MICHIGAN STATE

RUTGERS		RANK / 68
All-Time Wins	687	38
All-Time Win %	0.493	60
Wins (Last 100)	518	52
Wins (Last 50)	260	57
Wins (Last 25)	136	59
Wins (Last 10)	40	67
Wins (Last 5)	28	55
Game Grader (10 yr)	30.0	68
Game Grader (5 yr)	37.5	63
Game Grader (3 yr)	44.1	52
Draft Picks s' 2000	40	59
Draft Picks s' 2010	26	54
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		28
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		46

RUTGERS		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
41.5 (54)	46.7 (45)	44.2 (43)	24 (66)	31.1 (59)	31.5 (59)	17.8 (68)	21.3 (67)	22 (66)	19.9 (67)	30 (68)	



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PURDUE

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#18

BIG TEN

#68

OVERALL



PURDUE				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
14		(B) LSU		
13	OHIO ST	(CG) Michigan		
12	WISCONSIN	IOWA	N'WESTERN	INDIANA
11	MINNESOTA	WISCONSIN	MICHIGAN	MICH ST
10	Notre Dame	Syracuse	NEBRASKA	PENN ST
9	(B) Tennessee	PENN ST	OHIO ST	OHIO ST
8	INDIANA	INDIANA	IOWA	N'WESTERN
7	N'WESTERN	N'WESTERN	WISCONSIN	OREGON
6	MICH ST	ILLINOIS	Syracuse	ILLINOIS
5	NEBRASKA	NEBRASKA	Fresno State	WISCONSIN
4	IOWA	MARYLAND	INDIANA	NEBRASKA
3	ILLINOIS	MINNESOTA	MINNESOTA	Oregon St
2	UConn	FAU	ILLINOIS	Notre Dame
1	Oregon St	Ind. St (FCS)	Virginia Tech	Ind. St (FCS)
	2021	2022	2023	2024
	JEFF BROHM		RYAN WALTERS	ODOM

It was shocking to see such an offense-first program hire a defensive minded coach, and especially such a young one with no head coach experience. The Ryan Walters era ended quickly with a 5-19 two-year record.

Even more shocking was that Purdue doubled down and went with another defensive hire. At least this time, Barry Odom came in with decades of experience and was fresh off a full-scale program turnaround at UNLV where he leveraged NIL and the transfer portal to lead them to a Mountain West title game.

Odom went transfer-heavy here in his first year, bringing in 55 new players for 2025. He also hired Josh Henson to bring Purdue back to its pass-heavy, Air Raid roots.

Purdue opened up with wins over Ball State and Southern Illinois but then dropped the final ten games of the season. If you squint you can find some improvement: 2-10 was a one-win improvement over the 1-11 disaster, there were more competitive finishes, they moved up from dead last in Game Grader to second-to-last.

PURDUE				
2025 RESULTS	Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
BALL ST	W 31-0	230	0	70.8
S. Illinois (FCS)	W 34-17	101	-1	54.4
USC	L 17-33	-103	-3	21.0
NOTRE DAME	L 30-56	-156	-1	11.6
ILLINOIS	L 27-43	-54	-2	25.0
MINNESOTA	L 20-27	194	-3	48.5
N'WESTERN	L 0-19	-59	-1	20.2
RUTGERS	L 24-27	-198	0	26.9
MICHIGAN	L 16-21	-122	1	36.0
OHIO ST	L 10-34	-287	0	8.2
WASHINGTON	L 13-49	-239	0	5.0
INDIANA	L 3-56	-266	-2	0.4
OVERALL: 67th / 68 BIGTEN: 18th / 18 27.3				

They outgained Minnesota by 200+ yards but threw a late Pick Six that flipped the game to a loss. Then they blew a 24-21 lead with four minutes left allowing two late Rutgers field goals. Those were competitive, but the season ended with a very uncompetitive 56-3 Bucket Game loss to bring the two-year combined score to Indiana 122, Purdue 3.

For the first time since 1920-21, Purdue went winless in Big Ten play in consecutive seasons.

Odom went transfer-heavy again this cycle and Purdue signed the #10 class in the Big Ten. Combined with the recruiting class, they are pumping another round of 55 new players into the program. To notch some league wins and return to bowl season, they will need a better hit rate than last cycle, find some playmakers, and hope for a significant second-year bonus.

OFFENSE

Purdue averaged just 18.8 points per game, and that was somehow an improvement over the 2024 disaster. Injuries made the situation worse, as their top receiver, top tight end, and top running back played a combined 12 games.

Just two starters return from last year, and while virtually every position is up for grabs in fall camp, Odom made it clear that one is settled. Ryan Browne returns after starting all 12 games – the first Purdue quarterback to accomplish that since David Blough in 2016 – and despite throwing more picks than touchdowns, Odom gave his full endorsement: “I want to say, from as high of a mountain top as I can be on, I believe in Ryan Browne.”

His first six games were noticeably better than his final six, perhaps due to a shoulder injury he took in the seventh game. Browne has flashed his speed and athleticism but posted a low 59% completion rate and ranked *dead last* on the Big Ten QB Rating leaderboard.

Top receiver De’Nylon Morrisette missed the whole season, All-Big Ten Max Klare transferred to Ohio State, and then tight end George Burhenn only played in four games. This was an ineffective group of pass-catchers that lacked explosiveness and was plagued by dropped balls, and Purdue has lacked a true game-changing receiver since Charlie Jones in 2022.

The four-man rotation is gone, Morrisette is due back from injury, and the staff signed a new group of transfers. Bisi Owens (Penn) earned All-Ivy honors, Asaad Waseem (Florida Atlantic) caught 66 balls for 699 yards last year, and Xavier Townsend was a rotational receiver at Iowa State and UCF. Burhenn is also expected back, and will be joined by Kylan Fox who was UCF’s second tight end last year.

Devin Mockabee graduates after becoming the first Purdue running back to lead the team in rushing four straight seasons. His final year was cut short with an injury but he still finished fourth on the all-time rushing leaderboard here with 2,987 yards. The staff signed a thunder/lightning

PURDUE	UNIT RANKS	
BIG TEN RANK NATIONAL (of 18) TOP 15		
QUARTERBACK	16	
RUNNING BACKS	18	
RECEIVERS & TE	18	
OFFENSIVE LINE	15	
DEFENSIVE LINE	18	
LINEBACKERS	17	
DEFENSIVE BACKS	16	

PURDUE	RANK	
Scoring Offense	18.8 ppg	122
Points per Play	0.29	123
Total Offense	344 ypg	102
Yards per Play	5.3	101
Rushing Offense	126 ypg	103
Yards per Carry	4.0	92
O-Line Run Push	4.0	97
Explosive Rush	4.7	93
Passing Offense	217 ypg	81
Yards / Attempt	6.4	114
QB Rating	119	117
TD / INT Ratio	1.2	115
Sacks / Attempt	5%	31
Explosive Pass	5.1	121
Return. Production	61%	40
Returning Snaps	9,800	64
24.9 SECONDS/PLAY #15 of 68 P4		
HENSON (2025 PURDUE)	FAST	

PURDUE									
OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)									
O	48	58	32	39	27	30	44	11	30
F									41st
F	HENSON	HARRELL			BRIAN BROHM			MALONE	
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017
D	SCHERER	KANE	ENGLISH	LAMBERT	DIACO		NICK HOLT		ELS
E	65	68	58	64	41	45	60	59	24
F									66th

PURDUE		RANK
Scoring Defense	31.8 ppg	117
Points per Play	0.49	124
Total Defense	424 ypg	120
Yards per Play	6.6	133
3rd Down Conv%	43%	112
Rushing Defense	182 ypg	112
Yards per Carry	4.7	107
Negative Play %	8%	67
Explosive Rush	7.4	99
Passing Defense	242 ypg	111
Yards / Attempt	9.3	134
QB Rating	156	129
Completion %	64.7%	108
Explosive Pass	9.9	135
Return. Production	55%	58
Returning Snaps	11,440	49

PURDUE		RANK / 68
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play		
Offense Overall		48
Rushing Offense	0.0	43
Passing Offense	(8.2)	56
Defense Overall		65
Rushing Defense	(0.2)	55
Passing Defense	(18.4)	65

Mani Powell graduated with Big Ten honors, another starter Alex Sanford left for Pittsburgh, but Charles Correa is a hard-hitter and Tom Dienhart of *Gold & Black* calls him “an ultimate warrior, the heartbeat of the defense.”

Two more Big Ten transfers round out the projected trio at linebacker with Jojo Hayden (Illinois) and former four-star Anthony Specia (Penn State).

Last cycle, the staff pumped veteran transfers into the secondary and the strategy did not pay off. Not only were the yardage stats bad, this group couldn’t grab takeaways – four interceptions was a Big Ten low. A corner and the top three safeties are gone, but the staff was able to retain starting corner Hudaury Hines and nickel Smiley Bradford. Mister Clark (FIU) was an All-CUSA first-teamer and Don Saunders (Utah) brings a 6’4 frame at corner. Jaden Mangham was an All-Big Ten honorable mention safety at Michigan State in 2023 before a limited role at Michigan the past two years.

OUTLOOK

Purdue went winless in league play and ranked last in the Big Ten in my Game Grader. They head into a second rebuilding year and bowl season still seems out of reach.

PURDUE		RANK / 68
All-Time Wins	644	48
All-Time Win %	0.510	55
Wins (Last 100)	509	55
Wins (Last 50)	258	58
Wins (Last 25)	128	62
Wins (Last 10)	46	65
Wins (Last 5)	24	65
Game Grader (10 yr)	40.2	61
Game Grader (5 yr)	38.1	62
Game Grader (3 yr)	27.1	67
Draft Picks s' 2000	58	42
Draft Picks s' 2010	26	54
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		40
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		51

duo in Jerrick Gibson (Texas) and return ace Travis Terrell (Jackson State), plus Fame Ijeboi (Minnesota) who got a big freshman workload last year.

The offensive line cut their sack number in half, from a 10% sack rate (#116) to 5% (#31) in 2025. The group struggled to create a consistent run push, and it is a complete rebuild after two starters graduated and another two transferred out to Power 4 programs.

Joey Tanona is the anchor at left tackle that new line coach Zach Crabtree will build around. In spring the starting line featured three incoming Power 4 transfers in center Boaz Stanley (South Carolina), right guard Micah Banuelos (USC), and right tackle Nuku Mafi (Oklahoma State). All three were rated three-star transfers though they all started games last year. Former Top250 recruit and UGA transfer Marques Easley is projected to start at left guard.

DEFENSE

Purdue finished 65th of 68 Power 4 in my opponent-adjusted defense stat, and in the national bottom five in yards/play (#133) and yards/pass attempt (#134). Odom fired coordinator Mike Scherer and surprisingly brought back Kevin Kane who was in charge of the Purdue defense during the Ryan Walters era 2023-24.

For as bad as the 2025 defense struggled, Kane’s 2024 unit was statistically worse. They allowed 40 points/game and ranked last in the Big Ten in all major categories. Not exactly a “splash hire” for the fans to get excited about.

Three starters left for other Power 4 programs and just three starters return for 2026.

The interior line was a relative bright spot but starters Demeco Kennedy (Louisville) and big nose tackle Chops Harkless (Kentucky) both transferred out. TJ Lindsey is recovering from an ACL tear and is joined by Big Ten veteran Curt Neal (Illinois).

The ends failed to generate pass rush without bringing extra backers via blitz packages. Their top guy CJ Nunnally graduated and he had more sacks than the rest of the room combined. Breeon Ishmail and CJ Madden are experienced ends and the staff signed Elo MODOZIE, their lone four-star transfer, who was stuck in a crowded Georgia room after excelling at Army before that.

PURDUE	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 4	INDIANA ST (FCS)
S. 12	WAKE FOREST
S. 19	@ UCLA
S. 26	NOTRE DAME
O. 3	@ Illinois
O. 10	MINNESOTA
O. 16	WASHINGTON
O. 24	--- BYE ---
O. 31	@ Penn State
N. 7	MARYLAND
N. 14	@ Iowa
N. 21	WISCONSIN
N. 28	@ Indiana

PURDUE				GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)						
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR
27.3 (67)	13.9 (68)	40 (50)	48.2 (44)	60.9 (20)	40.8 (49)	38.6 (51)	52.8 (31)	56.2 (29)	23.8 (65)	40.2 (61)

